VIDEO ART THEORY

A COMPARATIVE APPROACH

HELEN WESTGEEST



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Introduction

It is hard to imagine a world today without cameras, which for widely divergent reasons record all sorts of events and activities, and without screens or monitors on which these recordings are presented. This camera-based culture has meanwhile pervaded the world of art as well. Most exhibitions of contemporary art will feature artworks that consist of moving images, a form of art to which we refer as "video art." As a result of the ubiquitous presence of images in our daily life and culture, we almost forget to interrogate critically how moving images mediate the world they present to us and what the consequences are for the contents of the visual communication involved. Fortunately, in recent decades artists have provided us with an array of video artworks, which aim at critically interrogating not only the visual language of video, but also the common language of television, photography, and cinema that surrounds us on a daily basis. Furthermore, some video artworks reflect on the relationships with other artistic visual media, such as painting and spatial arts. These concerns have turned video art into a highly fascinating topic for theoretical reflection on questions and issues associated with visual mediation in today's world. This volume aims to contribute to our understanding of video not only as a significant medium in contemporary art but also in the larger context of the visual mediations that all of us increasingly encounter in daily life. This second concern is pursued indirectly by investigating critical reflections on visual media in the video artworks that will serve as basis for a discussion of the relevant theoretical issues involved.

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Key characteristics of video art

Authors on video art agree that video is a most difficult medium to define. Although it is a young medium that came into being only half a century ago, it underwent drastic technical changes already. Contemporary digital video is a quite different proposition from video in the late 1960s, when the first portable black-and-white reel-to-reel systems were introduced. Moreover, contrary to Marshall McLuhan's famous insight that a new medium at first looks like a familiar medium before it develops its own specificity, video has continued to challenge other visual media by experimenting with and pushing the boundaries among them.

Nevertheless, some characteristics of video are still and quite constantly mentioned by specialists, although they may use slightly different terms. Yvonne Spielmann, in *Video: The Reflexive Medium*, has described several major characteristics of video, including these three: video is an electronic medium, video signals are generated inside a camera and can circulate between recording and reproduction equipment (closed circuit), and the recordings can be variously modified by processors and keyers (2008 [2005], 1). In her more recent essay "The Visual Flow: Fixity and Transformation in Photo- and Videographic Imagery," Spielmann in particular stresses that video has transformed the notion of an "art object" into something fluid and changeable, turning processuality and transformativity into its medium-specific features (2013, 106–107). Her characterization of video is closely related to that of Philippe Dubois, who in his *La question vidéo* defines video not as an object, but as an experimental condition (*état expérimental*) that instead of providing answers gives rise to questions and pondering (2011, 8). As he stresses, video is not just immaterial in a double sense (both in recording and projecting, as is true of film), but the image has even dissolved, turning video into a process only, one that is quite similar in a way to the wind (71–73). Moreover, as Dubois notes, other artistic media can be conceived in terms of an activity and a product, or a noun and a verb (as in "a painting" and "to paint"), but video is rather a means of communication (79, 81).

It is possible to sum up the most often mentioned features of video as a technology as follows (based on Berghaus 2005, 183):

- Electronic (magnetic) recording.
- Immediate live feedback: the recording and playback of the image occur simultaneously.
- Continuous flow of electromagnetic signals (as opposed to individually framed images on celluloid film).

- The monitor is a picture and light source in one (as opposed to the projected celluloid image that is reflected from the film screen, even though many videos are also projected by beamers).
- (Increasing) possibilities for image transformation and manipulation in the recording or post-production process.
- Storage of images on inexpensive cassettes, chips, or drives that can be erased and reused.
- Images can be read as electronic signals and transmitted via cable for long-distance broadcasts.
- Simplicity and flexibility of the portable video cameras has rendered recording crews and operators superfluous (individual work replaces team work).

On a more detailed level, Stephen Partridge explains in "Video: Incorporeal, Incorporated" (2006) that originally video referred to an electrical analog waveform produced by scanning the light (the latent image) focused onto a photosensitive plate in the video camera that is subsequently re-created into the pattern (or raster) of horizontal scanning lines made by an electron beam onto the photosensitive surface of a cathode-ray-tube, and this in turn creates the image that appears on a monitor. This waveform in the digital domain is now essentially bit-mapped or sampled to appear on a contemporary TV set, computer screen, or flat display panel. Partridge adds to this characterization that from the start video was a bastard medium that inherited a collection of conventions and properties from earlier media including radio, theater, and, to a lesser extent, film (in Hatfield 2006, 181).

Video's relationship with earlier audio-visual media is particularly addressed in publications dealing with video from the pre-digital age. Roy Armes, for instance, in *On Video*, argues that an understanding of video demands that it be seen within the whole spectrum of nineteenth- and twentieth-century audio, visual, and audio-visual media, including radio and photography, the gramophone, and the tape recorder (1988, 1). At one level, video is merely a neutral recording device, with little more evident scope for creativity than a copying machine. It can record and reproduce the systems developed within the film industry and the broadcasting institutions to depict reality and to create meaningful combinations of sounds and images.

The digitization of video quite radically changed the technical characteristics of the medium, rendering obsolete one of the most striking characteristics of video as magnetic tape and flow of scanlines. Regarding

the differences between analog and digital stages of the lens-based media (photography, film, and video), Mark B.N. Hansen, in *New Philosophy for New Media*, identified two equally problematic positions in the discourse on new media art: those who feel that digital media have changed everything and those who remain skeptical, wondering whether anything in new media is truly new (2006 [2004], 21). In this textbook I will pursue a balance between both extremes. If photography and film changed from a chemical into an electronic medium, which meant from visibility of images on film reel into invisible numeric codes, video changed from invisibility of images on electronic magnetic tape into invisibility of images in electronic numeric codes in chips. Video always needed a machine to make recordings visible. Digitization, however, has radically increased the possibilities of manipulation.

Some scholars, such as Yvonne Spielmann, consider the digitization of video merely as a step in its development. Spielmann stresses that although as an electronic medium video first rested on analog recording technology, it also established the essential features common to electronic digital media, such as transformativity. In this respect, the electronic principle of the processual image type has found a way forward in the more highly complex digital image type with unlimited possibilities (2008 [2005], 5). Digitization has probably brought lens-based media more closely together. Ming-Yuen S. Ma and Erika Suderburg, for instance, in the introduction to their anthology *Resolutions 3*, suggest that with the merging of multiple media production processes (video, film, photography, sound, interactive media, games) onto a single digital platform, some of the material differences that distinguished film and video are becoming less and less relevant to the study of contemporary media (2012, xx). In the form of moving image editing software and sound editing software, the digital platform facilitates the mixing of video and film footage in postproduction with increasing ease, as well as presentation of the completed work in a wide range of media, both digital and analog. As my argument in this textbook will demonstrate, the consequences of digitization for video art can be found in particular in the increasing diversity in the nature of video works. Digitization certainly also made it more difficult to decide which part of new media art has to be addressed in this book as digital video art. Rather than drawing a strict boundary, for each chapter I selected digital works for closer examination that well illustrate particular insights into the chapter's theme.

Regarding the efforts aimed at defining video art, Marc Mayer's quite exceptional characterization of video in "The Emergence of Video

Projection" is important as well (1996, 30). He observes an analogy to consciousness and, by extension, to being. Although the electro-chemical source of human consciousness has infinitely more complex ramifications in both nature or culture than a mere electro-magnetic mechanism, we have never come closer, according to Mayer in the mid-1990s, to creating a complete plastic surrogate of life than through the various elaborations on basic video art that we have seen over the last few years. Like man, video is entirely dependent upon a precarious life-support system for its existence, in its case, electronic circuitry and electricity.

Given that "video" is derived from the Latin "I see," the notion appears to ignore the sound aspect, but video originally was the shortened term for videotape-recording systems, distinguishing it from the audiotape recording. The two were not just technically closely related: video served as an addition to sound rather than as a replacement for it.

The training of art historians is geared to the analysis of pictures, and therefore many of them have tended to analyze video art primarily as pictures, if moving ones. Likewise, many early video artists were trained in the visual arts, and for this reason many of their video works do not contain sound, or only modestly. Today, video artworks rely as often on silence as on sound. Although this textbook gives priority to the visual aspects of video works, it also pays attention to sound from different perspectives. Chapter 1 discusses video art in the historical context of the sound of radio, television, and audiotape as early electronic audio (-visual) media. Chapter 2, which focuses on spatial characteristics of video art, also explores spatial features of sound. And Chapter 4, which is devoted to narrative and filmic conventions of video art, pays attention to the role of sound in dialog, voice-over, and voice-off.

Problem of general characterization of video art

The described multiformity of video explains why it is impossible to capture video or video art in a single, all-inclusive definition. The variety in the definitions that can be found in the literature about video art can be traced back to the specific focus of publications. As a result, some definitions, when applied to this volume's individual chapters, will fit better than others.

Recently, Lucas Hilderbrand characterized video art as defined by electronic signals and as being technology based, suggesting that there is some specificity but not one specificity. This would explain why some

authors prefer the term "media art" because the boundaries among video, film, and computer-based forms have become ever more blurred in the past decade or so (in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 2). I agree, though, with Katja Kwastek who in *Aesthetics of Interaction in Digital Art* argues that if we consider "media art" as an artistic category defined by technical or formal features, this implies that it is open to the common criticism that, generally speaking, "all art is media art, insofar as all art seeks to convey a message by means of a medium of some kind" (2013, 1).

Already in 1976 Davidson Gigliotti emphasized how hard it is to define video art, even if for other reasons. In his view, a single critical framework will not cover the whole practice of video art because of the wide variety of video artworks. As an example of this diversity he mentions the difference between videos that refer to the broadcast environment, and videos that do not. In addition, Gigliotti distinguishes interactive works (works predicated upon a direct relationship between camera, monitor, and viewer, and fully appreciable only by direct experience) from works that make no participatory demands (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 214).

Video's pluriformity itself has triggered a great variety of questions. Gregory Battcock, in the introduction to his anthology *New Artists' Video*, sums up several general questions to which video art gives rise: "What is video art? How does it differ from commercial television? Is video art linked to such traditional art forms as painting and sculpture? Is it a totally new phenomenon?" (1978, xiii). This list is followed by questions on aims of video artists, the kind of equipment needed, and on video art's first appearance and further development. As Battcock indicates, a large number of artists trained in visual media such as painting, sculpture, printmaking, and performance have turned to video. They have discovered ways in which the television format can complement their ideas and lead to new discoveries. Battcock suggests that in order to determine what video art is and what it is not, many writers and thinkers have found it useful to compare it to established art forms, as well as to the new forms that have appeared in the twentieth century. He predicts that those who bring with them a background in the fine arts will feel very much at home with this new medium. Similarly, those versed in other fields, such as psychology, sociology, cinema, and even the sciences, will find their expertise suitable for intelligent explorations within it. Thus practically anybody could work in video, according to Battcock, as it offers a fertile format for effective communication in all areas (xiv–xxi).

In an attempt to define video art in the same volume, David Ross characterizes it as "any artwork involving video tools," such as television

cameras, video sets, videotape recorders or projectors, and a variety of image processing devices. But he immediately adds to that the importance of the context. In his view, the term "video" might be applied to videotapes shown in the closed-circuit context of a museum, the commercial gallery, or a collector's home, while the same videotape shown through open-circuit transmission via broadcast or cable television is perhaps called television, purely as the result of the basic socioeconomic difference between the two (in Battcock 1978,141).

To an increasing extent, scholars and critics consider replacing "video art" with another, more appropriate term, but there is hardly any consensus about such alternative name. Some propose to integrate video art within the concept of "expanded cinema." Yet there seems to be hardly any consensus about the exact definition of "expanded cinema." Using this term rather than "video art" would only add to the confusion. Gene Youngblood, in his *Expanded Cinema* (1970), basically foresaw another form of spectatorship that can certainly be applied to video art: perceptually heightened synesthesia of new electronic technologies. This caused Youngblood to define expanded cinema as expanded consciousness. Apart from synaesthesia and intermediality, he also predicted in 1970 that in the future there would be a global public. After Youngblood some authors shifted the emphasis in the definition of expanded cinema to more spatial presentations of cinema. I will discuss some definitions of "expanded cinema" in Chapter 2.

In "Moving Image in the Gallery since the 1990s," Michael Newman has claimed that because today images are often shot in film, edited in digital, and then shown as DVD we have all reason to favor a more general notion such as "moving image" instead of film or video art. He defines the moving image as an art that implies both time and a spatial display in a gallery (in Comer 2009, 88). Not only Newman, but also Tanya Leighton as editor of *Art and the Moving Image* (2008) voiced a preference for the term "moving images" over video art. I do not share their enthusiasm for "moving image" because many video works cannot be sufficiently characterized by a focus on movement. Time passing by, after all, is not the same as movement.

Medium as a concept and the comparative and interdisciplinary approach of media

In this book, I will use the notion of medium mainly to refer to particular capabilities and conventions in mediation: with what means can or

usually do video artworks communicate their contents to the beholder? As such, the medium is part of the "visual strategy" of the artwork, but also relates to the expectations and experiences of the spectators. This approach to medium as a term partly relates to Rosalind Krauss's statement that the internal plurality of any given medium makes it impossible to think of medium as nothing more than its physical characteristics, and that particularly the heterogeneity of video demonstrates the end of this kind of medium-specificity (1999, 6, 31). In this respect, Jacques Rancière has reflected on the notion of medium in art theory in "What Medium Can Mean" (2011, 35–37). His starting point is that we understand the word medium as that which holds "between": between an idea and its realization and between a thing and its reproduction. The medium thus appears as an intermediary, as mediality, as the agent of an operation. He elaborates on the relationship between technology, the notion of art, and the formation of a milieu marked by a specific sensibility. The current volume does not so much focus on the role of the idea of art because video art as an artistic medium cannot be discussed independently from video as part of the mass media of communication, such as television. This implies that this book also deals with the notion of medium as defined – for instance by Henry Jenkins (2006, 8) – as both a technology that enables communication and a set of interconnected social and cultural practices that have grown up around that technology.

Both video and video art are called "medium" in this book. Video refers to the audio-visual medium in general, whereas video art indicates the use of video as artistic medium in the context of art, although sometimes "video" is used as shorthand in the latter case as well. Based on an inventory of the technological options and artistic conventions in mediation in video art in relationship with social and cultural practices throughout the five decades of its existence I selected four focal points. These concerns – which also relate to the most-often mentioned characteristics of video by scholars, critics, and artists – are based on how video art in its mediation deals with aspects of time, space, representation, and narrative. The flexibility of video as a medium becomes particularly clear in the range of applications: from a temporal angle video deals with immediacy and real time, but also with past and remembered time; from a spatial perspective video can apply three-dimensionality or its immateriality; from the vantage point of its contents it can represent a world not only as a sequence of moving images but also as static contemplative images; and from a concern for narrative, video can simultaneously appropriate and subvert conventional film stories.

My selection of these four focal points in part followed from comparative research of video art and other media. Most video works relate in one way or another to other media, testifying that each medium has increasingly become part of a larger cultural ensemble of media. The ongoing integration and convergence of different media especially applies to media in the contemporary visual arts and in contemporary culture at large. As Jay David Bolter and Richard Grusin have argued: "A medium in our culture can never operate in isolation, because it must enter into relationships of respect and rivalry with other media. ... we cannot even recognize the representational power of a medium except with reference to other media" (2000 [1999], 65). Yvonne Spielmann rightly stresses that from the beginning video has developed cross-medial characteristics, starting with interventions into television, while at the same time video had to defend its relative specificity (relative because of shared properties with television) against film and television as established media (2013, 107).

My comparative media approach implies among other things that I draw a connection between, on the one hand, how video artworks deal with time and comparative research of video in this respect with television, performance art, and home videos, and, on the other hand, how video deals with space and the analysis of video as a kind of spatial installation art and "projection medium." Furthermore, I discuss how video works represent their contents in relationship to how issues of representation play out in photography, drawing, and painting. Finally, I consider how experiments with narratives in video are related to the approach of video as cinema.

Importantly, the comparative media approach provides insights into the possibilities and characteristics of video as a medium, but also yields new perspectives on interrelated media such as television, film, spatial arts, photography, and painting. Another valuable feature of this approach, in particular given the virtual absence of theoretical literature about video art, is that it facilitates productive juxtaposition of debates on these interrelated media with the scarce discussions on the most prominent characteristics of video.

A focus on the concepts of time, space, representation, and narrative in relation to video requires an interdisciplinary theoretical framework, in part because these concepts have been profoundly investigated outside the fields of video art and art history. For example, media theorists have written countless publications about television and other mass media; visual and cultural studies offer reflections on representation theories;

the field of psychology provides interesting studies about people's compulsion to repetition; and questions on narrative in moving images are at the center of film studies. The application of views and theories from these various academic fields adds an extra interdisciplinary level to this book's interdisciplinary nature, which automatically results from the comparative media approach adopted. Ming-Yuen S. Ma and Erika Suderburg have noted that the discourse on video was interdisciplinary from its inception (2012, xxi). Already the first generation of video artists had diverse backgrounds in visual arts, dance, performance and body art, conceptual art, avant-garde music, counterculture, writing, political activism, and a plethora of other practices. Likewise, the first generation of critical writing on video has drawn from film theory, art criticism, poststructuralist theories, and other disciplines.

Although the argument in this book focuses on media, content and medium are always interrelated. A video about a subject is not the same as the subject itself. What changes when something is presented as a video? How does "being a video work" (rather than, for instance, a photograph, television show, or cinema) influence the meaning of a specific subject? Which aspects of the medium influence the interaction with the spectator? Insights into how videos mediate and generate meanings may give rise to a better understanding of how we deal with the world around us, and how the world deals with us.

Historiography of video art

Although this book does not aim to offer a historical survey of video art, it is impossible to ignore its relevant technical innovations, the changing cultural contexts in which video artworks are produced, and specific artistic developments in this art discipline. In the literature on developments in video art two approaches come to the fore. One approach highlights the distinction between early analog video art of the 1970s and contemporary digital video art from the early 1990s to the present (while in the intervening decade of the 1980s artists seemed to display less of an interest in video art). The other approach focuses on video art's continuous development since its inception in the 1960s by zooming in on parallel categories of video art that could be characterized, for instance, as critical response to television or cinema, as socio-political documentary, as spatial interaction with its spectator, as stressing the usage of a reproduction device, and as reflection on imaging. Although my discussion of major differences between the video works in Chapter 1 and

Chapter 4 seems in line with the first approach, my decision to combine discussion of early works and contemporary works in each chapter betrays my preference for the latter approach. Works by Johan Grimonprez and Keren Cytter, for instance, are discussed in both Chapter 1 and Chapter 4.

The organization of the chapters of this textbook makes it possible to discuss some relevant issues in a more or less historical, chronological order. This means that I will first concentrate on (1) connecting video's relationship with television to debates on the nature of video in the late 1960s and 1970s, and debates on technical developments in time-based media toward the present. This is followed by a discussion of (2) the concern with space in the presentation of video as projection in a space, often on multiple screens, which started in the 1970s and via debates on installation art continued into the present; (3) debates on video's common features with painting and photography, which mainly started with the digitization of photography and video in the late 1980s, and the subsequent introduction of flat LCD-screens; and (4) the relationship between video and cinema, which also grew more close after the digitization of both media and particularly since the 1990s when more video artists began to reflect on the tradition of cinema in their videos.

Even if I do not aim to offer a history of video art, a brief consideration of the discussion on its year and date of birth seems appropriate here. According to William Kaizen, Andy Warhol was the first well-known artist to acquire a video camera, in July 1965, presenting its first results that same summer, several months before video art pioneer Nam June Paik obtained his first video equipment in October 1965 (in Leighton 2008, 258–259). Yet according to Ken Hakuta, Paik already experimented with the Sony Portapak in 1962 or 1963 while living in Tokyo, being a friend of Nobuyuki Idei, an executive at Sony who later became its president. Paik took his Sony Portapak with him to New York when he moved there in 1964; on 4 October 1965 the first public presentation of his video work took place (in Hanhardt and Hakuta 2012, 20). In both versions 1965 can be considered the year of video art's entry into the public domain. However, some authors do not agree, for instance Wulf Herzogenrath who claims that video art was born in March 1963 in Wuppertal, Germany, with an exhibition of TV assemblages by Fluxus artists such as Wolf Vostell and Paik (1983, 26).

Regardless of which account is embraced, most authors agree that the availability of the video camera in the mid-1960s coincided with radical

changes in modern art as well as in society. Laura Cottingham emphasizes that in the years 1965–1975 video art took off simultaneously in the US, Germany, and Japan – the three nations that in that period emerged as dominant economic powers – albeit on a smaller scale in the latter two countries (in Ravenal 2002, 4).

Several critics have commented on the climate and circumstances that allowed video art to emerge. Marc Mayer emphasizes the major political changes that took place in particular in New York in 1965: at the height of the war against communist regimes, this city was the center of anti-war, civil rights, feminist, gay liberation, and minority rights movements (1996, 26). Hermine Freed has identified the mid-1960s in the arts as the period when pure formalism had run its course, when it became politically embarrassing to make objects (but ludicrous to make nothing), and when many artists were doing performance works but had nowhere to perform. At that time, when it became clear that television communicates more information to more people than any other medium, video proved to have several qualities that made it particularly useful for dealing with some of the difficult social and philosophical issues raised (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 210). An additional argument is brought in by Anja Osswald, who in *Sexy Lies in Videotapes* characterizes avant-garde artists in the mid-1960s as longing for more objectivity in artistic means; for them the video camera was just what they needed (2003, 9). Stuart Marshall, when commenting on the popularity of the video camera among social activists in "Video: From Art to Independence" (1985), suggests that for those excited by the radical potential of the Portapak camera it was easy to forget that "the development of this particular consumer commodity was underpinned by a vast investment in new commercial, military and managerial technology" (quoted by Armes 1988, 116).

As is true for any other medium, views also differ on the roots of video art. Some scholars argue that video art implicitly existed already in experiments of artists with TV sets and productions on broadcast television. Others are of the opinion that video art came into being as part of avant-garde filmmaking in the 1950s or even as far back as the 1920s. From a yet wider historical perspective, Marc Mayer has suggested that if we consider video primarily as a tool for mass communication, then it belongs to the sequence of innovations in mechanical reproduction that began in the 1840s, the formative years of photography (1996, 16).

As an artistic medium, video art is primarily rooted in art history of course. John G. Hanhardt proposes to discuss video art as a response to

two issues: its opposition to the dominant institution of commercial television and the art practices of an international constellation of artists during the late 1950s and early 1960s (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 71). Martha Rosler, however, in "Video: Shedding the Utopian Moment" (1985), situates video art practices mainly in the history of avant-garde art of the early twentieth century. In particular early video art, which involved acts of profound social criticism in the late 1960s, is related by Rosler to critical works by Dadaists, Expressionists, and Surrealists (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 31). The disruptive efforts by this avant-garde intended to provoke not just the art world but also that of everyday life (39). Moreover, these artists expressed a deep ambivalence toward the social power of science and technology, seeking to counter and destroy the institutionalization of art in the "machine society," and to merge art with everyday life. Although this attempt certainly failed, subsequent avant-gardes, in Rosler's view, including those that began to use or address television technology through video art, pursued similar objectives (46).

Classification and selection of video artworks

In an effort to put different video artworks into separate categories, authors have come up with various solutions. Already in 1976 Ira Schneider and Beryl Korot observed three basic approaches to the video image: video in which the artist/performer is subject; video in which the environment is subject; and video in which the abstract synthesized image is subject (1976, 3). Two years later, Gregory Battcock identified two categories of video artists: those producing videotapes and those producing so-called installation video (1978, xiv). Although in the four chapters of this book some more classifications by other authors will be mentioned in passing, classification of video art as such is not a major objective here.

The selection of key video artworks for this book was based on their quality as "theoretical positions" with respect to both reflection on their being a video work and their challenge of another visual medium. This makes it possible to present works by famous video artists and those by less well-known artists side by side. Regarding its geographical spread, my selection of video artworks largely follows this art form's historical development: examples of early video are mainly produced by American artists, whereas more contemporary video works are by artists from a variety of countries worldwide.

After having described the main issues and complexities of video art in the context of comparative media research, I develop this study's

central research concern: what insights can be provided by comparative media research into how video artworks "work"? In this investigation the comparative media approach consists of comparing quite diverse characteristics of video regarding time, space, representation, and narrative with characteristics of other media to which video works relate or on which they reflect. Given this context, the question of how video artworks "work" calls for a consideration of the implications of particular applications of video's characteristics and its references to other media for the construction of meanings.

The central focus of the first chapter pertains to insights provided by comparative research of video art – in relation to television, performance art, and home video – into video's complementary characteristics of immediacy and memorizing, and the consequences of particular applications for generating meanings. The second chapter's basic concern is how the comparison of video installations and particular views on spectatorship in installation art contribute to our understanding of video's complementary characteristics of immateriality and physical presence, and what the consequences are of the explicit usage of various spatial qualities in video art for the production of meanings. The third chapter focuses on how modes of representation in the selected video works relate and react to such modes in photography, painting, and drawing: how do views on representation implied in these various still media provide insights into the workings of video art? The last chapter mainly raises the issue of how specific insights about narrative theory from film studies can enhance our understanding of the video artworks discussed. Particularly the role of temporal aspects, the perceptual activity of the spectator in creating a narrative, and discussion on Hollywood conventions appear to be interesting for closer examination of strategies such as repetition in generating meanings in these video works.

Literature on video art

Most of the books available on video art present historical or thematic overviews of this medium or focus on the oeuvre of a specific video artist. Currently there is no study that is specifically devoted to theorizing the artistic medium video from the above-described perspectives. The kind of studies that come closest to this study, but which differ from it at the same time, are works devoted to video in general, focusing on technical aspects and socio-cultural functions of videos in society, and readers on

theories of moving images that usually consist of a variety of case studies by many authors.

Different from the field of photography, where almost every scholarly text refers to seminal publications such as Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida* or Walter Benjamin's two famous essays on photography, video art does not have such seminal sources. Rosalind Krauss's "Video: The Aesthetics of Narcissism" (1976/1978), one of the rare early critical essays on video art, is most quoted in texts on early video art.

The first substantial books on video art mainly dealt with video art in the US. For example, video artist Michael Shamberg, in *Guerrilla Television* (1971), paid attention in particular to the characteristics of the production process and the intentions of activist video artists with whom he is affiliated. Shamberg was also editor of the first issue of the magazine *Radical Software* in 1970. Ira Schneider and Beryl Korot, who were also involved in this magazine, edited in 1976 the first seminal anthology about video art, entitled *Video Art: An Anthology*. Video artists as well as critics and curators contributed to this volume, dealing with issues of which many are topical to this day. Two years later, in 1978, Gregory Battcock edited *New Artists' Video: A Critical Anthology*, which is a less ambitious compilation of texts on video art but which contains some interesting reflections on the medium. As response to the still rather limited critical discourse regarding video art by the end of the 1980s, Douglas Hall and Sally Jo Fifer collected critical writings on video art at that time, resulting in their anthology *Illuminating Video* (1990). It was structured along the following themes: Histories, Furniture/Sculpture/Architecture, Audience/Reception: Access/Control, Syntax and Genre, and Telling Stories. More critics than artists were involved in the project.

Sean Cubitt's emphasis on the cultural contexts of video (art) in *Timeshift: On Video Culture* (1991) and *Videography: Video Media as Art and Culture* (1993) added new perspectives to the field. Cubitt promotes reflection on video as video culture, a set of relations around the uses of video. In general he relates video either to the entertainment industries of radio and television or the technologies of surveillance. The anthology *Resolutions 2: Contemporary Video Practices* (1996), edited by Michael Renov and Erika Suderburg, continued in that same direction. Also David Joselit addressed video from a socio-cultural perspective in *Feedback: Television against Democracy* (2007), but he mainly focused on political issues. He proposed to think about television and video in terms of the categories of feedback, the viral, and the avatar.

By the end of the twentieth century several historical overviews of video art were published. Particularly Michael Rush has played an important role in this field with his *New Media in Late 20th-Century Art* (1999) and *Video Art* (2003). Chris Meigh-Andrews's *A History of Video Art: The Development of Form and Function* (2006) particularly focuses on the history of video installations. Different from Rush and Meigh-Andrews, Yvonne Spielmann contributed profound technological insights into the electronic medium video and its development from analog to digital in *Video: The Reflexive Medium* (2005). Calling video a reflexive medium means understanding it mainly as a process of immediate construction and reconstruction of signals.

After Hall and Fifer's seminal volume, one of the most substantial anthologies about video art was edited by Tanya Leighton in 2008. Strikingly, she chose the title *Art and the Moving Image* for her critical reader, rather than using the term video art. Moreover, the essays focus more on the relationship between video art, cinema and spectatorship than did the previous mentioned anthologies. The third and main part of the reader is entitled "From Cinema to Post-Cinema," following parts that discuss histories and revisions, and the agonistic relationship between video and television. Published as it was by the Tate Gallery in London, it is not surprising that the texts mainly aim to gain insights into the critical reception of moving images in the art world.

The authors and artists included in the volume *Art and the Moving Image* originate from a larger diversity of countries than earlier volumes on the topic. That diversity has increased further in the more recently published anthology *Resolutions 3: Global Networks of Video* (2012), edited by Ming-Yuen S. Ma and Erika Suderburg. The wide-ranging implications of video art and video-based production in contemporary media culture (such as the role of the medium in sociological research) are explored in this volume by an interdisciplinary team of authors. The editors emphasize in their introduction that video is now practiced and theorized in global spaces, and has become part of a global flow of capital, labor, and media.

Finally, as a conclusion of this brief overview of literature, a shift can be observed from discussions of video art in the context of art, television, and political activism in the 1970s toward, more recently, an interest in the context of media culture and expanded cinema. Evidence of this shift is film theorists' increasing interest in film/video installations, as in the case of, for instance, Raymond Bellour's *La Querelle des dispositifs: Cinéma – installations, expositions* (2012). Moreover, the geographical

focus shifted from the US toward a global perspective. The global perspective involves attention to socio-political issues that are no longer restricted to the Western world.

Although this textbook deals with various aspects of video art, many issues in this field are beyond the scope of the book and had to be ignored. For instance, this book is not a technological manual on how to make a video, so it does not focus on production; but aspects of production processes are addressed when they explain how video works deal with time, space, representation, or narrative. Moreover, the institutionalization (from video as institutional critique to institutionalized practice), reception, and distribution of video practices will not be addressed in this book; these are discussed in the anthologies *Art and the Moving Image* and *Resolutions 3*. This study hardly touches on these issues due to my focus on the video works themselves and their interaction with the spectator. As a result of this focus, the topical issue of conservation and restoration cannot be addressed here either, but Pip Laurenson's essay "Vulnerabilities and Contingencies in Film and Video Art" (in Comer 2009, 145–151) and *40yearsvideoart.de-Part 1: Digital Heritage* (2006), edited by Rudolf Frieling and Wulf Herzogenrath, offer interesting introductions in this field. Marita Sturken, in her essay "Paradox in the Evolution of an Art Form," claims that the problem of preserving videotapes is related not only to their short lifespan but also to the various formats that have changed so rapidly (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 102).

The above-mentioned publications mainly address the general public of museums and galleries of modern and contemporary art. Although my textbook primarily targets a scholarly, academic audience, it also seeks to appeal to a broader audience of educated readers. I hope to convince readers of the usefulness of the comparative approach of visual media on the basis of several selected focal points, as a way to gain insight into processes of visual mediation and the construction of meanings in video artworks and, indirectly, in the visual media we deal with in daily life. The integration of theory and practice is meant to contribute to a better understanding of video art and to stimulate critical engagement with it. In general, the book intends to contribute to "media literacy"– defined as the ability to analyze, evaluate, understand, and create media in a variety of forms – from the conviction that this is possible through an art historical perspective marked by an interdisciplinary focus.

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1

Immediacy versus Memory: *Video Art in Relation to Television, Performance Art, and Home Video*

Immediacy is the most often used term in descriptions of early video works. Many video artists have mentioned this characteristic in interviews to explain their preference for video as medium.[1] As video artist and scholar Stephen Partridge explains in "Video: Incorporeal, Incorporated" (2006), the virtual impossibility of editing with the early videotape recorder of the late 1960s drove artistic interest and experiment away from filmic conventions, such as montage, and toward the use of closed-circuit systems and instant playback. Accordingly, artists highlighted the new technology's intrinsic properties, such as immediacy, transmission, the "live," the closed-circuit, record-replay with time delay, feedback oddities, synthesizer manipulations, and synchronicity with sound. Some of these properties also mark video art in the new digital era, as Partridge underscores, but in particular synchronicity with sound does not. Sound is now recorded as a data stream separate from the image stream (in Hatfield 2006, 184). This chapter and the chapters that follow will establish that some of the characteristics of early video art can indeed still be observed in contemporary video art, but that some features changed significantly in the course of time, mainly as a direct result of new technological developments.

In comparisons of video with another medium, television is the one that figures most prominently. This is true in particular in essays that deal with video art from the pre-digital era, because the technology of analog video was in fact invented for the mass medium of television. Consequently,

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both could be defined as electronic media that can be transmitted directly or recorded on magnetic tape. This implies that immediacy was at first medium-specific for television, which was gradually introduced from the mid-1930s on. After the digitization of visual technologies, television and video became technically related more closely to photography and film. As this chapter will demonstrate, however, traces of their common roots can still be found in some contemporary video works.

If most authors stress video's technical similarities with analog television and its differences with film, video artist and scholar Chris Meigh-Andrews reminds us that we should not forget that in the early years of video many artists experimented with both video and film, and that they often did so in combination (2006, 81). Some of them recorded images on film and transferred the results to video, while others worked with video and transferred the results to film. Another common strategy was filming images off the television screen. Only gradually, toward the mid-1970s, did video art begin to forge a distinctive practice focusing on video's ability to provide instantaneous feedback. The frequently used notion of "instantaneousness" in this context has been put into perspective by new media theorist Sean Cubitt in his essay "Precepts for Digital Artwork," where he claims that "very, very fast is still not instantaneous," and that "the present should never be mistaken for its occupation by images of even the most recent past – the one twenty-fifth of a second required, for example, to build up an electron scan on a video monitor" (in Marchessault and Lord 2007, 308).

Regarding the perception of time in video art, video artist Davidson Gigliotti observed in the mid-1970s that when thinking of time in the everyday sense he is tempted to call it "real time." This notion, however, which is derived from computer terminology, is almost always used to mean an abstraction of everyday temporal experience. Real time occurs only when everyday temporal experience is translated into media (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 215–216). As a result, Gigliotti rightly decides to refer to real time only when he means mediated time – time as expressed in video. He considers real time to be a media model of everyday temporal experience. In addition, he introduces "compressed time" as a second media model of the subjective experience of memory, and a third mode of mediated time, which he calls "expanded time" and which he associates with subjective contemplation. The latter would be similar to the sort of time that we experience when viewing the sea or the stars above. What is "expanded" is our sense of the present moment. As an example he mentions the use of the video technique of delay

which has no programmatic beginning or end, no single point of focus, no narrative, and yet which engages a broad spectrum of our attention (216).

With regard to spectatorship, this chapter mainly concentrates on viewers' experiences of immediacy in video art and expectations based on watching television. Concerning the perception of video art as a new medium, in 1976 Robert Stearns – director of The Kitchen Center for Video – claimed that there is a sense of disorientation, due in part to the often highly personal nature of much video art, incongruous with the more familiar, formularized product of network television. Viewers experienced a sense of disturbance in particular in works that force themselves upon them by capitalizing not only on the personal but also on the repetitious and the self-reflexive. Stearns concludes that such works are often called boring because the artist, rather than seeking to manipulate the time he uses, points directly to it: by using time consciously, the artists intend to make the viewer conscious of it (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 160–161).

The central focus of this chapter pertains to insights provided by comparative research of video art – in relation to television, performance art, and home video – into video's complementary characteristics of immediacy and memorizing. This concern includes an inquiry of the consequences of explicit usage of immediacy or memorizing and references to these other media for the construction of meanings. The first section focuses on immediacy and continuous flow in video resulting from its being an electronic medium, in relation to television. In the second section I develop a connection between immediacy in video art and in performance art, putting the complex notion of "video performance" center-stage. Next, the third section discusses video's ability to record events to support our memory, while it also draws a comparison between documentary video artworks and home videos that document family life. The structure of the chapter's argument echoes the three essential areas for artistic use of video identified by art historian Wulf Herzogenrath in 1977: video as mirror (second section), video as documentary medium (third section) and video as electronic medium (first section) (in Davis 1977, 90). This chapter's theoretical framework relies on publications on video art, as well as on sources from several related disciplines: the first section in part draws on theories from television studies; in the second section I use art historical literature about performance art; and the last section relies on work by cultural theorists. But first I will address several

relevant issues for my argument in this chapter by way of two case studies, one from a relatively recent date, and a video artwork from the first generation.

Gillian Wearing's *Trauma* (2000) Juxtaposed to Joan Jonas's *Vertical Roll* (1972)

On a medium-sized monitor we hear a woman say from behind a mask: "It is not true that none of the mistakes in the world are made by psychiatrists who would never admit they were wrong." Next the voice informs us that a psychiatrist recommended her parents to send her to a boarding school, which happened to be a residential school for the maladjusted. There she became the target of bullying by the girls and the staff. This episode is one of the eight stories about traumatic experiences told by eight adults in British artist Gillian Wearing's video work *Trauma* (2000) (Figure 1.1). The speakers wear masks of children's faces to indicate the moment when the harrowing event took place.[2] Each video is presented on a monitor in the wall of a small room only suitable for private viewing. The close-up and central presentation of the speaker evoke associations with conventions of presentations on television.

Moreover, this video series reminds one of the history of video, specifically its use as a tool for documentation or remembrance and its application as a psychological device. Film theorist Michael Renov even defines a category within video as "video confessions." He relates this phenomenon to the organization of social life in Western society as identified by Michel Foucault in *The History of Sexuality* (1976). As Renov claims, our present society has become a singularly confessing society; in public contexts people are telling, with the greatest precision, whatever is most difficult to tell: "Western man has become a confessing animal" (Renov and Suderburg 1996, 80). Renov focuses on the therapy of self-examination in our confessional culture and the place we should give to video in this account, arguing for a uniquely charged linkage between "video" and "confession" in the current cultural environment. Based on Mimi White's *Tele-Advising: Therapeutic Discourse in American Television* (1992), Renov demonstrates how television programs not only borrow from psychological theory and clinical practice, but also construct new therapeutic relations, using the talk format of everyone confessing over and over again to everybody else: the camera has become



Figure 1.1 Gillian Wearing, *Trauma* (video still), 2000. Color video with sound, 30 minutes. © Gillian Wearing, courtesy Maureen Paley, London.



Figure 1.2 Joan Jonas, *Vertical Roll*, 1972. One-channel analog video, black-and-white, sound, 19:38 minutes. © Joan Jonas, courtesy Electronic Arts Intermix, New York.

the instrument of confession (81). Regarding the aesthetic domain, he relates this tendency to the age-old view of art as being capable of yielding "cathartic" effects for artists and audiences alike.

Moving from Wearing's *Trauma* to American artist Joan Jonas's video *Vertical Roll* (1972) involves not only bridging an interval of three decades, but also a change in socio-cultural context. How did Jonas, who belongs to the first generation of video artists, deal with the quite new medium of television at that time? Her *Vertical Roll* exaggerates the poor technological state of the electronic audio-visual medium of television in the early 1970s (Figure 1.2). The images shift bottom up over the screen, bounded by a black band – a disturbance familiar to television viewers, caused by disturbed simultaneity (de-synchronization) of receiver and sender frequency of the monitor. The video presents Jonas wearing an exotic theatrical dress, sometimes combined with a head mask. The staccato movements of the upward rolling images that present only fragments of

Jonas's body and face prevent a clear view of the event. As an "extra layer" of the video Jonas enters the screen, resulting in the vertical bar becoming the background for Jonas's new performance in the foreground, which consists of her tapping the screen that presents the vertical roll with a silver spoon, although slightly out-of-synch (Kathy O'Dell in Hall and Fifer 1990, 146). For her representation of the woman's body - in line with the feminist art of the 1970s - Jonas uses characteristics of the electronic media of video and television, as well as aspects of the artistic medium of performance art related to time, such as tedious, repetitive actions, which renders this work a quite suitable case study for my argument throughout this chapter.

Although *Trauma* and *Vertical Roll* are separated by a time span of three decades, both video works ask questions about how video deals with oppositions such as immediacy versus documentation/memory and the tension between public and private. Before addressing these opposite pairs, this chapter goes back to an important source of the videotape, the audiotape. Video is often discussed as a medium of moving images, but frequently – as underscored by the two case studies – sound figures prominently as a meaningful aspect of this medium as well.

Video Art Dealing with the Constant Movements of Audio-Visual Electronic Media, and the Immediacy and Socio-Cultural Aspects of Television

From television and audiotape to videotape: Dynamic images interwoven with sounds

More or less every historical overview of video art honors the Korean/American artist Nam June Paik as one of the founding fathers of this artistic medium. It is noteworthy that Paik started out as a musician who increasingly integrated electronic images in his electronic music performances. The emergence of video, then, does not just reflect a development from static to moving images. Developments in modern art, technological inventions in electronics and information transmission, and socio-cultural changes actually converge in this medium by the mid-1960s. After briefly introducing Paik's video works and preceding television works, this section discusses various technical roots of video as an electronic audio-visual medium and its development in order to provide



Figure 1.3 Nam June Paik, *TV Cello,* 1971. Video-television performance. © Ken Hakuta, courtesy Nam June Paik Estate.

insight into video's characteristic of immediacy and its application in the construction of meaning in several video artworks.

Nam June Paik's pioneering work in music Nam June Paik's *TV Cello* (1971) can be seen as the combined outcome of various important experiments he executed with music, audiotapes, broadcast images, television sets and video(tapes) (Figure 1.3). In this work, Paik transformed three stacked cathode-ray tubes (dismantled TV sets) into a "cello." When the cellist Charlotte Moorman played this "cello," she created a series of electronic sounds, transforming the TV sets into a musical instrument. The material displayed on the screens is based on closed-circuit recording of Moorman's performance, alternated with broadcast television feed.

The experiments that led to projects such as *TV Cello* date back to Paik's musical education in the late 1950s. Trained as a pianist, he studied history of music and art in Tokyo, and composition at the Freiburg Conservatory (Germany), where his interest in electronic music, magnetic audiotapes, and modern art was stimulated. Paik started to employ audiotape in the late 1950s as an attack on traditional musical instrumentation and compositional practices. He created audiotape recordings of himself, splicing together piano playing and screaming, bits of classical music, and sound effects. As a next step he introduced action into his

audio work and, subsequently, experiments with TV sets and transformations of broadcast images. His explorations into the workings of television and the application of magnets to distort television images paralleled his manipulations of sound on pre-recorded audiotape (Hanhardt 2000, 24).

The focus of Paik's attacks gradually shifted from traditional music to television. This new medium greatly fascinated him, but he regretted that it discouraged the creativity of its users. His changed ambition led him to create, in 1963, interactive television projects such as *Point of Light*. In this work, when the viewer of a radio pulse generator hooked up to a TV set would turn the radio's volume dial, the point of light in the center of the screen would become either larger or smaller (Hanhardt 2000, 35). In *Participation TV*, created in the same year, the spectator had to make sounds into a microphone placed before a TV set, thus causing bursts of abstract imagery to appear on the screen (127).

In this same period, Paik, while living in Tokyo, started experimenting with the Sony Portapak, the first portable video camera, given to him by Nobuyuki Idei, an executive at Sony. Paik took his Portapak with him to New York, where he moved in 1964, and where on 4 October 1965 the first public presentation of his video work occurred (Hanhardt and Hakuta 2012, 20). In this presentation Paik still relied on additional technology which belonged to the realm of television production (Spielmann 2008 [2005], 77). Although it would take another four to five years before consumers could buy videotapes, the first professional videotape recorder (VTR) had become available to television stations already in 1956. Manipulation of the videotaped images was only possible after Paik, together with the electro-engineer Shuya Abe, built a video synthesizer in 1969 at the WGBH-TV studio in Boston. Influenced by the development of audio synthesizers, the video synthesizer was an image-processing device that enabled artists to add color to monochrome video images and to degrade and distort broadcast signals (Meigh-Andrews 2006, 115–116). In this respect it is ironic, according to art historian David Joselit, that only by distorting the broadcast signal the material nature of its medium is made to appear (2007, 11).

Technical roots of both television and video As with many other media, scholars differ in their views on the origins of television and its next of kin, video. Because sound and image recording are interrelated in the audio-visual media, some authors discuss television as a further development of radio, and videotape as a follow-up of audiotape. Others refer back to even older media or processes of transmission of information in general.

Art critic David Antin, for instance, has argued that essentially television combines the photographic reproduction capacities of the camera, the motion capabilities of film, and the instantaneous transmission properties of the telephone (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 176).

According to new media theorist Jeremy Butler, television's predecessor and closest relative, in economic and technological terms, is radio – not film, literature, or theater (2007 [2002], 227). Economically, television networks replicated and often grew out of radio networks. Technologically, television broadcasting has always relied on much of the same equipment as radio broadcasting (microphones, transmitters, etc.). With these close ties to radio – a sound-only medium – it is almost inevitable that television's aesthetics would rely heavily on sound: the experience of watching television is equally an experience of listening to television. Likewise, film theorist Roy Armes, in his discussion of the basic characteristics of radio, stresses that radio has always been a speaker's medium, giving a key role to presenters, who link items and introduce records or outside broadcasts, and to storytellers who are able to devise ways of utilizing the essential intimacy of the medium so as to create a uniquely close link between the listener and an imaginary world (1988, 77). The central role of the stories told by the protagonists to the spectator in Gillian Wearing's video series *Trauma* reminds us of television's roots in radio.

In video art, one will find hardly any works that explicitly relate to radio, however. One of the interesting exceptions – aside from Paik's abovementioned *Point of Light* – is Mexican artist Rafael Lozano-Hemmer's 2003 project *Frequency and Volume*. In this work, the shadows of the bodies of visitors cut into a projection beam, which is tuned into a radio frequency. By moving around in the beam of light, visitors were able to scan the frequency spectrum, with the size of their bodies determining the volume of the sound. Lozano-Hemmer notes that the system could tune into a variety of signals, including air traffic control, cell phones, police dispatches, and so on: "The piece investigates the contested radio space in the context of the increased surveillance of the body as an antenna" (quoted by Holly Willis in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 107). Some other experiments of artists with radio are discussed by Heidi Grundmann in "Radio Art" (1989) (in Druckrey 1999, 90-100).

As observed by film theorist John Belton in his essay "Looking through Video: the Psychology of Video and Film," the name "video" (literally "I see") suggests – especially in its contrast to "audio" ("I hear") and "radio" ("I emit beams") – an image technology that exists in a linearly evolving chain of other image technologies. Television and video would

traditionally have been misperceived – by the average viewer, at least – as outgrowths of film. The two technologies, however, evolved separately, rather than successively. Historians trace the genealogy of cinema back to photography, photochemistry, and the phenomenon of so-called persistence of vision. Belton concludes that video is an extension of the late nineteenth-century inventions of the phonograph, the wireless telegraph, and radio (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 62–63). Butler also turns back to the late nineteenth century, but refers to the first experiments with creating and transmitting electronic images in Germany, such as Paul Nipkow's scanning system (2007 [2002], 257). The Russian scientist Boris Rosing was the first to develop an all-electronic system using the cathode ray tube (CRT), successfully transmitting an all-electronic picture by 1911. That video is considered an electronic picture next to the other electronic instruments at our disposal is particularly evident in Wolf Vostell's *Technological Happening Room* (1966). In a room this German artist, one of the founding fathers of European performance and television art, presented a large number of electronic instruments (television monitors, videotapes, telephones, radios, Xerox machines, record players, computers, an epidiascope, and a juke box) that were operated from a control desk. Visitors were bombarded by sounds and images from the networked media. Actions and reactions were recorded and played back to them, and in the course of the visit the relationship between object and subject became blurred: "passive" watching of images turned into "active" producing of images, thereby eliminating the gap between art and life.

Some authors, such as cultural critic Raymond Williams, have even searched for roots of the dynamic audio-visual media in the earlier nineteenth century, the era of the Industrial Revolution. Williams understood nineteenth-century systems of mobility and transfer in production and communication as responses within a phase of general social transformation. His 1974 *Television: Technology and Cultural Form* is considered a cornerstone of contemporary television criticism (e.g. by Butler 2007 [2002], 17). Especially the concept of "planned flow" that he coined to characterize television has been frequently applied by television scholars. If "flow" relates to the ongoing technical movements in television and video, Williams's definition of the term particularly deals with the sociocultural characteristics of television: "This phenomenon, of planned flow, is then perhaps the defining characteristic of broadcasting, simultaneously as a technology and as a cultural form" (Williams 1975 [1974], 86).

Technical characteristics of analog video and television and differences with film In a review of *The Video Show* in London's Serpentine Gallery for *Art & Artists* magazine in 1975, British video artist David Hall discussed the particularities of the video medium in contrast to those of film. He emphasized the fact that a video signal is transferred as a magnetic tape-based invisible stream, which is very different from the series of seemingly separate frames on a filmstrip. Rather than as a series of separate instants, one can only consider videotape as flow. In video there is a continuous flow of light onto the photo-conductive signal plate which is scanned and transposed onto tape (quoted in Meigh-Andrews 2006, 42). The production of images as a continuous flow links video to television. In this respect, David Antin proclaimed, in 1976, that it is with television that one has to begin to consider video, because "if anything has defined the formal and technical properties of the video medium, it is the television industry" (quoted in Joselit 2007, 37). This observation also explains why Hall's description of video images does not differ so much from Marshall McLuhan's description of the dynamics of television images in *Understanding Media*: "the TV image is not a still shot. It is not photo in any sense, but a ceaselessly forming contour of things limned by the scanning finger" (1964, 272). McLuhan – being one of the earliest major figures to theorize television in general – even characterized this technology in his enthusiasm as "our most recent and spectacular electric extension of our central nervous system." According to Nam June Paik, however, in his 1969 note "Versatile Color TV Synthesizer," the new technology still lacked human aspects, which is why he sought to humanize the electronic medium (in Rosebush 1974).

More recently, and in a far more objective tone than McLuhan, media theorist Yvonne Spielmann accounted for the technical characteristics of transmission and presence that video has in common with television (2008 [2005], 3). Her explanation of analog video also stresses the dynamic process of the forming of images. In a simple technical assembly with a camera and a monitor, she expounds, information carried by light is registered by the cathode ray and translated into video signals that are transmitted to a screen radiating the electronic signal. In these two processes of registering and reproducing, the electronic signal, which contains the video information, is continuously written in scanlines. Spielmann notes that this movement from left to right and from above to below corresponds to the writing and reading process in Western cultures. The dynamic involved results in an ongoing process of disappearing and becoming: each frame is radically incomplete. If on a TV

screen we used to look at partial images, this persisted after the shift from analog to digital: a single pixel or dot of visual information is conveyed every four-hundred-thousandths of a second in an unbroken chain of electronic scanning. Video images on television screens and monitors, in other words, continue to be in the process of their own realization (50).

In his essay "Video, Flows and Real Time" (2008), sociologist and philosopher Maurizio Lazzarato relates video's main characteristic of electromagnetic waves to the videotape *Passing Drama* (1991) by Greek/German artist Angela Melitopoulos, which deals with a drama of migration in South-East Europe. The deliberately inserted technical disturbances in this work render the electronic flows in it clearly visible, turning them into an echo of the involuntary movement of the deterritorialized, migrant proletariat. Based on this case study, Lazzarato concludes that "weaving, dissolving, and re-weaving flows ... is radical constructivism in politics as well as in the video image" (in Leighton 2008, 283, 285).

Television literally means "seeing from afar," spanning distances. This particular feature of electronic images, however, is at the expense of the quality of images in comparison to those of film, and although the quality of the electronic images has improved over the past decades, video and television continue to struggle with details and colors.[3] In *Video Art: An Anthology* (1976), various authors have addressed differences in quality in their comparison of video and film. Art critic Bruce Kurtz, for instance, emphasizes that film, with its twenty-four complete still frames per second, reflects an illusion of movement, while television, with its constantly changing configuration of dots of light, provides an illusion of stillness (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 235). Because of the poor resolution of the television image and the small size of the TV screen, David Antin suggests that most TV camera shots involve what would be considered close-ups in film (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 180).

Moreover, because it is hardly possible to engage the viewer's consciousness in details of television images, it became inevitable, according to video artist Ingrid Weigand, to speed up the action. For video artists, the image characteristics created certain conditions they could choose to exploit. Most video artists, for example, have rejected the use of fast image-pacing and developed the minimalized quality of the video image into an element of their aesthetic. In terms of their content, video artworks have tended to be simple, if not banal (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 281–282).

Spanning distances in video and television means that the visual component of the signal is designed to flow from one place to another. Chris Meigh-Andrews has described various forms of these flows in video art: from camera to transmitter to television receiver, or, in a closed-circuit system, from camera to video recorder to monitor, or directly from the camera to a monitor (2006, 233). If the camera is pointed directly at the monitor, this causes the picture signal to cycle in an endlessly repeating loop known as video feedback. In his essay "Space-time Dynamics in Video Feedback," scientist James Crutchfield provides a detailed study of the techniques and analysis of the physics behind the process of feedback. The camera converts the optical image on the monitor into an electronic signal, which is subsequently converted by the monitor into an image on its screen. Next, the image is electronically converted and again displayed on the monitor, and so on ad infinitum. The information thus flows in a single direction around the feedback loop (quoted in Meigh-Andrews 2006, 233). Numerous video artists, including Paik, have exploited the visual potential of video feedback.

Regarding television's characteristic of direct transmission, David Antin has argued that although by 1961 videotape recording had become commonplace (turning the true live production into a rarity limited largely to sports and special events), the live production on videotape that reached homes with a delay of a few hours or a few days was generally accepted as actual live television by the average viewer (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 177). As a result, the television audience did not only accept but even enjoyed a production error. This leniency on the part of the audience was caused by the increased feeling of spontaneity and immediacy created by minor crises. The industry wished, or felt obligated, to maintain the illusion of immediacy, which it defined as the feeling that what one sees on the television screen is living and actual reality, taking place at that very moment. The perfection of videotape made possible the careful manipulation and selective presentation of desirable "errors" and "minor crises" as marks of spontaneity, which became as equivocal in their implications, according to Antin, as the drips and blots of the Abstract Expressionist painters (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 177).

Alongside similar technical characteristics of transmission and recording of images, video and television also share the synchronicity of images and sound. Both Nam June Paik and Joan Jonas have experimented with synchronicity in the above-discussed video works, trying to realize various kinds of slightly asynchronous effects. In her essay "Bare Lives," art

historian Pamela M. Lee analyzes the encounter of Jonas in *Vertical Roll* with parts of her body on a television screen in out-of-sync frequencies: the vertical roll itself and the asynchronicity of striking with a spoon or with two blocks of wood. According to Lee, Jonas instrumentalizes the temporal delay between signals for both a representational and a structural effect, making the viewer aware that television presents distorted views by definition (in Leighton 2008**,** 156).

With regard to the process of fading as described by Lee as both a technical quality of video and the subject of Jonas's video (the continuously appearing and disappearing body of the artist), it is interesting at this stage to bring in Sean Cubitt's more general contemplation in *Timeshift: On Video Culture* about the relationship between, on the one hand, the constantly fading images of video as well as the fast fading electro-magnetic tapes, and, on the other, the author's fading from the work and the viewer's becoming (1991, 142). Contrary to film, which in Cubitt's view offers the illusion of being, which is why it can offer such strong models for identification, in video the images of characters are always in the process of fading away. If in life people constantly approach completion and in film they appear to exist completely, in video it is as if they existed completely just a moment before but that that moment has gone and they are in the process of dissolving, of losing their "reality." Similarly, the presence of the author in the work involves a constant fading. Although the video image and the magnetic sound are physical homologues of the events before the camera and microphone, they are different from it, at first only a little, during the moment of taping, but progressively more and more as time goes on. The author fades globally from the tape; in each viewing he or she re-emerges in the interstices between images, like a ghost in the unseen control track. In video, the creative process may still give rise to metaphors of birth, but the viewing seems to be far more like watching a small death. This process is counterbalanced in a way by the viewer's steady becoming, addressed in the fading as a becoming. Thus, the on-screen fading images stimulate the viewer to replace what progressively absents itself from the images (Cubitt 1991, 143).

I would like to finish this discussion of the technical characteristics of analog video and television by drawing attention to some early collaborations between artists and television studios, which underscore that both parties were keen on tapping the potential of video as a new electronic medium. The facilities at Boston's public television station WGBH can

even be considered as an important early influence on the development of video art in the USA. In the early 1960s, this station in fact encouraged experimentation, with technical staff working alongside innovative producers and directors. For instance, American artist Peter Campus made his video work *Three Transitions* at WGBH-TV while being artist-in-residence, and in 1969 Paik and Abe built their video synthesizer at that facility (Meigh-Andrews 2006, 215). In Germany, filmmaker Gerry Schum made two television productions in cooperation with Sender Freies Berlin and SWF for which artists created special films: *Land Art* (1969) and *Identifications* (1970).

What motivated artists to cooperate with television studios, which most of them will have considered part of the capitalist mass consumption society they strongly rejected? Video artist Hermine Freed, in her essay "Where Do We Come From? Where Are We? Where Are We Going?" (1976), underlined that communication is the purpose of art, after all, and that television had become a far more relevant medium for communication than canvas. Adding that people's sense of time had radically altered since the 1950s (due to the large-scale development of air travel, space travel, telephones, computers, and television), Freed suggested that this changed awareness became crucial to the importance and meaning of video art. In particular television would have contributed to such changed awareness of time and space: more information could be transmitted simultaneously to more people in more places about more people in more places via television than through any medium previously known. Freed also mentioned the attraction of simultaneity: anyone who has been in a television control room where several camera shots from the studio and several channels from other studios, on and off the airwaves, are monitored at once understands that sense of simultaneity in real time which is unique to video (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 211–212).

An interesting project that backs up Freed's argument is *Send/Receive Satellite Network*, which was executed in September 1977 by Liza Bear, Keith Sonnier, Willoughby Sharp, and several other artists. For this two-day project the artists set up a two-way satellite link between New York and San Francisco. Using a CTS satellite co-owned by NASA and the Canadian government, artists on either side of the country were able to cooperate in real time. Dancers, for instance, responded to each other's movements from opposite sides of the country. The resulting program was broadcasted to viewers on Manhattan Cable's public access channel. The project centered on questions about the implications of simultaneity and instant exposure and response. According to art historian Rachel



Figure 1.4 Keren Cytter, *Video Art Manual*, 2011. One-channel digital video, color, sound, 14 minutes. © Keren Cytter, courtesy of the artist and Pilar Corrias, London.

Wetzler, through *Send/Receive* the artists not only explored the artistic uses of satellite technologies and the nature of telecommunications as a medium, but they also began to articulate the political potential of artists' use of them.[4]

This section focused on the (early) debates about comparisons of television, video, and film as analog media. But one may wonder whether the arguments are still applicable after the digitization of these media. Some digital video works, such as Wearing's *Trauma*, ignore the shift from analog to digital because they deal with characteristics of television that were not influenced by digitization. Other recent video works, such as Israeli (and peripatetic) artist Keren Cytter's *Video Art Manual* (2011), apply the new possibilities of digital video, but also reflect on how digitization changed television (Figure 1.4). Television theorist John Ellis's essay "*Speed,* Film, and Television: Media Moving Apart" provides insights into how television has changed (1996, 107). This essay is part of the anthology *Big Picture, Small Screen: The Relations between Film and Television* (1996), edited by John Hill and Martin McLoone, in which the authors aim to demonstrate that in our digital age film and television are closer together than ever before. As such Ellis's argument serves as an interesting exception within this volume. In his view, the divergence of film and television is growing more marked with every new technological innovation. Both have profited from digital image technology, but each has used it differently. Cinema uses the new potential to make ever more realistic, yet impossible, images. Television uses it to make constantly changing collages of images. In doing so, television has

discovered a means of enhancing its particular social aesthetic. Thus, digital image manipulation allows television to combine images, while allowing cinema to continue to present a spectacle of reality (107).

Moreover, as Ellis argues, television has taken advantage of the "two-dimensional feel" of its screen, in comparison to that of cinema. By treating the television screen like a sheet of paper, by writing over images, by creating the feel of drawn images, and by presenting video images side by side or overlaid on each other, television exploits its graphic qualities rather than its photographic potential (108). As a result, television has found new uses for digital image technology, and this enhances its relationship with the present and the live (113). In this use of new graphics, television emphasizes again that it has no ambition of becoming cinema in the home. Television operates in a different way by being continuously available and providing a distinctive, speculative approach to events that are occurring at the same time as the TV broadcast is taking place. Different from entertainment cinema, television's fictions – from soaps and series dramas to made-for-television films – are entangled in a world of fact (116). In fact, Keren Cytter's *Video Art Manual* includes footage of television programs that confirm Ellis's collage-like characterization. The combination with fragments of staged actions evokes associations with zapping between television channels or surfing on the internet. This video deals with immediacy as an avalanche of actual information that can be misused through combining facts into scenarios that increase fear as means of power. In this work the concern is the fear of loss of electricity through solar activity. This observation invites closer examination of the socio-cultural aspects of television.

Socio-cultural aspects of television interrogated by video art

Video artworks do not only relate to television through common technical characteristics; some videos also respond to television as a socio-cultural medium. Artist Douglas Hall and new media theorist Sally Jo Fifer state in their introduction to the anthology *Illuminating Video* that before we can consider how video operates outside of the home, we need a better idea of what television means within the home (1990, 17). For a number of video artists, video is the language of television absorbed into the discourse of cultural critique: television turned against itself (19).

What could be called the language of television is open to changes. The television industry's cultural forms and genres, strategies, demographic models, and platforms of production and distribution have



Figure 1.5 Martha Rosler, *Semiotics of the Kitchen*, 1975. One-channel analog video, black-and-white, sound, 6:9 minutes. © Martha Rosler, courtesy of the artist, and Electronic Arts Intermix, New York.



Figure 1.6 Johan Grimonprez, *Double Take*, 2009. One-channel digital film novel, black-and-white, sound, 80 minutes. © Johan Grimonprez, courtesy of the artist.

been subject to frequent revision and modification. However, what has endured through these modifications, as observed by new media theorist Kenneth Rogers, is the fundamental idea of content monopoly. Simply put, the source of television's power and capital is located in its capacity to monopolize control over content at every level of production and to force this content to travel through the bottleneck of its distribution apparatus. In equal measure, according to Rogers, the overwhelming tendency of alternative video practice has been content based, albeit in a counter-hegemonic way (in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 41).

One of the most powerful strategies of television is its direct addressing of the viewer. New media theorist Paddy Scannell describes this feature in *Radio, Television and Modern Life* as the "discovery" of audiences (2002 [1996], 12–13). Scannell explains that broadcasting learned that it must approximate to the norms of ordinary, everyday, mundane conversation.

In talk-as-conversation participants treat each other as particular persons, not as a collective. So, too, with broadcasting: the hearable and seeable effect of radio and television is that one experiences being addressed by it. In looking at the speaker in Wearing's *Trauma* one feels addressed by her as described by Scannell (Figure 1.1). As stressed by David Joselit in *Feedback: Television against Democracy*, unlike film projection of a large-scale image, the small television screen in particular tends toward the kind of dramatic intimacy epitomized by the close-up (2007, 19). Allied herewith is the television programming that privileges individual modes of identification, which is essential to a consumer ethos premised on the efficacy and pleasure attributed to individual acts of consumption.

The central positioning of the speaker was also an effect of the "aspect ratio" of the television screen. After World War II, the television frame stabilized at a size of four units wide by three units high – the same dimensions as those of movie screens at the time. This proportion is also called 1.33 (4:3 = 1.33:1), the standard-definition television's aspect ratio. Originally, the elongation of the film frame was realized as a response to the perceived threat of television in the postwar decade. Film producers reasoned that theatrical films must give viewers something they cannot get from television. Thus in the 1950s, film studios attempted a variety of technological lures, such as widescreens of 2.35:1 and 2.55:1. Most of today's films have a 1.85 aspect ratio, and, after remaining stable for decades, television's aspect ratio also shifted toward an aspect ratio of 1.78, normally identified as 16 to 9 (Butler 2007 [2002], 181–182). Regardless of these changes, the format continued to be horizontal. The horizontal format of television, film, and computer screens has become so familiar that one almost forgets that the traditional genres of portrait painting and portrait photography relied on vertical formats. The 2012 traveling exhibition of Gillian Wearing's video works and photographs, in which vertical portrait photographs (mainly masked self-portraits) and horizontal portrait videos were presented side by side, made visitors aware that media and conventions of format tend to be closely interconnected.[5]

Television does not only feature monologues of speakers addressing the viewer, however. It presents its audience with, in the words of Raymond Williams, a "planned flow," implying an experience of an almost seamless abutting of a variety of genres: news, commercials, sports, sitcoms, talk shows, and so on. These genres are quite similar in some respects when it comes to capturing and holding the audience's attention; but they also have their own recognizable conventions, as shown by Jeremy Butler in

his systematic analysis of the characteristics of, for instance, newscasts, sports programs, game shows, reality television, music television, and commercials (2007 [2002]).

The images on the TV sets featured in Paik's *TV Cello* could be referred to as "music television," but needless to say they hardly look like regular music programs on 1970s' television. The "special effects," such as distortion of the images and abrupt changes, precede our contemporary "video-clips" on music channels. Within the limited scope of this volume, it is not possible to delve into an analysis of music videos, some of which seem to challenge the boundary between entertainment and art.[6] Rather than being interested in formal results, Paik, as other artist-participants of the Fluxus group in the 1960s, strove for integration of art into daily life, aiming to enrich people's lives through stimulating their creativity. This intention evoked a critical response, in particular by the American artist Martha Rosler. In her essay "Video: Shedding the Utopian Moment" (1985), she argues that Paik did not analyze television messages or effects, nor did he provide a counter-discourse based on rational exchange or make its technology available to others. In her view, he merely provided an upscale symphony of the most pervasive cultural entity of everyday life, without giving any conceptual or other means of coming to grips with it in anything other than a symbolically displaced form (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 45–46).

Rosler's critical statement is relevant for an analysis of her own video *Semiotics of the Kitchen* (1975) (Figure 1.5). Cultural theorist Anja Osswald associates this work with the preference of female artists in the 1970s for the medium of video. She rejects the oft-mentioned argument that these female artists liked this medium because it was not charged with the tradition of "male" art history, unlike most other artistic media (2012, 587). According to Osswald, video was attractive because it was related to the mass medium of television, one that produced identities and fixed (sexually defined) power relations – a major focus in semiotic investigations – and therefore a most suitable medium for interrogating these dominant systems of representation (587). In *Semiotics of the Kitchen*, Rosler initially presents herself in the clichéd role of a housewife hosting a cooking program on television. Soon it appears that her attributes are organized and presented according to a pseudo-scientific ordering. In an ironic tone accompanied by increasingly aggressive gestures, she alphabetically presents a series of kitchen implements (apron, bowl, chopper, and so on) and demonstrates their functions briefly by moving them around in her hands. In this way, Rosler can be said to turn

these familiar kitchen-related objects into domestic weapons. In "For an Art against the Mythology of Everyday Life" (1979), she claimed to see video in general as allowing her "the opportunity to do work that falls into a natural dialectic with TV itself," adding that in this particular video: "a woman in a bare-bones kitchen demonstrating some hand tools and replacing their domesticated 'meaning' with a lexicon of rage and frustration is an antipodean Julia Child" (2004, 7). This Julia Child, a major TV personality in the US, presented the first TV show on cooking and brought French cuisine to American kitchens.

In "Video: Shedding the Utopian Moment," Rosler reflected on the various ways artists attempt to use the main vernacular and popular medium of television. She discerns two groups: a surrealist-inspired effort aimed at developing a new poetry from this everyday "language" of television, which has led to narcissistic, self-referential video art, positioning the private against the public (a category of video art that will be discussed in the next section), and a group of artists who were more interested in information than in poetry, who were hardly concerned with spiritual transcendence, and who instead espoused an interest in social transformation (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 32). It is evident that Rosler does not only prefer the latter category, but that as an artist she herself also belongs in it. If *Semiotics of the Kitchen* reflects on the "cliché-information" provided about housewives in cooking programs, the almost obsessive repetition of quite similar actions also calls forth repetitions used in commercials and certain television shows. Regarding the use of repetition on TV and in video art, Sean Cubitt has argued in *Timeshift: On Video Culture* that this has the effect of producing anxiety (1991, 94). The difference is, however, that "advertisers (or more properly speaking, media buyers) use repetition as a way of getting campaigns to stick in our minds"; artists, however, use repetition to reveal the paranoia lurking beneath this recycling of ads.

Only three years after Rosler's kitchen-video, American artist Dara Birnbaum attacked representations of women in popular television shows such as *Wonder Woman*, also making use of repetitions in an almost obsessive way. Like Rosler, Birnbaum analyzes the mechanisms of mediating in television, but she appropriated cuts from these shows and edited them, mainly speeding them up. Her 1978 video work *Technology/ Transformation: Wonder Woman* was one of the first edited video artworks. The term "transformation" seems to have a double meaning here, referring both to the new technology that enabled the editing of video and the woman's "makeover" into a TV show super-heroine. Artist and critic Michael Rush emphasized that Birnbaum exposed in this video work how

in these kinds of television shows emotion is achieved through techniques and how manipulative this popular television imagery can be, engaging in this way the politics of television (2003, 27; 1999, 126).

Rosler's and Birnbaum's video works can be linked, in certain respects, to the postwar history of American television, as discussed in television theorist Lynn Spigel's study *Make Room for TV: Television and the Family Ideal in Postwar America* (1992). Rosler's and Birnbaum's videos date from three decades after the end of the war, but American television did not seem to have changed drastically in that period. What had changed was the dissemination of TV sets, which skyrocketed from about 0.2 per cent of American homes in 1946 to 85 per cent by 1959 (Hartley 1999, 90). As regards the role of women, Spigel argues that close-ups of beautiful women or scantily dressed bathing beauties emanated from the television screen, presenting themselves to male spectators, thus turning the TV set into the "other woman" in the home (1992, 120). Moreover, she concludes that the ideological harmony between technological utopias and housing utopias created a perfect nesting ground for television in the postwar years. Women's home magazines displayed television sets in living rooms with panoramic window views, and in 1948 *DuMont* advertised one of the first console models with the slogan "your new window on the world" (104–105).

Another television genre referred to in some video artworks is television news. David Hall imitated the format of television news in his videotape *This is a TV receiver* (1976). The videotape shows a well-known newsreader (Richard Baker) who describes the paradoxes of the real and imagined functions of the TV screen on which he appears. The next shot is a copy of the screen, followed by copies of copies, finally resulting in a serious degeneration of sound and image. Ultimately, only electronic snow is left, the raw material of any electronic medium. Hall clearly disrupted the viewers' expectations that were so powerfully shaped in the 1970s by broadcast television (Spielmann in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 138). Already in 1971 Hall, together with Scottish TV, produced his *TV Interruptions*, which consisted of short "interruptions" that appeared unannounced in between television programs, for instance presenting a tap that seemed to fill the TV set with water.

If Hall commented on the typical television phenomenon of the newsreader who had to emphasize the "liveness" of broadcast television in the 1970s, thirty years later the Dutch artist Arnout Mik critically reflected on the selection of visual reports of war in TV news shows in *Raw Footage* (2006). This two-channel video projection is a compilation of footage

from television journalists recording the Yugoslav Wars in Serbia, Croatia, and Bosnia. Mik bought this never-broadcast footage from Reuters. Without being informed about the source of the images, it is hard to tell whether one is watching a staged scene (as is true of most of Mik's other works) or not. The information that the unusual images of war were rejected by Reuters for that reason makes one aware of the prominent role of advance expectations, for instance when watching teams playfully filming each other in the midst of war (Spielmann in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 139–140). Mik's work reveals not only that daily life is part of war, but also that war becomes part of daily life, as reflected in particular in the shocking images of children playing with real weapons as toys.

It seems paradoxical that some studies stress the major role of television in private life at home, whereas others underscore its being a mass medium.[7] According to television scholar Allison Simmons, TV's intertwining of the traditional concepts of public and private partly explains the early enthusiasm about television: it involved the paradox that the private television viewing experience in one's living room was simultaneously a public event, shared with millions of others (in Davis and Simmons 1977, 7). The tension between TV's domestic role in private life and the collective experience of the outside world it offers has also been clearly present in television programs in general. Sitcoms, talk shows, commercials, cooking programs, and similar genres all come with the suggestion of the people on the screen being present in one's living room. Rosler's video *Semiotics of the Kitchen* underscores how much the image of housewives in their kitchen as a domain of private life is related to more general socio-cultural patterns.

Another aspect of the private-public tension of the medium of television is interrogated by Gillian Wearing in her video work *Trauma*, the preceding video work *Confess All on Video. Don't Worry, You Will Be In Disguise. Intrigued? Call Gillian ...* (1994), and her recent video work *Secrets and Lies* (2009). It is not always easy to understand why people like to confess secrets or tell about traumas on TV, as this implies bringing issues of private life into the public domain. In 1994, Wearing, being especially interested in internal struggles of common people, invited people in an advertisement to contact her. The many responses surprised her and some of the confessions she used for a sequel, using the text of the ad as title. To transform the public museum visit into a domestic TV watching experience, she presented these three video series in small cabinets in the traveling exhibition of her work in 2012.

Regarding the private-public paradox of television, it is interesting to address the use of the mask by Wearing in *Trauma* and Jonas in *Vertical Roll*. As cultural theorist René Berger submitted, the screen-mask plays a double role in primitive societies: it hides and it unveils. It can be considered as a screen between two worlds (the world of gods and the world of men); it is at once barrier and means of passage (in Davis and Simmons 1977, 217). Berger relates this function of the mask to the television screen: "... has not the television screen become for mass society the equivalent of what the mask was and is in primitive societies: an agent of mediation?" (218).

In addition to the tension between private and public that had to be bridged in television programs, the variety of genres had to be fused into a "planned flow": the format of sports programs, which should give the viewer the experience of sitting in the stands, differs from that of newscasts, commercials, and sitcoms. A closer look at the different genres demonstrates, however, that the differences between the genres are less evident and rather more complicated. Belgian artist Johan Grimonprez's *Double Take* (2009), which is often called a "film novel" rather than a video work, could be described as visual research into the manipulative strategies of various genres of television (Figure 1.6). His visual arguments confirm observations in recent publications of television scholars. Jeremy Butler, for instance, argues that the difference between newscasts and commercials is blurry (2007 [2002], 107). They both present evidence to the viewer that is designed to support an argument about, what he calls, "the historical world." In this regard, then, commercials could be considered "news" about products and services. He adds that television journalists would dispute this interpretation, asserting that anchors and reporters are not trying to sell the viewer anything. It could be argued, however, that to survive, a newscast must market its interpretation of the historical world as accurate and true. A newscast's vision of the world is sold directly through its promotional spots and indirectly through the arguments about the world that it expresses in its news reports. Cytter's *Video Art Manual* deals with this very characteristic, among other things. Grimonprez's visual research in *Double Take* goes even further, demonstrating similarities not only between news and commercials, but also between these and fiction programming.

Double Take contemplates, as does *Video Art Manual*, the role of media in the modern Western culture of distrust and fear: "Paranoia is turned into fear, and fear into a commodity" (Grimonprez in an interview with Mark Peranson 2011 [2009], 148). Grimonprez particularly investigates

the increasing influence of television on our understanding of current issues and recent history. He inserted stock footage from the period of the Cold War in *Double Take*, using the "space race" as a metaphor for the Cold War, and focused on clips from news shows which presented the "Kitchen Debate" between US vice-president Richard Nixon and Soviet premier Nikita Khrushchev in 1959 in Moscow, which was the first televised summit meeting. The newly invented Ampex color videotape recorded the historical event in a model kitchen at the American National Exhibition. These flashes are regularly interrupted by commercials for Folger's coffee, presenting a couple quarreling in the kitchen about the quality of the coffee, mirroring on a micro level the political quarrel on the macro level. Grimonprez's in-depth research in archives produced several curious results that he interspersed among the footage. One example reads: "Paris, August 18, 1900: Russian engineer Konstantin Persky coins the word 'television' after transmitting the first image." The various items are interconnected by statements from the famous filmmaker Alfred Hitchcock, selected from the hundreds of one-minute television statements he presented between 1955 and 1962, such as: "Television is like the American toaster, you push the button, and the same thing pops up every time" and, announcing the interrupting commercials: "those crazy commercials are pure poetry … [and] keep you from getting too engrossed in the story." In a comment on *Double Take*, Grimonprez stressed that this work is not only about the role of television in the 1960s: "The mainstream media doesn't correspond to the actual state of the world. We forget so easily that what was going on in the '60s is what's going on now … " (in Peranson 2011 [2009], 148).

The diversity of genres on television, investigated by Grimonprez and many television scholars, seems to make television very different from cinema, but television scholar John Hartley, in his *Uses of Television*, recalls that in the 1930s and 1940s, before the dissemination of television, the cinema audience was treated in a way that is much closer to the way television eventually came to be watched than to how we now watch cinema (1999, 57–58). The shows were a hybrid mixture of newsreel, comedy, reelers (10 or 20 minutes) with a full-length B-movie on offer, as well as the main feature film. The visitors did not necessarily know what was on in advance, nor did they queue up for a particular start time. Instead, people would drop in at any time (like switching on the television to see what is on) and sit through a repertoire program until the point where they began watching was repeated, when they could either leave or see it again. Interestingly, the latter aspect is similar

to how museum audiences nowadays have to deal with video art in exhibitions (for more on this, see the next chapters). This practice turns video artworks also into "video flows," in which you can step in at any moment and leave again whenever you want to.

To mark the transition from a focus on the relationship between video and television to one on the link between video and performance art, the subject of the next section, it is useful here to mention the 2001 television performance by the Mexican artist Ximena Cuevas (discussed by Kathy High in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 57–61). Cuevas was invited on the popular Mexican television show called "La Tombola" (The Raffle). Toward the end of the show, she exclaimed to the host that she was bored with this so-called entertainment. She pulled out a small Sony camcorder from her bag and started speaking directly to the television public. Looking straight into the television camera lens, she pointed her small video camera directly at the broadcast audience. Next, she suggested to the viewers that rather than taking an interest in her life, they should take an interest in their own lives. This dare to the viewers presented a break from typical one-way broadcasting.

In sum, the close relationship between television and video causes viewers to recognize in video artworks similar effects of (suggested) immediate transmission, such as direct addressing as "conversation partner," a tension between private and public, low technical quality and disturbances, and constant movement of images. This close relationship, however, also enables critical reflection on television through exaggeration of similar features or their inversion (such as boredom rather than acceleration, or a-synchronicity instead of synchronicity), prompting viewers' awareness of "how television works," by suggesting that video art uses these characteristics in alternative ways. The video artworks discussed here appear to make viewers realize in particular that the experience of immediate presence is an experience of mediated presence, rather than an experience of directly presented reality, as television seems to try to suggest to us.

The Appeal of Immediacy: Video in Performance Art and Performance in Video Art

It is important to realize that the immediacy of electronic images preceded the electronically taped images (both in case of television and video). The importance of live programming, rather than recorded



Figure 1.7 Vito Acconci, *Centers*, 1971. One-channel analog video, black-and-white, sound, 22:28 minutes. © Vito Acconci c/o Pictoright Amsterdam 2014. Courtesy Electronic Arts Intermix, New York.

telecasts, carried over from radio, whose programmers preferred live broadcasts to electrical transcriptions or recordings on acetate disks (Butler 2007 [2002], 258–259). Production manuals, such as *The TV Program: Its Writing, Direction, and Production* (1951), offered advice such as that television "should make the most of its frequently described power of 'immediacy,' which is its ability to transport the audience to the site of events taking place elsewhere at the same moment" (in Spigel 1992, 138).

This section concentrates on video's oft-mentioned characteristics such as live monitoring, instant playback, and continuous real-time recording. The diversity of applications of the medium of video in performance art is at the center of the present section, varying from integrating video in the performance to replacing the live event by video recording. All these so-called "video performances" are perfectly suited for comparative research of performance art and video art intending to provide insight into their particular characteristic of immediacy and its application in the construction of meanings. Video has also been used for its ability to document and consequently to memorize, an ability which performance as an ephemeral medium lacks. This application of video will be discussed at the end of the section as a stepping stone to my discussion of documentary video and home video.

Video performance defined as the use of video in performances

In the early 1970s quite a few artists – such as Carolee Schneemann, Valie Export, and Joan Jonas – integrated video cameras and recordings in their performances. Here, the immediacy of the live artistic performance before an audience was combined with the immediacy of video camera recording. In his essay "Videoperformance" (1976), artist and

curator Willoughby Sharp tackles the issue of the proper definition of the term "video performance," indicating that in the exhibition *Video Performance* on show in January 1974 at 112 Green Street Gallery in New York there was already confusion about the term among the invited artists (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 260). Vito Acconci argued that because of the nature of the show, its announcement as video performance, he wanted to combine video with something live, while Chris Burden created a work in which he could be seen only on the monitors. As Burden put it: "That is why it was a video performance ... I wanted them to accept it as TV reality, because people automatically believe what they see on the screen." Sharp notes that Burden makes an important distinction here: it was a video performance because the piece was visible only on video (265). The next subsection will deal with video performance in the latter definition.

In *Avant-garde Performance: Live Events and Electronic Technologies* (2005) theater and performance theorist Günter Berghaus continues to use the term "video performance" for both categories. One of the categories Berghaus defines as a stage action confronted with an electronically mediated image of the same event, both exhibited simultaneously to the audience (2005, 184). In this category, two separate, but interconnected, discourses take place at the same time, enabled by the instant-relay property of the video camera. The monitor displays sequences of images that are an objective refraction or a distorted manipulation of the live performance. The discourse of the body is combined with the discourse of the electronic medium. The juxtaposition of the two information systems allows the audience to compare and critically assess the two simultaneous presentations of an organic body and its artificial image.

An exemplary work in this category of video performance, also mentioned by Berghaus, is Joan Jonas's *Organic Honey's Visual Telepathy* (1972), the performance in which she first used the Portapak camera she had bought in Japan in 1970. As was true of all her other video performances, each presentation was a work in progress and differed from the previous presentation, so it is hard to describe what *Organic Honey's Visual Telepathy* exactly looked like. On the basis of various descriptions of this performance we may conclude that it consisted, in general, of a video monitor and camera (closed-circuit video) that occupied the center of the space of the gallery, and a large video projection screen that was placed to the side. The movements of four performers, including Jonas, across the space were recorded and instantly projected on both the monitor and the screen. On a second monitor another video work by Jonas was

presented. Jonas choreographed her live action partly in reaction to the projected images. Furthermore, a large mirror on wheels had been rolled in front of the audience. Its function was described by curator Chrissie Iles as "echoing the video imagery's juxtaposition of real and mediated space," suggesting a parallel between video and the mirror: "Just as the performers witness their actions live on the video screen, the audience can see themselves in their reflection … The real-time properties make this parallel possible" (in Schmidt 2000, 157). In relation to this work Jonas commented that video performance "offered the possibility of multiple simultaneous points of view. Performers and audience were both inside and outside," adding that she was interested in "the discrepancies between the performed activity and the constant duplicating, changing and altering of information in the video" (in Schmidt 2000, 108). In an interview with Joan Simon, Jonas explained that the title of the work was based on her experience of video as magical, which led her to imagine herself as an electronic sorceress, naming this alter ego Organic Honey (28).

Jonas used the video camera and the recordings as participants in her performances; some other artists used the video camera as an extension of their body. An interesting example is American artist Dan Graham's *TV Camera/Monitor Performance* (1970). For this video, Graham was lying on a stage at eye-level of a seated audience. A TV monitor was positioned to the rear of the audience, facing the middle of the stage. With his feet facing the audience Graham rolled from one edge of the stage to the other, holding a video camera constantly to his eye while pointing it at the monitor image. As a result, the monitor displayed an image of itself as seen by Graham and as continuously rotating. When the members of the audience looked to the rear at the monitor they perceived Graham's subjective view together with the audience that was positioned between the camera and the monitor. The beholders, however, could never see their own gaze directly, only the back of their own head among the frontal gaze of others (Graham 2013 [1979], 2). Graham used the feedback system of video in this and many other works as a sociopolitical device, an instrument that is part of a system of control, but that can also be applied to raise our awareness of the role of particular viewing positions. In his "Essay on Video, Architecture and Television" (1979), Graham focuses on video's characteristic of feedback, while stressing the difference with the more detached media of film and television on the one hand and the restricted qualities of the mirror on the other (as will be addressed in the next subsection).

Although the insertion of video recordings and video (or film) cameras in art performances has not been exceptional over the past four decades, far more often video (and 8/16mm film) replaced the public in what Günter Berghaus labeled the other category of video performances and in what Chris Burden defined as a video performance. What were the implications of this other role for video as a medium?

Video performance defined as substitute for a live event

Already in the early years of video as an artistic medium artists turned the camera onto themselves. The focus on their own body made this kind of video art differ from the works reflecting on the medium of television as discussed in the former section. David Antin notes that at first glance most artists' videos seem to be defined by the total absence of any features that define television, but this apparent lack of relation is in fact a very definite and predictable inverse relation (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 177). According to Antin, the most striking contrast with television is that it is commonplace to describe artists' videotapes as "boring" or "long." While this perceived quality would have little to do with the actual length of the tapes, it had everything to do with the attitude of the video artists (177). The performances that took place around the time just before the mid-1960s, in which the body of the artist played a central role and little happened, in particular preceded the look-alike video art. Consequently, to understand early video art in which artists put their body in the center of their work, it is necessary to consider briefly the performance art of the 1960s.

Art historian RoseLee Goldberg was one of the first scholars to investigate this art form profoundly. In 1979 she published *Performance: Live Art 1909 to the Present*, followed by a revised and expanded edition in 1988. In 1998 her new insights into the developments of performance art were published in *Performance: Live Art since the 60s*. With regard to the formative years of performance art, Goldberg states that in the early 1960s artists such as Carolee Schneemann, Yoko Ono, and Shigeko Kubota, among others, insisted on the body as the main locus of ideas about art (1998, 95). Provocative, disturbing, and elemental, their often nude performances in the artists' own lofts or alternative galleries were charged with meanings on both a visceral and intellectual level. On the one hand, viewers were transformed into voyeurs of the eroticism surrounding the performers. On the other, many viewers quickly understood the intended ironies of the various surprising and sometimes shocking gestures (95).

Acting before a public might evoke the impression that performance art was quite similar to theater, but Goldberg stresses that although one might call events such as the ones in the Judson Church in New York "new performance-art theater," they had nothing to do with even the most basic of theatrical concerns: there was no script, no text, no narrative, no director, and especially no actors. Instead, the focus was on movement, images, and time (64). Goldberg explains that the introduction of performance in art must be viewed against a background of a political and intellectual battle for cultural change in major cities across Europe, Japan, and the US. The performances were a response to a decade in which the traces of postwar trauma were slowly erased by expanding consumerism. These artists forced art into the domain of public confrontation (37).

As regards the wide availability of the Portapak hand-held video camera (since the late 1960s), Goldberg notes that performance artists such as Joan Jonas, Vito Acconci, and Bruce Nauman were interested in the immediacy of video, particularly the medium's real-time recording and immediate projection. Making a video or doing a performance involved similar, almost interchangeable processes (179–180). Moreover, Goldberg observed that artists such as Bruce Nauman and Paul McCarthy used video as a distancing device to record intensely private performances that were extremely strange and disturbing (180).

Even more than Goldberg, Berghaus stresses the relevance of immediacy in both performance art and new media in his *Avant-garde Performance* (2005). In a reflection on American artist Allan Kaprow's 1960s works, Berghaus summarizes the characteristics of "happenings" as identified by Kaprow in his 1966 *Assemblage, Environment and Happenings*: happenings are derived from life but are not exactly like it; the dividing line between them must be kept fluid; they must have much immediacy and physical presence; they do not work with a traditional dramaturgy of plot, dramatic development, or predetermined climaxes and endings; and the artist employs chance methods, which serve as basis for generating open-ended, life-like actions that make up the happening (2005, 87).

Next to the category of video performance, in which the use of video is integrated in a performance (as discussed in the previous subsection), Berghaus defines a category of video performance developed by artists who substituted the live events with electro-magnetic tapes. These performances had to be viewed on a video monitor (184).

American artist Vito Acconci's first videotape *Corrections* (1970) was commissioned for the first traveling video exhibition in America, called

Body Works. This video work is, in fact, strongly related to performances in which artists interact with video cameras and monitors before an audience. Acconci created *Corrections* by sitting in front of a TV monitor on which he could see what he was doing out of his sight. He repeatedly applied lighted kitchen matches to a small tuft of hair at the nape of his neck. The camera, mounted on a tripod, was pointed directly at the back of his head, so that the focal point, the burning clump of hair, was in the center of the screen. Explaining this work, he later wrote that he had searched for an action that could coincide with the feedback capacity: sitting in front of the monitor, having eyes in the back of his head (quoted by Sharp in Schneider and Korot 1976, 258).

Most of the recordings of performances specifically generated for the video camera, as Berghaus concludes, were processed, filtered, manipulated, and designed to establish an objectifying distance between performer and spectator (2005, 187). The physical reality of the body was turned into an electronic discourse that was specific to the video medium. Through the use of editing techniques the artist reworked the recorded material. The videotape became an autonomous creation in which the performance was subsumed without losing its intrinsically performative quality. Jonas's 1972 videotape *Vertical Roll*, introduced at the beginning of this chapter, perfectly fits this description. It is noteworthy that Jonas applied multiple uses of videotapes: the continuous tape of the closed-circuit, tape pre-recorded to be included in a performance, or videotape to stand on its own. She considered performances documented on tape as mere documents, in contrast to a performance recorded for a single channel video work that she "altered through special effects, change in camera angle, or working with and cutting back and forth with two cameras, inserting new material, parts cut out, and so on" (in Schmidt 2000, 106).

A more recent example of this category of video performance, which exploits the new options of digital video, is *Model 5* (1994–1996) by the Austrian duo Granular Synthesis (discussed by Spielmann in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 139). The duo's name refers to separating a video graphic recording into units of information and subsequently sampling and re-synthesizing them. In *Model 5* the previously recorded image and sound material of Japanese performer Akemi Takeya was broken down into its smallest elements and reassembled in another frequency. This causes the synchronicity and stability of the image and the sound to be dissolved: image and sound are separated, blurred, and perceived erratically as flickers. Surprisingly, this high-tech manipulation calls forth

Jonas's *Vertical Roll*, created more than twenty years earlier. In *Model 5*, however, the newly produced frequencies resulted in far more extreme deformations. The audience perceives the intervention as violent and painful because the artistic duo dissected the voice and portrait of Takeya. Her natural rhythm is eliminated and replaced by a mechanical rhythm in the sequence. In effect, a mathematical operation of digital analysis was applied to a video recording of Takeya's performance. Regarding works like these, Spielmann concludes that where the base video material stands for continuity in the performance, the digital editing of the live presentation is used to make us aware of the media level (139).

If this section might suggest that only artists produced what might be called video performances, a striking case from outside of the art world - the webcam recording by college student Jennifer Ringley of her daily life - proves that this is not always the case. Ringley started the recordings at a rate of one video still every three minutes in April 1996 and was online continuously (24/7) until she turned off the camera in 2003. Photography theorist and artist Victor Burgin reflects in "Jenni's Room: Exhibitionism and Solitude" on this phenomenon, which in newspapers was referred to as exhibitionism (2000, 80). Burgin claims that if one judges Ringley to be an exhibitionist one has done no more than acknowledge one's own voyeurism. He concludes that the camera seems to function as her companion, compensating for the absence of her mother as she just left the parental home. Burgin uses three metaphors for the video camera: from the perspective of the beholder of the JenniCam website, the camera is a window; from Ringley's position, her camera is either a mirror or an accompanying (maternal) eye (80, 87). Regarding the metaphor of the mirror, one should note that Ringley hardly looks at the lens as if it were a mirror. This is different from some early video art performances in which the lens of the camera is used as a mirror, prompting associations with narcissism rather than exhibitionism.

The immediate reflection of the mirror as metaphor for video Video performances presented on a monitor, particularly the early ones, most often show the artist in close-up due to the small size of TV sets. Moreover, the artist is often focusing on the camera. These characteristics are applicable to both Jonas's *Vertical Roll* and Acconci's *Centers* (Figure 1.7). We are familiar in daily life with looking close-up into a mirror at ourselves. It is not surprising, therefore, that this kind of video has been compared to looking into a mirror.

Rosalind Krauss has even observed a narcissist connotation in mirror-like videos in her groundbreaking 1976 essay on video art. This much criticized piece, entitled "Video: The Aesthetics of Narcissism," was first published in the art magazine *October*, and two years later it appeared in a slightly revised form in Gregory Battcock's anthology *New Artists' Video* (1978, 43–64). Krauss develops her argument about early 1970s' video art on the basis of an analysis of Acconci's video performance *Centers* (1971). She starts her essay arguing that symmetry in paintings of the 1960s allowed the artist to point to the center of the canvas to invoke the internal structure of the picture-object. She continues to ask what it means to point to the center of a television screen. In *Centers* Acconci faced the camera during the whole time of the recording (22'28") while pointing straight ahead at his own image, and while trying to keep his finger focused on the center of it. According to Krauss, *Centers* typifies the structural characteristics of the video medium because it was made by Acconci using the video monitor as a mirror (1978, 44). Although Krauss confuses the camera for the monitor here, her statement holds to make sense:

> what we see is a sustained tautology: a line of sight that begins at Acconci's plane of vision and ends at the eyes of his projected double. In that image of self-regard is configured a narcissism so endemic to works of video that I find myself wanting to generalize it as *the* condition of the entire genre. Yet, what would it mean to say "the medium of video is narcissism?" [italics in original] (44).

Krauss concludes by saying that her statement describes a psychological rather than a physical condition. Contrary to common definitions of media such as painting, which focus on physical characteristics such as canvas and paint, defining video on the basis of its psychological condition would mean a shift in thinking about media. Krauss puts forward that in everyday speech the word "medium" is not related to physical characteristics; and that particularly in a (para)psychological sense it is related to telepathy, extrasensory perception, and communication with an afterlife (45). In particular she relates her view to psychoanalyst Sigmund Freud's transformation from "object-libido" into "ego-libido," which is Freud's specific condition of narcissism (54). After inserting a reference to psychoanalyst Jacques Lacan's mirroring stages and constantly renewed status of alienation, she characterizes narcissism as the unchanging condition of a perpetual frustration (55).

Specifically regarding the relationship with the mirror, Krauss observes that video, like the mirror and unlike other visual arts, is capable of recording and transmitting at the same time, producing instant feedback. As a result, the performing artist is centered between two devices that function as the opening and closing of a parenthesis. One is the camera and the other the monitor, which re-projects the performer's image with the immediacy of a mirror (45).

Krauss's qualification of Acconci's *Centers* as narcissistic, and even representative in this characteristic of many other video works, asks the question whether this video work could also be interpreted from other perspectives related to the medium. According to Michael Rush, Acconci's pointing arm and finger cannot only be interpreted as referring to himself; the artist also points directly at the viewer, drawing the viewer into the art process (2003, 11). Acconci commented on his visual statement that the TV image turns the activity around: "a pointing away from myself, at an outside viewer – I end up widening my focus on to passing viewers (I'm looking straight out by looking straight in)" (quoted in Rush 2003, 11). Anja Osswald characterized this shift described by Acconci as transformation of pointing at the self into pointing at the public (2003, 65). In this respect, curator Tanya Leighton emphasizes that Acconci points to video's immediacy and how the "now-ness of communication" is both opened and foreclosed in television (2008, 23). Acconci would have urged viewers to consider their own reflections within the paradoxical contradiction of televisual "now-ness."

David Joselit likewise claims that artists such as Acconci in particular stage the fundamental struggle in a media world over possessing one's own image as property. How may television function as a public realm and how can an image act politically in that arena? Thus, in contradiction to the claim of Krauss, Joselit concludes that in exploring the struggles around the possession of one's own image (which are as firmly rooted in politics and economics as they are in psychology), the self's appearance is not narcissistic, but rather the initial moment in constituting a genuine public. In other words, rather than narcissism, it is the public that is the medium of video (in Douglas and Eamon 2009, 117–118).

Anja Osswald critically analyzed Krauss's famous essay in her 2001 dissertation on video performances, published as *Sexy Lies in Videotapes: Künstlerische Selbstinszenierung im Video um 1970* [Artistic Self-staging in Video around 1970] (2003). Praising Krauss's essay as one of the earliest attempts to ground video art theoretically as well as aesthetically, Osswald

criticizes it for neglecting an essential feature of video in the comparison of video with the mirror and the tautological circle of self-reflection (both splitting up and doubling the self) prompting the Narcissus metaphor. Unlike a regular mirror, the electronic mirror does not reflect images in a reversed way. As a result, the outside view plays a role, introducing the category of the viewing Other, rather than destroying the Other, as Krauss suggests in her argumentation (Osswald 2003, 64). This difference between video reflection and mirror reflection becomes crystal-clear in Joan Jonas's single-channel tape *Left Side Right Side* (1972). Jonas positioned herself between two cameras, one in front of her and the other behind her; she sat opposite both a monitor and a mirror placed side by side, so that her video reflection, which is "true," was paired with her reverse mirror image. During the opening sequence "this is my right eye . . . this is my left eye" she is pointing at her eyes one by one; the video continues to present variations on that theme. Joselit notes that this ostensibly simple situation becomes dazzlingly complex through various shifts that reveal components of the apparatus to the viewer: the monitor, mirror, performance space, or all at once (2007, 160).

In her essay "He Saw Her Burning" Jonas reflected more in general on her regular use of the mirror (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 367). She recalled that she did her first performance piece in 1968, and from the beginning the mirror provided her with a metaphor for investigations, as well as with a device to alter space, to fragment it, and to reflect the audience that was included by this reflection. The Portapak video camera enabled her to add another reflection, and to relate to the audience through close-up on the live transmission of the closed-circuit video system. By doing so, the monitor was turned into an ongoing (mirrored) mirror, so to speak.

The fact that the video images are not a mirrored reality means, according to Osswald, that the electronic "mirror" is rather the reflection of the self-reflection (2003, 29–30). This is what artists such as Acconci and Jonas actually do in this kind of video work: use the metaphor of the mirror or shadow as visual expression of differentiation, while simultaneously touching on the problem of split identity. In her dissertation research, Osswald profoundly analyzed the 1970s' video performances by Acconci and Jonas, arguing that these works share the impersonal character of self-representation of the artists. Strengthened by the anonymous-technological nature of the medium and limited size of monitor images, the video recordings look quite neutral and have a quasi-documentary style. Moreover, the word "self-portrait" is hardly used in titles of video performances; Osswald tended to find rather more descriptive titles. Such

observations led her to the conclusion that these works reduce the artist to an empty container; what is presented is the rhetorical artificiality of self-images (splitting, doubling, self as other) or the paradox of "self-less self-images." The medium of video was thereby used as a reflective medium in a double sense: as reflective mirror and as reflective medium for self-reflection that includes the observer as Other. Furthermore, the technical character of the medium, its reproducibility, and not least its relationship with the mass medium of television, put video at a great distance from media that make individual styles possible (65).

Krauss and Osswald appear to agree on the suitability of the medium of video as a psychological tool, but they disagree on the assumed narcissist nature of videos in which artists present their own body. Regarding these different views, it is interesting to bring in Hermine Freed's opinion, from an essay written in the same year as that of Krauss. As Freed argues, video artists use their own body mainly for a pragmatic reason. Artists rely on their own body because they have the firmest control over themselves; it is easier to do something the way you want it done yourself than to try to explain what you want to have done to someone else. Moreover, artists are accustomed to working alone. When artists use their own image, it is more likely they do so because of their need to work alone than because of narcissism (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 212). This interpretation of Freed is corroborated by Osswald when she quotes Bruce Nauman's answer to Joan Simon's question in an interview in 1988 as to why he applied paint on his face as a mask in his filmed performance *Art Make-up* (1967–1968): "To present yourself is obviously part of being an artist. If you don't want people to see that self, you put on make-up ... there is a kind of self-exposure that is threatening" (quoted in Osswald 2003, 31).

It is fair to say, however, that Krauss does not finish her essay by defining all video art as narcissism (1978, 57). At the very end the essay takes a positive shift by signaling three groups within the corpus of video art that run counter to her argument up to that point. The first category consists of tapes that exploit the medium in order to criticize it from within; the second group comprises tapes that represent an assault on the video system in order to break out of its psychological hold; and the third category involves installation forms of video, which use the medium as a subspecies of arts such as sculpture. Krauss's example of the first category is Richard Serra's *Boomerang*; she refers to the installation works by Peter Campus that involve the visitors as an example of the third category; and her example for the second category is Joan Jonas's *Vertical Roll*. Krauss observes in this work an enclosing of Jonas's body between two

apparatuses, as she saw in Acconci's work, yet not as a narcissist relationship in this case (59). Thus, in the end, Krauss and Osswald agree that in the early 1970s video artists expressed a fascination for the similarity in terms of immediacy of mirrors and video recordings, and in particular for the complex relationship between the two, which made video an interesting medium for "self-reflection" for artists and viewers alike.

To bring this comparison of video and the mirror to a close, a brief contemplation on the use of video as "delayed mirror" seems appropriate. In particular Dan Graham has experimented in various ways with this phenomenon. As he noted, mirrors are designed to be seen frontally, whereas the video monitor's projected image of a spectator observing it depends on the spectator's relation to the position of the camera – not on his or her relation to the monitor. This means that a view of the beholder can be transmitted from the camera instantaneously or time-delayed over a distance to a monitor, which may be near or far removed from the beholder's (viewing) position (Graham 2013 [1979], 67). In his essay on feedback in video, Graham included an illustration of a scientific experiment from R.L. Gregory's *Eye and Brain* (1966). It shows a man making a drawing out of his own sight by looking at a monitor on which he sees his hand drawing with a delay of a few seconds. Graham added that when a perceiver views his behavior via videotape on a five- to eight-second delay, which is the limit of "short-term" memory or memory which is part of and influencing a person's (present) perception, this immediately influences his future intentions and behavior (69).

Graham's most famous work dealing with delayed feedback is *Present Continuous Past(s)* (1974). So far in this chapter we have discussed performances that were all executed by the artists themselves (or in the case of Granular Synthesis by a colleague). Already in the 1970s, however, some artists had the visitors perform. In *Present Continuous Past(s)* the artist himself is absent from the video performance and unknowingly the visitors become the performers. The work consists of a white room with mirrored walls on two adjacent sides. A monitor and camera are mounted on the third, mirror-less wall, while the partial fourth wall marks the room's entrance. As the viewers enter the room, they are at first struck by the multiple mirror images of themselves. The monitor appears to mirror the space, yet without the viewers' image. Suddenly they see themselves entering the room on the monitor. Thus they see themselves first in the mirror, after which, eight seconds later, they see the mirrored actions relayed on the monitor. The discrepancy between the video image and

the mirror image operates on several levels, according to Hermine Freed. The video image is a "normal" one, you see yourself as others see you, but in time delay you see yourself objectified, in the same relationship to yourself as to anyone else in the room (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 212).

The starting point of this section was that immediacy in performance art relates to the direct interaction of "self-other" in the relationship of performer-audience. When video recording and projection are inserted this interaction becomes more complicated, and this is even more the case with the addition of a mirror that forces the visitor to compare the perception of the physical presence of the artist with the mirrored image and directly recorded and projected images that may include themselves. Video performances produced without the presence of an audience offer possibilities for artists to experiment with the immediacy of closed-circuit and feedback, which may well be seen as video's mirroring qualities, even if the images are not presented mirror-wise. The use of technical disturbances thereby draws attention to video's mediating role. In both categories of video performances, however, video's immediacy contributes to the viewer's awareness of self-other perceptions.

Video as documentation of performances

The paradox of performance art is that artists stress the importance of its ephemeral nature in their choice of this medium, but are searching at the same time for ways to document the events. Several documenting film/video recordings have even replaced the original event in becoming the actual work of art, to be collected and exhibited in museums, whereas others continue to be kept in (the artist's or collector's) archives as part of the documentation of the performance.

Curator Douglas Fogle has addressed the dilemma of performance art's documentation in his anthology *The Last Picture Show: Artists Using Photography 1960–1982* (2003), but he limited his research to photographic documentation. Only briefly does he touch on the main difference between photo camera recording and film or video camera recording: the important characteristic of duration (which can be extreme) gets lost in photo documentation. Art critic Nancy Foote considers this aspect an advantage: photographs allow the artist to eliminate duration and this safeguards spectators from the possible monotony of a film or videotape of the actual event (in Fogle 2003 [1976], 27).

Nevertheless, many performance artists have preferred film or video documentation, if often in addition to photo and text documents.

Peggy Phelan, scholar in performance studies, emphasizes in *Unmarked: The Politics of Performance* that performance cannot be saved, recorded, documented, or otherwise participate in the circulation of representations of representations: once it does so, it becomes something other than performance (1993, 146). She notes that the pressure of the reproductive economy is enormous: only rarely the "now" to which performances address their questions is valued. This is why, according to Phelan, the now is supplemented and buttressed by the documenting camera and the video archive. These recordings can only be a spur to memory, triggering some recollection to become manifest.

When considering the live event and its documentation, the issue of the selected perspective on the recorded event is equally important. This is a worthwhile topic of research in its own right because it is not always clear whether the presence of the public is part of the performance and should be recorded, or if the recording should only frame the performer. And should one add close-ups of the artist even if they are not visible for the visitors present? In the case of artists with strong views on the recordings of their performance, the decisions taken may shed light on their views on performance art and the role of film/video. Yet it is also true that many performance artists have been quite indifferent to the often accidental recordings of their work by visitors.

Another problematic aspect of the documentation of performances is briefly addressed by Nam June Paik in his "Input-time and Output-time," in which he argues that to counter the television entertainment or in order to preserve the purity of information or experience, some video artists refuse to edit or to change the time-structure of performances or happenstance. As he explains, they insist that input-time and output-time be equal. In real life, however, the relationship of input-time and output-time is much more complex. In some extreme situations or in dreams our whole life can be experienced as a flashback compressed into a split second, which means that certain input-time can be compressed or extended in output-time at will (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 98). Paik relates this to metamorphosis as a very function of our brain, which is, in computer terms, the central processing unit itself: "The painstaking process of editing is nothing but the simulation of this brain function" (98).

All varieties of documenting performances through video, however, seem to capitalize on video's recording function, as a way to save events

as memory for the future. These documents share this application with home videos that "help participants remember," as Sean Cubitt characterizes home video in *Videography*, a mnemonic function that video shares with family photography and that perhaps derives from it, turning video into a supplement to this older medium (1993, 5). This mnemonic power of video is the focus of the next section.

The Application of the Mnemonic Ability of Video and the Relationship with Activist-Videos and Home Video

A not yet discussed specific kind of video in which time plays a crucial role pertains to "video documentaries" and "home videos" that take advantage of video's suitability for registering and preserving events for the future. From the early 1970s, amateurs have made home videos of family life to remember special events and contribute to a history of the family, but video artists, too, created diary-like works or biographical documentaries. In the same period, political activists started to use video as a tool for recording and documenting their activism, and some of them propagated video recordings as educational material. Although artists participated in collectives such as Raindance Corporation, most of them hardly bothered about the difference between video artworks and vernacular documentary moving images.

Interestingly, three decades later, many visitors viewed the exhibition *Documenta* 11 (2002) as the culmination of a development in contemporary art in which the documentary form increasingly became the dominant artistic language, as evaluated by its curator Okwui Enwezor in "Documentary/Vérité" (2003) (in Lind and Steyerl 2008, 81). In this exhibition, however, Enwezor aimed to hybridize the documentary mode – defined as essentially concerned with the recording of dry facts – by joining it to the idea of *vérité* – a French word which encompasses a process of unraveling, questioning, probing, and diagnosing a search for truth (Enwezor and T.J. Demos in Lind and Steyerl 2008, 87, 109).

The next section intends to provide insights into video's mnemonic ability, through investigating some video artworks – in which the documentary is also hybridized in various ways – in relation to activist documentary videos and home videos.

Video as social documentation and recording tool in activism

Critic and curator Deirdre Boyle demonstrates in "A Brief History of American Documentary Video" (in Hall and Fifer 1990) and *Subject to Change: Guerrilla Television Revisited* (1997) that at first there were few distinctions between video artists and activists: nearly everyone made documentary tapes. And in *Being and Time*, art historian Marc Mayer notes that the democratization of video as a medium in the 1970s was seen by many as the solution to social inequities of establishment misinformation (1996, 27). It would fragment oppressive master narratives and revolutionize the way in which oppressed groups and individuals told their own stories. Chris Meigh-Andrews, in *A History of Video Art*, characterized the emerging video art practice as ranging from political activism, such as by Raindance Corporation in the USA and TVX in the

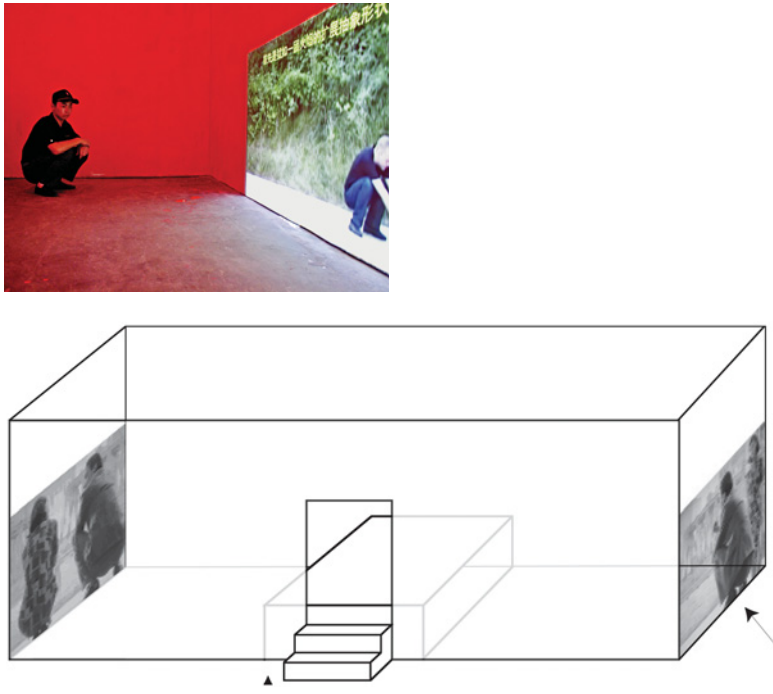


Figure 1.8 Simon Leung, *Squatting Project/Guangzhou*, 2008. Two-channel digital video installation (projections facing each other), color, sound, nine variations on two-minute segment of film *Center Stage*. © Simon Leung, courtesy of the artist.

UK, to works by performance-based artists (2006, 81). He describes the New York-based Raindance Corporation, founded in 1969, as a "movement" of American youngsters who were politically active and inspired by a desire for greater participation in the democratic process and a growing awareness of the power of cultural production. They increasingly viewed the accessible video and computer technology as major components in an arsenal of radical cultural tools. This kind of collective that included political theorists, artists, and activists grew as much out of a shared cultural imperative as from a pragmatic need to pool and share equipment (61).

Radical Software, a journal founded in 1970 by Raindance Corporation and edited by Paul Ryan, Ira Schneider, and Beryl Korot, was influential in creating a video counter-public sphere by opening up a discursive space in which strategies of direct response in video aesthetics, politics, and technology could be discussed collectively. Guerrilla video tactics outlined ways to mount run-and-gun strikes that would capture events that could provide a perspective not filtered through network monopolies (Rogers in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 39–40). Deirdre Boyle calls these initiatives the story of the first television generation's dream of remaking television and their frustrated attempts at democratizing the medium (1997, xvi).

In 1971, journalist Michael Shamberg, a member of Raindance Corporation, published *Guerrilla Television* in cooperation with his fellow-activists, in which they formulated their view on the medium-specific characteristics and preferable uses of video. It became the first book on video to be published in the US. As announced on the back cover, the book tells its readers how one can break the stranglehold of broadcast television on the American mind; the blurb also claims that information tools and tactics are more powerful means of social change than politics, and that the book informs us how low-cost portable videotape cameras, video cassettes, and cable television networks can be applied to develop a sense of media ecology and achieve "true democracy." This book of more than 100 pages consists of two parts: a set of ideological statements is followed by a detailed manual that includes theoretical reflections on video and television, as well as various technical details (mainly about video cameras) and practical instructions. Feedback in particular is stressed as an important prerequisite for the verification of experience, which is not provided by broadcast television (Shamberg 1971, part 1, 12).

Shamberg compares a broadcast television crew that goes to an event and stands above the crowd with going to an event with a Portapak and shooting in the crowd (part 2, 8). According to Meigh-Andrews, many

politically and socially motivated artists who began using video in the 1970s made what came to be called "street tapes" – direct documentation of ordinary people going about their day-to-day lives, often edited "in camera," using the pause control of the Portapak (2006, 64). As examples, he mentions Les Levine's *(Irish) Bum* (1965) and Frank Gillette's five-hour documentary on the street life of the hippy community. These documentaries use video's easy recording technology to prevent social events from being forgotten.

"Guerrilla Television," according to Shamberg, could contribute to an information infrastructure for "Media"-America, a grassroots network of indigenous media activity (1971, part 2, 9). He notes that at Raindance there was no notion of ownership of videotape footage. When people recorded videotapes these were filed together in what was called the "data bank." Everyone was free to make use of this data bank for his or her own edits. And elsewhere in the book Shamberg mentions that a videocassette distribution network is cheaper and more far-ranging than local cable systems (29).

In an essay about "video memories," cultural theorist Marita Sturken draws attention to the fact that for independent video makers the preservation of images and recording of history has been an underlying desire in the accumulation of videotapes. She refers to both Raindance and Videofreex as video collectives with an interest in compiling data banks of alternative images and accruing an alternative visual history to the nationalist history produced by broadcast television. Because concerns about preservation of the tapes themselves were deemed irrelevant, most of the early videotapes by the collectives failed to survive (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 3).

Shamberg's *Guerrilla Television* can be considered a 1970s video activists' manifesto. One may wonder what a more recent equivalent of this manifesto could be. An interesting candidate is *The Electronic Disturbance*, written in 1994 by the Critical Art Ensemble, a collective of five artists with different backgrounds exploring the intersections between art, technology, radical politics, and critical theory. They state that communication and control functions of the elite are now fully cyberspatial, so cyberspace has become the only effective site of resistance:

> Since it is unlikely that scientific or techno-workers will generate a theory of electronic disturbance, artists-activists (as well as other concerned groups) have been left with the responsibility to help provide a critical

> discourse on just what is at stake in the development of this new frontier. By appropriating the legitimized authority of artistic creation, and using it as a means to establish a public forum for speculation on a model of resistance within emerging techno-culture, the cultural producer can contribute to the perpetual fight against authoritarianism. (in Wardrip-Fruin and Montfort 2003, 788)

They add that postering, pamphleting, street theater, and public art were useful in the past, but people have left the streets; the public has become electronically engaged. The Critical Art Ensemble incites artists to take advantage of the fluidity of the electronic world through invention (788).

An exemplary video work by the Critical Art Ensemble is *Immolation* (2008), a five-minute loop video installation. It addresses the use of incendiary weapons on civilians after the *Geneva Convention* and the *Protocol on Prohibitions or Restrictions on the Use of Incendiary Weapons* of 1980. Two juxtaposed projections confront the damage done on a macro landscape level and on the (micro) cellular level of the body. For the latter part the artists "created" human tissue in a laboratory and used microscopy recordings. In addition, film footage of present and past wars that have used immolation against civilian targets is inserted. The goal is to provide a different way of imaging, viewing, and interpreting the human costs of these war crimes, in contrast to the barrage of media imagery to which we have become so desensitized.[8]

Video has also increasingly become part of artistic criticism in fields such as post-colonial theory. The Hong Kong born artist Simon Leung became particularly famous for his *Squatting Projects* (1994–2008) executed in various metropolitan cities. The multimedia projects included, among others, pasting posters and presenting videos showing squatting figures. *Squatting Project/Guangzhou* (2008) consisted of two video projections presenting nine variations on a two-minute segment from Stanley Kwan's 1992 movie *Center Stage*, in which the protagonists squat together and reflect on the multiple connotations of crouching (Figure 1.8). In these projects, Leung presents resistance through the performative act of squatting in specific spaces and places to highlight political or social restrictions on the use and occupation of space.[9] As in the case of the above-discussed activist-artists, Leung also publishes texts to underscore his arguments. In 2008, for instance, in his reply to a questionnaire by art magazine *October* as part of the public discourses on the invasion of Iraq, he expresses his preference for artworks that address

> the power of the state as it intersects the psyche, ones which engage the correspondence between aesthetic/political/form/subject and the effects and affects of power. … they often interpolate representations of the mechanisms of power with signs of resistance; they often contemplate the vicissitudes of daily life held hostage by masculinist drives toward domination – some of them leading to war. (Leung 2008, 103)

Activists such as Raindance Corporation, Critical Art Ensemble, and Simon Leung use video images as visual arguments, aiming to stimulate the social-critical awareness of their public. In fact they use video as a witnessing and documenting medium, as a tool to serve collective memory, which is the focus of the next section.

Video art and collective memory

Sean Cubitt emphasizes in *Timeshift* that video is a process both of remembering and forgetting, but where television is designed to forget on an industrial scale, video is condemned to remember (1991, 106). Through video is recorded what has already been lost, the memory of absences that once motivated desire, or that can still promote anxious, guilty, or nostalgic emotions. Cubitt's reflection on memory and forgetting relates to the medium of video in general. When one searches for video artworks that specifically reflect on collective memory and amnesia, the first video that comes to mind is American artist Woody Vasulka's videotape *Art of Memory* (1987), probably one of the most oft-discussed video works in historical overviews of video art. In "The Politics of Video Memory: Electronic Erasures and Inscriptions," Marita Sturken argues that in this videotape particularly the role of video as a technology of memory is present: remembering, forgetting, and containing memories (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 4). *Art of Memory* deals with the fluctuating cultural meanings of images that are coded "history." Vasulka used black-and-white photographic and filmic images of historical events of the twentieth century, such as the Spanish Civil War, the Russian Revolution, World War II, and the atomic bomb. Newsreel and documentary footage are changed into image-objects that appear to sit on a Southwestern desert landscape. They serve to de-contextualize the filmic images: one cannot read them as windows onto the world, but only as generic images of history. Having lost their individual meaning, the images of history have become a tangle of memories swallowed by the electronically

rendered desert landscape. Scratchy voices echo these images; one cannot understand them, but they can be interpreted, according to Sturken, as the voices of history (5).

Commenting on the same work, Yvonne Spielmann observes that by integrating historically precedent technology (photography and film) into the fluid movement of electronically processed landscape images, Vasulka makes the transformation of history into discourse visible on two levels (2008 [2005], 107). These are the historical distance of the media used and the storage function of older image and sound media. By presenting this stored information through the moving video images, the artist translates them back from being a container for memory into remembered history. What is more, the historicity of the technological progress is transferred into a dynamic discourse of criticism of the military-industrial context, which put technology on the course of destruction.

Regarding the various levels of memory that play a role in *Art of Memory*, film theorist Raymond Bellour observes at least four of them. The first level is the memory of war of the artist as a child. The next memory level is that of the grownup, who remembers the impact of war machines on him. The third one would be that of the character that Vasulka invokes as his alter-ego: the man with deeply etched features standing in the landscape, who is faced with his doppelgänger, made of pure webbing, through which electronic memory is suddenly, exemplarily, blended with the web of history. The fourth level of memory relates to the spectators, who must mentally return to the past apocalypse (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 149–151).

The relationship between recording and erasing in video and in our memory runs explicitly or implicitly through many texts about the medium of video. Michael Shamberg, for instance, stressed in *Guerrilla Television* the characteristic of videotape as re-usable: "you simply record over it . . . " (1971, part 2, 22). In Chapter 3 video's ability successively to record, erase, and re-record will be discussed in more detail in juxtaposition with the medium of drawing.

A multilayered example of a more recent video work that deals with collective memory is French artist Pierre Huyghe's *The Third Memory* (1999). It consists of a two-channel projection on two juxtaposed screens and reflects on the film *Dog Day Afternoon* (Sidney Lumet, 1975). This film deals with the notorious attempted robbery of the Chase Manhattan Bank in Brooklyn three years earlier, on August 22, 1972. The robbery

was led by John "Sonny" Wojtowicz, who shortly after the release of the film publicly contested its accuracy in a letter. A copy of the letter is included in Huyghe's installation along with news clippings of the actual bank robbery. In *The Third Memory* Huyghe gives Wojtowicz the opportunity to tell his own story in relation to the robbery and its media coverage. The resulting staged and edited report is a few times interrupted on one of the screens by the fragment from *Dog Day Afternoon* on which he reflects, and it finishes with TV footage of the robbery.

In *The Place of Artists' Cinema*, film theorist Maeve Connolly provides an in-depth analysis of this video work (2009, 139). She notes that Wojtowicz's limited scope for explanation – also owing to Huyghe's editing – resulted in a juxtaposition of "original" film fragments and "re-enacted" scenes by Wojtowicz that look surprisingly similar, turning *The Third Memory* into a re-enactment of the original film shoot, rather than of the robbery. Huyghe himself noted that Wojtowicz shifts between "the memory of the fact and the memory of the fiction" (quoted in McDonough 2004, 107). Another interesting aspect of "collective cultural memory" is Wojtowicz's remark that he and his "troops" borrowed many of their tactics from the famous film *The Godfather* (released in the spring of 1972), which they watched in preparation for the robbery.

Huyghe's way of dealing with a historical event calls forth the debates on the nature of the documentary.[10] If for a long time the genre of documentary photography and film was acknowledged as truthful reportage with a social function, in the past few decades this status has increasingly been criticized. Specific discussions gave rise to the introduction of new terms, such as "post-documentary" by Martha Rosler and "documentary fiction" by Jacques Rancière. In "Documentary Fiction: Marker and the Fiction of Memory," Rancière, a scholar in aesthetics and politics, deals with the questions of "what is memory?" and "what is the documentary as a genre of fiction?" (2006 [2001], 157) Regarding Huyghe's *The Third Memory*, it is interesting that Rancière relates memory, documentary, and fiction through explaining the relationships he notes between memory and fiction, and between documentary film and fiction film. He defines memory as "an orderly collection, a certain arrangement of signs, traces, and monuments," while fiction involves, in his view, "using the means of art to construct a 'system' of represented actions, assembled forms, and internally coherent signs." This observation leads him to the conclusion that documentary film, in fact, does not need to differ very much from fiction regarding cutting a story into sequences, assembling shots into stories, joining and disjoining voices, bodies, sounds and

images, and manipulating time (158). He illustrates his points with reference to Chris Marker's documentary film *The Last Bolshevik* (1992), yet as a genre concept "documentary fiction" is also applicable to Huyghe's *The Third Memory*.

The combination of memory, documentary, and fiction also informs the concept of documentary fiction that is the outcome of art historian Sabine Eckmann's analysis, in *In the Aftermath of Trauma: Contemporary Video Installations* (2014). This publication is devoted to five video installations that explore individual and collective trauma caused by radical historical events, such as the 1947 division of India and Pakistan (in Amar Kanwar's *The Lightning Testimonies*, 2007) and the killing of Osama bin Laden (in Alfredo Jaar's, *May 1, 2011*, 2011). She explains that in these works a variety of methods is used in order to include in the regimes of the visible the elusiveness and improbability of memory in its relation to traumatic political events (2014, 7). As she stresses in particular, all installations employ both documentary materials and fictional content and strategies, aiming at, according to Eckmann, a Brechtian alienation effect that creates a discursive space for critical engagement (12).

Martha Rosler in "Post-Documentary, Post-Photography?" agrees that strict objectivity, a standard derived from journalistic ethics, is an inappropriate ideal for documentary, but she disapproves of artists who exploit this to turn to the alibi of personalization, sentiment, or disengagement (2004 [2001], 230). Significantly, Rosler underlines the importance of a continuous effort to defend documentary, arguing that we need it. One should find a balance between observing the situation of others and expressing one's own point of view, including some form of analytic framework identifying social courses and proposing remedies (240). Rosler's suggestions differ from Rancière's description of "documentary fiction," but her suggestion to reflect on societal issues and question their representations simultaneously is akin to Huyghe's take in *The Third Memory*. Likewise, the video work *Video Apathy* (2010) by British artist Toby Huddlestone, which deals with political activism and collective memory, appears to relate to Rosler's as well as Rancière's view on documentary, albeit in a different way. This video, which lasts seven-and-a-half minutes, presents a history of the last sixty years focusing on a range of protests, rebellions, and revolts against wars, political machinations, unemployment, and undesirable social structures. The work consists of historical images which flash by in a rhythm underscored by a rap-like voice-over, which explains the goals of the activists. Toward the end the question arises: for what do people fight and protest nowadays?

Significantly, in the light of our discussion in the first section of this chapter that related video art to television, the voice-over concludes that reality television and social media have now taken the place of demonstrations and rebellions. Huddlestone observes a society of indifference, indecision, and powerlessness, and he reacted to that by organizing the political campaign *Apathy 2009*, which could be considered as an ironic performance artwork: a protest which addressed nobody and presented texts that showed excuses intended to justify not protesting. The event was documented and was added one year later to his historical overview *Video Apathy*. This last episode that seamlessly follows the historical highlights is, in fact, a self-constructed historical event (Langenbach 2013, 70).

According to Marita Sturken, electronic images have a continually shifting relationship to history. The television image is an image of immediacy, transmission, and continuity. This has led certain cultural critics to declare television to be the site of memory's demise. Fredric Jameson, for instance, has claimed that memory seems to play no role in television (1991, 70). In contrast, Sturken argues that the stakes in memory and history are ever present in electronic media; despite its paradoxical relationship to the preservation of memory, "television-video" is a primary site of history and cultural memory, where memories, both individual and collective, are produced and claimed (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 2–3).

Home video as mnemonic device

Michael Shamberg advises his readers in *Guerrilla Television* to tape everyday ordinary events: eating, walking, sleeping, talking, making love (1971, part 2, 48). He adds that one should feel absolutely no compulsion to show these tapes to others, or even save them, because it is inherent in the economy of videotape that it is erasable. Shamberg stresses that this differs from film, because film costs money and time and compels people to "do something" when the camera is on. Thus home movies pick up on what is essentially abnormal or forced behavior (48).

In her essay about the politics of video memory, Marita Sturken emphasizes that since its invention, the camera has functioned centrally in the desire to remember, to recall the past, to make the absent present. Photographic, cinematic, and video images are the raw materials used to construct personal histories: events remembered because they were photographed, moments forgotten because no images were preserved, and not-recorded memories that work in tension with camera memories (in

Renov and Suderburg 1996, 1). The shift in use from 8 or 16mm film to video recording as the preferred medium for documenting performances (as discussed in the former section) paralleled the development in recordings of family life. After the introduction of the first relatively inexpensive portable Portapak camera, important events in family life (especially weddings) were recorded ever more frequently by video cameras, which made immediate presentation possible on the television screen. Art theorist William Kaizen, in "Live on Tape: Video, Liveness and the Immediate," describes an advertisement in *Life* magazine of September 1965 that shows a mother taking video images of her children, accompanied by the caption that "the new home video recorder, made by Sony Corp., makes a movie at a swimming pool and instantly shows it on a television screen" (in Leighton 2008, 260).

Some video artists have explicitly expressed awareness of the relationship between their medium and the home-made video. Vito Acconci, for instance, argued in his 1984 essay "Television, Furniture, and Sculpture: the Room with the American View" that art video might be placed as "a subcategory of home-made video or on a sliding scale somewhere between home-made video on the one side and regular broadcast television on the other side" (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 130). This categorization is quite surprising because most of Acconci's videos do not look like home video or television, although they deal with private life, and should rather be positioned as critically reflecting on both of them. Also, in contemporary art quite a few video works extend or parody consumer video's modes of interfacing with everyday life. These works can be related to the genres of home video that have emerged in the past few decades, such as video diaries, video letters, commemorations of holidays and other special occasions, and documents of natural disasters, accidents, and police brutality.

Media artist Christine Tamblyn describes in her essay "Qualifying the Quotidian: Artist's Video and the Production of Social Space" (1996) how ordinary people use the culture imposed on them by the technocratic elite, and she relates this to certain video art practices. She notes that video has become a primary tool in the production of social space. As a medium that is economically accessible and requires minimal technical skills to master, video is ideally suited as a vehicle for the close integration of art and life (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 14–15). In the video artworks discussed by Tamblyn, video art and consumer video both serve as vehicles of cultural intervention. Examples include Lynn Hershman's electronic diary, records of vacations or other journeys in Chip Lord's

Motorist (1989), and video used as a family album in Jeanine Mellinger's *In Those Days* (1988) and in Janice Tanaka's *Memories from the Department of Amnesia* (1989).

The latter is a virtual family album that reflects on the death of the mother of Japanese artist Tanaka. The artist juxtaposes "official" historical accounts with personal memories and anecdotes, combining still photographs, audio recording, and written inscriptions. In a detailed analysis of this work, Marita Sturken notes that for Tanaka the video form becomes an aid to bear witness and reclaim memories. Tanaka stated that in her childhood home "silence was the keeper of memories," and that her videotapes are a means of speaking through that silence (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 8, 12). In this and other tapes discussed by Tamblyn and Sturken, memory is not seen as a depository of images to be excavated, but rather as an amorphous, ever-changing field of images. It is about acknowledging the impossibility of knowing what really happened, and a search for a means of telling about it.

Whereas Tanaka applied characteristics of the family album as home video genre, American artist Lynn Hershman created with *Electronic Diary* a video related to the genre of diary. It consists of three parts: *Confessions of a Chameleon* (1986), *Binge* (1987), and *First Person Plural* (1988). In the first part the artist describes how she was abused as a child and how in defense she constructed an imaginary personae for herself. The third part returns to her childhood abuse. As the second part most clearly uses technical aspects of the medium to underscore the contents, only *Binge* will be addressed here. This piece was recorded over a period of several months as she tried to lose forty-five pounds. Each day she set up the camera in her studio, addressing its fixed lens as one might address a therapist. She free-associated about her feelings toward her changing body. Throughout the tape Hershman employs special effects in an inventive manner to illustrate the ideas she broaches in her monologue: while talking about avoiding looking in mirrors, her image splits into two symmetrical halves; and a verbal allusion to physical distortion is counterpoised with a squeeze zoom that compresses her body into a thin column. When she states "we're taught to filter out our originality," an electronic filter applied to the image removes its color. And technical malfunctions during taping interrupt the depressed Hershman's confession of her own malfunction in losing only two pounds in six months. In this way, analogies are shown between abilities of the medium and events in reality portrayed by the medium (Tamblyn and James in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 20–21, 128).

In her essay "The Electronic Corpse: Notes for an Alternative Language of History and Amnesia," filmmaker and theorist Erika Suderburg discusses what Sean Cubitt calls "timeshifting," which is what makes video a revolutionary tool, as we throw off our passivity and reorganize received information ad infinitum to create our own programming (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 103). Suderburg's most relevant case study is filmmaker Jean-Luc Godard and Anne-Marie Miéville's one-channel video work *Soft and Hard (Soft Talk on a Hard Subject between Two Friends)* (1985) (109–112). According to Suderburg, Godard was interested in video because he could control all the technical aspects of it simultaneously: shooting, lab work, and playback exist in one unit.

The tape shows Miéville arranging flowers, Godard on the phone needling a producer, Miéville at a film editing table, and then popping in videotapes of a soccer match. The domestic order of routine is perpetually infiltrated by the history of cinema through film stills. The main question deals with how one's personal image history is formed in the crosstalk between film history, the domestic refuge, televisual flow, the charting of a current historical news story, or the breakdown of these units in recollection (111). A hard question is where these "masses of objects" are laid to rest in a continuum that can include African famine and the American actress Lillian Gish. Their discussion then circles around the erasure of memory via television. Godard says he likes television because it does not show things. He can become lost in its free-flow fall and interrupt the flow with his own images. Miéville remarks: "television makes you think that it never shows things, but it never stops showing things and that is what showing things is" (112).

Tamblyn, Sturken, James, and Suderburg discuss in their essays in the volume *Resolutions 2* various ways in which artists react to amateur home video genres. In debates about the term "vernacular" scholars agree on the application of the term to the works of amateurs, but there is a lack of consensus as to whether the term includes works of professionals who create products for use in daily life, such as advertisements and educational and therapeutic tools. In his article "Wedding Video and Its Generation," cultural theorist James M. Moran discusses wedding videos as objects of cultural analysis. This genre of commercial event video falls, according to Moran, outside the typical lines of theoretical inquiry. As media, wedding videos are neither broadcast nor publicly exhibited. Their audiences are always local at the most micro demographic levels, yet cross all categories of ethnicity, gender, sexuality, and age. Adopting conventions from home

movies, television broadcasts, still photography, and narrative filmmaking, the wedding video intersects several protocols of spectatorship and constructs new audience communities (Moran in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 360–361, 365).

Professional wedding videos do not seem to be an interesting target for video artists, contrary to the use of video as therapeutic tool by professional therapists. A good example is a video by the American artists Joe Gibbons and Tony Oursler: *Onourown* (1990). In this work the deployment of the medium as a therapeutic tool is satirized. The tape's premise is that the two protagonists – Gibbons and Oursler, playing marginalized artists – have been discharged from a psychiatric hospital due to budget cutbacks. To aid in their rehabilitation and adaptation to independent living, their therapist suggests keeping a video diary. Additionally the therapist has produced videotapes of mock counseling sessions that they are supposed to watch daily. These videotapes consist solely of the therapist's pat responses; the artists are supposed to "fill in the blanks" by talking back to their television set (Tamblyn in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 22–23).

Memory and psychology also play a role in theories about the medium of video, for instance in the use of the term "screen memories." Marita Sturken notes that images projected and transmitted on screens can be seen as "screen memories," which she relates to psychoanalysis (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 1). According to Freud, a "screen memory" functions to hide painful memories that are too difficult for a subject to confront; the screen memory offers itself a substitute, while "screening out" the "real" memory. The introduction of editing tools in the course of the 1970s, and especially the digitization of the medium of video in the 1990s, increased the shift in video art from evoking real-time experiences to fragmented memory-like structures, as will be discussed in more detail in Chapter 4, where also Freud's theory of "screen memory" will be related to Rodney Graham's video *Vexation Island*.

At the end of this section, I want to emphasize that it is not always immediately clear whether one is looking at a documentary, activist video, or video performance (the latter itself being a complicated category, as discussed in the former section). For instance, British artist Catherine Elwes presents herself in her video *With Child* (1983) during her pregnancy and reflects on the effects of it. Sean Cubitt discusses this video in *Timeshift: On Video Culture*, in which he investigates how video functions in both daily life and art and how it relates to the mass medium of television (1991, 131–132). Cubitt argues that Elwes works through

the more fragile dialectic of personal politics, particularly the strangeness which adults acquire around childbirth. He describes how the pregnant artist rehearses the activities and expressions of the child, while the child's toys, notoriously two stuffed monkeys, take on the adult roles of sexual activity. Cubitt emphasizes that pregnancy and childbirth are given a prominent position in ideologies of women's oppression: they guarantee the absolute difference of the woman, and tie her to the biology of her sex as the essence which she is preordained to fulfill. Elwes's tape pulls on many facets of pregnancy, the cultural meanings, the social status, to such an extent that the suggestion that this is only a "personal" piece would appear naïve if not actually ideologically limiting itself, according to Cubitt. Elwes's video is used by Cubitt to demonstrate that personal politics is a route through the interface of both the social and the individual. He relates Elwes's video to video documentaries, whereas Rose-Lee Goldberg emphasizes similarities with performance art (particularly performance art as part of new feminist criticism), such as cathartic self-analysis, endurance, visceral engagement with viewers, as well as the use of language, frequently as monologue (1998, 181).

In sum, my argument in the third section of this chapter has demonstrated in particular that the video works discussed either critically reflect on the medium's potential as a vehicle for memories or evoke awareness of the special power of video as an alternative tool of remembrance in social practice. This observation complements the results of my literary research and visual analysis approaches in the chapter's two previous sections, devoted to immediacy and comparative research of video art in relation to television and performance art. As I suggested, video artworks such as the ones discussed in the first section make viewers aware that the experience of immediate presence is an experience of mediated presence rather than an experience of directly presented reality, as television may seem to suggest to us. Moreover, the potential of video to mediate presence on the spot appears to be useful in performance art to support issues of self-other perception.

Technical developments have clearly influenced characteristics of video art, television, and video used in social practice. Still, intentional disturbance continues to play an important role in most of the video artworks discussed and its role is often emphasized in theoretical reflections on video art. Disturbances are either caused technically or evoked through contents or both: disturbance of immediacy, disturbance of memory, disturbance in expectations, or disturbance in interaction in

order to increase the public's critical perception of audio-visual electronic mediation.

This chapter started with Gillian Wearing's video work *Trauma*. At the end of this chapter I conclude that the discussed strategy of immediacy used by television for directly addressing the viewer as conversation partner, as underscored by close-up and frontal presentation in the center of the screen, is also employed by Wearing. The HD-quality increases presentness, but the mask obstructs it, stressing the tension on television between private and public, as well as between exposing and obstructing views. The sections on video performances and video as tool in social practice make clear that *Trauma* is also related to the use of video as reflexive instrument in self-other relationships. Moreover, the work combines the suggestion of immediacy in addressing the viewer with the presentation of selective memory through the mask and story from the past. The importance of sound in this and other video works underscores that some video artworks are still in debt to video's roots in audiotape recording and in radio as the precursor of television. Sound strengthens real-time experiences and comes out of the image into the space of the public, which leads us to the various spatial characteristics of video art.

Notes

1 Some quotes (from Leighton 2008, 259): Andy Warhol: "... immediate playback. When you make movies you have to wait..."; Bruce Nauman: "Well, initially, it was the immediacy of the medium"; Frank Gillette: "People see videotape and what they read in their skulls is 'real' – it seems live, and has unstored quality like the immediacy of ... the 7 o'clock news"; and Lynda Benglis: "Video was for me a way of presenting certain ideas that occurred in film, but presenting these ideas in a more immediate, self-revealing way"; Dan Graham: "Video is a present-time medium .. [it] feeds back indigenous data in the immediate, present-time environment"; Vito Acconci: "The immediacy of video was the most startling thing."
2 Gillian Wearing is quoted about the use of the masks in Krystof 2012, 13.
3 Chapter 3 will address color in video art more in-depth.
4 http://rhizome.org/editorial/2012/nov/29/sendreceive-liza-bear-and-willoughby-sharp-after-a/ (accessed December 3, 2013).
5 Chapter 3 elaborates on portrait videos.
6 For a historical overview of this genre, see, for instance, Bódy and Weibel 1987.

7 Nowadays television can also be watched outside the domestic spheres, e.g. on smart phones in public transport, but that does not change dramatically the private ambiance.
8 www.critical-art.net/Installations.html (accessed December 30, 2013).
9 Leung paraphrased by Pamela Kember. www.aaa.org.hk/Diaaalogue/Details/809 (accessed December 4, 2013).
10 For a brief overview of these debates, see Van Gelder and Westgeest 2011, Chapter 4 "Photography's Social Function: The Documentary Legacy."

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2

Immateriality versus Three-Dimensionality: *Video Art as Sculpture, Installation Art, Projection, and Virtual Medium*

In his essay "Video Art Installations: the Telenvironment" (1976), art critic Peter Frank notes that, commonly, video is strictly regarded as a temporal medium. The technological nature of video, however, gives it relevance not only in time, but also in space, owing to its mode of presentation in particular (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 204). In the 1970s, the usual way of displaying video relied on the cubical TV set, a spatial object quite different from the traditional method of displaying cinema on a flat screen. Frank even compares the intimate box format console monitor to a theater, suggesting its similarity with a puppet stage. Only in passing does he refer to the then recently developed method of projecting video onto a large screen, as in cinema, but he concludes that such enlargement accentuates the peculiar "feel" of video even more (its grain, its color, its figural distortion), removing it further from film in sensory terms (204).

This was in 1976. Although since then the technical quality of video works has improved tremendously of course, this did not solve all the problems of its presentation. As film and media scholar Lucas Hilderbrand argues in "Moving Images: On Video Art Markets and Distribution" (2012), there has always been the problem of how to exhibit video art in gallery spaces, particularly single-channel work, and these questions seem to persist. Should video be shown as a continual loop or with predetermined start times? With amplified sound or with headphones? With multiple works competing for time on a single monitor or with dedicated outposts for each work? After the move to projection and

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dedicated spaces, according to Hilderbrand, the video artwork came to represent an immersive world with technological and architectural elements that could not easily be replicated by the home video viewer. Rather than being a kind of reproducible text, the video work grew dependent on more complex specifications for its presentation (in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 4–5).

From the early 1980s on, screens have played an increasingly important role in the discussion of spatiality in video art. Spatial installations that consisted of TV sets were succeeded by multiple screens for multichannel projections installed in a spatial setting in galleries. As art historian Kate Mondloch observes in *Screens*, by dispersing focus across screen spaces that coexist, and even sometimes compete with the actual exhibition space, certain media installations generate a forceful, critical effect that hinges on the tension between illusionist/virtual and material/actual spaces (2010, 62). These kinds of presentations gave viewers an experience of being both "here" (embodied subjects in the material exhibition space) and "there" (observers looking onto screen spaces) at the same time. Mondloch's observation emphasizes that spatial presentations of video art invade the space of the spectator and influence the perception of the visitor. Referring to Michel Foucault's view that docile subjects respond to internalized disciplinary initiatives, she claims that screen-based spectatorship could result in a disciplinary process that regulates viewers' minds and bodies in specific ways aiming at docile productivity. As Mondloch concludes, however, there is a prospective criticality embedded in critically reflexive artworks that explore the charged relationship between bodies and screens, even while they make use of coercive technologies of attention (35). Most of the artists that will be discussed in this chapter, such as Lynn Hershman, Bruce Nauman, and Shirin Neshat, purposefully exploit this volatile relationship and, to use Mondloch words, assiduously negotiate "the unstable equilibrium between participation and regulation intrinsic to media reliant installation spectatorship" (35).

The central notion in this chapter is "video installation." This concept is used in a variety of definitions. In its broadest definition, "video installation" refers to the spatiality involved in the presentation of video art. The term relates to "installation art," which usually indicates artworks consisting of a spatial constellation of objects that can be entered by the viewer. Art historian Claire Bishop, in her influential *Installation Art: A Critical History* (2005), elaborates four modalities of experience that installation art structures for the viewer: The Dream Scene, Heightened

Perception, Mimetic Engulfment, and Activated Spectatorship. Each one of them implies a different model of the subject and relates to a distinctive type of work. Two years before Bishop, curator Mark Rosenthal, in his *Understanding Installation Art* (2003), proposed a taxonomy of installation art consisting of four poles: Enchantments, Impersonations, Interventions, and Rapprochements. Bishop's modalities of experience partly overlap with these four poles. In the course of this chapter I will return to these two classifications several times and discuss their particular merits in more detail.

The crucial role of the beholder in installation art was first addressed by art historian Julie H. Reiss in *From Margin to Center: The Spaces of Installation Art* (1999). As Reiss argues, the spectator is in some way regarded as integral to the completion of the work, which turns spectator participation into the essence of installation art, although the definition of participation varies greatly from one artist to another, and even from one work to another by the same artist (1999, xiii). For most of the key works in this chapter, the spectator's participation appears to be important indeed, if not inevitable.

Video installations are not only closely related to installation art, but as spatial arrangements of moving images they are also part of a development from classical cinema toward cinematic installations. The anthology *Kinematografische Räume: Installationsästhetik in Film und Kunst* (2012) by art historians Ursula Frohne and Lilian Haberer discusses in great detail how cinematic presentations have become more spatial, and how the imaginary space of film turned into a combination of imaginary and actual space. And in the compilation *La Querelle des dispositifs: Cinéma – installations, expositions* (2012), Raymond Bellour relates his analyses of film and video installations to topical debates on "dispositive aspects" (regarding both the complex apparatus and display) of cinema. This chapter, however, focuses more on relationships between video and spatial arts than between video and cinema, which will serve as the main comparative medium in Chapter 4. The basic concern of this chapter is: how do comparative research of various video installations, the literature on video art, and particular views on spectatorship in installation art contribute to our understanding of video's complementary characteristics of immateriality and physical presence? This focus comprises an inquiry into the consequences of the explicit usage of various spatial qualities in video art for the construction of meanings.

As part of the varieties in spatial presentations and the consequences for spectatorship, this chapter addresses the specific video space-system

of the closed-circuit as a recurring phenomenon from the early years of video on. In the previous chapter I discussed closed-circuits in their quality of immediacy and real-time experience. In this chapter they are addressed as inclusive spaces that encompass the viewer and his/her space. Moreover, whereas the video works discussed in the former chapter mainly dealt with the suggestion of the immediate presence of the body of the artist or performer, video installations largely tend to concentrate on – and sometimes even depend on – the body of the responding viewer. Rosalind Krauss, in her 1976/1978 seminal essay, already drew attention to the use of the human body as video's central instrument, as well as to the difference between videotape's relation with the body of the artist practitioner and video installation's heightened concern with the responding viewer (in Battcock 1978, 45).

The structure of this chapter is partly based on a chronological order. Following the introductory case study, the first section starts with the earliest years of video art, when the moving images were presented on a TV set as a spatial element that doubled as "building block" for creating assembled sculptural objects. Next, the subsequent three sections deal with video projections on screens and objects, which became possible only after improvement of the quality of the video images, whereby technological innovations went hand in hand with increasingly larger screens. In the 1990s the digitization of video and new relationships with the internet extended the space of video art into virtual and global spaces, and this serves as the focus of the last section. These developments in video art reflect a spatial extension, moving from the small TV box via monumental multiple screens to the virtual global world. Significantly, the shift also implied an increasing dematerialization of video art. This chapter's last case studies will, though, reveal an increasing interest in the relationship between digital space and physical presence, both in content and form of presentation.

Lynn Hershman's *Tillie the Telerobotic Doll* (1995) Juxtaposed to Andy Warhol's *Outer and Inner Space* (1965)

American artist Lynn Hershman's 1995 telerobotic doll Tillie makes us look through her eyes at the world around her (Figure 2.1). Tillie operates much in the same way as camera surveillance technologies: the



Figure 2.1 Lynn Hershman, *Tillie the Telerobotic Doll*, 1995. Interactive networked installation. © Lynn Hershman, courtesy of the artist.



Figure 2.2 Andy Warhol, *Outer and Inner Space*, 1965. 16mm film, black-and-white, sound, 66 minutes or 33 minutes in double screen. © 2014 The Andy Warhol Museum, Pittsburgh, PA, a museum of Carnegie Institute. All rights reserved. Film still courtesy The Andy Warhol Museum.

doll's eyes are replaced by cameras, a video camera in her left eye and a webcam in the right eye. The visitors to the gallery who are spotted by Tillie's left eye can see the recordings of themselves in the mirror placed in front of Tillie that mirrors a small monitor positioned opposite to her. The webcam in her right eye is operated by internet users who through remote control are also able to move her head 180 degrees. These images are refreshed at a rate of thirty seconds and a resolution of 320×200 gray scale, to accommodate visitors with slow connections. Regarding Tillie, Hershman states that reliance on tracking and surveillance techniques has resulted in a culture that has a peripheral vision that extends beyond

normal human physiology. Through Tillie, viewers not only become voyeurs, but also virtual cyborgs, because they use her eyes as a vehicle for their own remote and extended vision (in Tromble 2005, 87).

Tillie the Telerobotic Doll, as interactive networked and closed-circuit video installation, includes various kinds of spaces: the physical space of the doll, the closed-circuit system, and the gallery visitor; the space in which the external user is physically present; and the virtual space in which the virtual user visits the gallery and directs Tillie's webcam eye. Finally there is the complicated social space between the virtual visitor and the visitor to the gallery, who is not aware of the virtual manipulator of Tillie's right eye and head.

Dealing with these multiple spaces in video art was only possible after control by computers and the internet became available. From the mid-1960s, however, artists already investigated multiple spatial aspects of video art by means of TV sets and through experimenting with the space of the observer. American artist Andy Warhol's *Outer and Inner Space* (1965) is an interesting example in this respect (Figure 2.2). This work consists of a confrontation of the older medium of film with the new medium of video in the form of a quadruple film-video, black-and-white portrait of the actress Edie Sedgwick. Two separate reels of film, of thirty-three minutes each, form together a split screen with four close-ups of the actress: two of the images present Sedgwick in profile on TV sets in the background, while the other two are of her speaking in the foreground to someone off-screen, commenting on watching herself on television. Thus, the video recording in this work is presented in the space of the film set, rather than that of the gallery.

Tanya Leighton calls this quadruple film-video portrait one of the earliest works reflecting on film's relationship to video and televisual liveness (2008, 23). The multiple portrait is described by William Kaizen as showing Sedgwick "as she becomes acclimatised – sort of – to the immediacy of video" (in Leighton 2008, 265). Or does the work even more serve to demonstrate Warhol's own exploration of the potential of this new medium? In the summer of 1965, *Tape Recording* magazine asked Warhol to experiment for one month with the portable Norelco slant-track video recorder, a remote-control television camera with a zoom lens, and a Concord MTC 11 hand-held video camera with a Canon zoom lens (Rush 2003, 52). During the filming of *Outer and Inner Space*, Warhol experimented with the video medium, deliberately distorting the scanning of the video image or playing with the vertical roll on the TV monitor. The ingenious juxtaposition of video/television portraits and

film portraits makes *Outer and Inner Space* a fascinating early example of experimenting with space in video art.

Although Hershman's *Tillie* was produced thirty years after Warhol's *Outer and Inner Space*, both works present various spaces simultaneously. The two works therefore provide an excellent starting point for my discussion in the sections below, which deal with issues of space in video art that range from the use of the TV set as an intimate optical box to the wide open spaces of our burgeoning digital world.

Television as an Object: Sculpture or Part of Architecture

The early video artworks of the late 1960s and 1970s were presented on TV sets. Reproductions of these video images in books tend to ignore the role of this "show-box." For most artists it was merely a necessary condition for exhibiting video images and some even considered it to be an obstacle in their reception as art: "When people saw those screens in the gallery, they just thought about the domestic, they thought about having their tea."[1] Art historian Liz Kotz even argues that monitors disrupted the gallery or museum space: "is it any wonder video is so often confined to the basement or the stairwell?" (2005, 101)

Art historian Rob Perrée, in *Into Video Art*, stresses that the cubical casing of the TV set was necessary because the tube inside, which made the invisible recording visible, needed space (1988, 13). Even if the artist did not want to see the monitor as part of his work, he could not get away



Figure 2.3 Bruce Nauman, *Wall Floor Positions*, 1968. One-channel analog video, black-and-white, 59:25 minutes. © Bruce Nauman c/o Pictoright Amsterdam 2014. Courtesy Electronic Arts Intermix, New York.



Figure 2.4 Bruce Nauman, *Lived/Taped Video Corridor*, 1969–1970. Closed-circuit installation: wallboard, video camera, two monitors, videotape player. © Bruce Nauman c/o Pictoright Amsterdam 2014.

from it: "the thing is there, in its full dimensions and usually in its full ugliness" (13). As a consequence, it occupied part of the physical space of the viewer, and this caused the monitor to be more readily associated with a sculpture than with a painting, even when its images were restricted to the front side only. Another sculptural element of these video works mentioned by Perrée is that the light comes from within. The light source is behind the screen and shines toward the spectator. Conversely to film, where images are projected onto a screen, with video "the spectator takes the place of the screen and receives the images directly" (13). Thus, the monitor's actual radiation of light has a strong grip on the surrounding space.

Some artists chose to emphasize video's "show-box" characteristic as being different from film. The early video works of American artist Bruce Nauman, for instance, look quite similar at first to video recordings of performances, discussed in the previous chapter. In works such as *Wall Floor Positions* (1968), however, Nauman not only positions his legs and arms in various ways on the floor and toward the wall to investigate the environment of his body, but through limiting his movements to the frame

of the video camera he seems to investigate the inner space of the television cube, while the wall in the back becomes the rear wall of the cube (Figure 2.3). Commenting on this work, Michael Rush stresses Nauman's interest in the relationship between video and sculpture, but he refers to the sculptural poses of his body on his studio floor and wall, as if using his body as sculptural material (1999, 101). When we connect both observations, Nauman perhaps rather looks like a small moving sculpture locked up in a box, forced to adapt his body's positions to the inner size of the cube.

The spatial forms of TV sets were already used by Fluxus artists such as Wolf Vostell before the birth of video art. In his first *TV De-coll/age*, created in 1958, Vostell placed six television monitors in a wooden box behind a white canvas, which was slashed open with a knife. Tellingly, he declared the TV set to be "the sculpture of the twentieth century" (quoted in Rush 1999, 85). Rush concludes that both Vostell and Paik recontextualized the monitor, thus inaugurating a new way of viewing this small screen divorced from the familiar, commercial locus of the home (1999, 86). Nam June Paik has employed the spatial dimension of TV monitors from his earliest video works on. The TV sets that together constitute his *TV-Cello* look like the hollow body of the cello, filled with images rather than sound (Figure 1.3). Especially his transformed TV sets stimulated visitors to consider the works as spatial art objects. An interesting example of these transformations is the room Paik filled with randomly scattered and damaged TV sets for the exhibition *Exposition of Music-Electronic Television*, held in March 1963 in Galerie Parnass in Wuppertal, Germany. Wulf Herzogenrath has even referred to this exhibition as video art's moment of birth (1983, 26). The visitors were allowed to handle materials and directly experience sounds, smells, and movements through a playful encounter with these prepared objects, some of which were laying on their (back)sides, which also altered people's perception of the objects (Hanhardt 2000, 35). Some of Paik's works in this show referred to his interest in Zen Buddhism, such as *Zen for TV* (1963), which presented nothing but a minimalist white line on the black television screen – resulting from the use of a magnet that reduced the electronic scanlines to one line of light only. Not only the simplicity of the one white line seems to relate to his interest in Zen Buddhism, but also the deadlocks in his work can be related to Zen. Zen literature is full of deadlocks (to stimulate irrational thinking), which can also be found in several of Paik's works such as *TV-chair* (1968), a chair with a

television monitor as seat, that can only be used either as a chair or to watch television, not for both at the same time.[2]

The groundbreaking exhibition of artistic experiments with TV sets in the US was *TV as a Creative Medium*, at the Howard Wise Gallery, New York, in 1969. Marita Sturken characterizes the show as the legacy of machine art and kinetic sculpture, issues of mass media and information, as well as explorations of the aesthetics, technology, and time-based aspects of the medium (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 109). The suggested relationship with kinetic sculpture – a form of three-dimensional moving artwork often applied by artists in the 1960s – adds an interesting root to the history of video art, in addition to the more often discussed roots of television, audiotape, film, and performance. Observing video art presented on a TV set as a kinetic sculpture means focusing on how the objectness of the box is interconnected with the movements inside of it.

According to Vito Acconci, it was actually inherent to the domestic use of television to consider the TV set as a piece of (kinetic) sculpture. In his 1984 essay "Television, Furniture, and Sculpture: the Room with the American View," he explains that in its early days, the TV set took up the position of specialized furniture, if not of sculpture:

> It was like other furniture, but there were differences: it couldn't be sat in, like a chair; it couldn't be sat at, like a table ... Compared to other furniture, the television set couldn't be used, it could only be looked at; it had the uselessness that one associates with art. A person could walk around the television set, the way a person could walk around a sculpture; but, in order to see what was being transmitted, the person would have to look at it frontally (the way a sculpture is looked at in photographs). (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 128)

Various artists have used television sets explicitly as boxes to be looked at frontally. Striking examples are Nauman's above-discussed early work (Figure 2.3) and one of Hall's *TV Interruption*, which presented a tap that seems to fill the television set with water (see Chapter 1). In *Video-Skulptur: Retrospektiv und aktuell 1963–1989*, a variety of "video sculptures" is addressed, for instance the more complicated example *Il nuotatore* (1984) by Italian Studio Azzurro, which consists of a row of twelve monitors that seem to be filled with water in which a swimmer swims back and forth "across the water and monitors" (Herzogenrath and Decker 1989, 52).

The cubical television set inspired some video artists not only to use these boxes to create video sculptures or furniture but to use these spatial objects as architectural building blocks. Probably one of the most striking and literal examples of presenting video as building block is American artist Gary Hill's *Hole in the Wall* (1974), which entailed the artist recording himself knocking out a hole the size of a monitor in the wall of the Woodstock Artists' Association, videotaping the action from the next room, and then playing it back on a monitor placed in the hole. Hill thought of this video installation (actually his first one) as a transition from sculpture to video (Rush 1999, 145). An even more literal way of building with TV boxes involves the 23-meter high conical ziggurat of 1003 monitors that is *Dadaikseon* (*The More the Better*), which Paik built in 1988 on the occasion of the fortieth anniversary of Korean liberation.

The so-called "video wall" of nine stacked television sets arranged in rows of three, created by the American artists Frank Gillette and Ira Schneider in 1969 for the *TV as a Creative Medium* exhibition, related to the space of the visitors in a different way. Aside from cycles of fragments of broadcast television, this constellation, entitled *Wipe Cycle*, presented live recorded images of the visitors exiting from the elevator. If visitors stood before the grid of screens for eight seconds, they saw themselves entering the gallery from the elevator again. The relationship between the space of the visitors and spaces broadcasted elsewhere brings to mind Davidson Gigliotti's reflection, dating from 1976, on the preference for multi-channel presentation of some artists who were dissatisfied with single-channel work. In Gigliotti's view, this preference is hardly revolutionary because anyone who has ever been in a television control room, or even seen a picture of one, will realize that the multi-channel video experience is not new. Moreover, he refers to quite similar surveillance systems in larger apartment buildings, in war rooms, newsrooms, classrooms, laboratories, and therapy institutions of all kinds (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 214). As Gigliotti adds, the 525 lines that are flashed on the screen every 30th of a second can organize only a limited amount of information, implying that resolution is considered too poor for complicated images. By adding more channels to the system, the field of information is increased (215). Furthermore, as he notes, these multi-channel works also led to another kind of attention, different from the single-channel work that demanded strict attention to the screen. The widening of the perceptual focus triggered a variety of questions, such as: how is this work to be viewed? Do all monitors carry information of the same value? Are we to view them all at once, or in some kind of

order? Does the nature of the programming provide some kind of clue, or perhaps the nature of the system? Where are we supposed to stand? (214).

Schneider and Gillette presented their live feedback system surveying the space of the visitors in a wall-like structure. A more spatial environment for experiencing the workings of closed-circuit recording was created by Bruce Nauman in his *Live/Taped Video Corridor* (1969–1970) (Figure 2.4). He invited the visitor to enter a space that might be called a "video/televisual space." If sculpture can be characterized as spatial objects to be looked at, architecture consists of spatial objects to be entered. The visitor has to enter Nauman's narrow corridor to see the images on two television sets located at the back, piled as two cubical objects. The bottom screen runs footage of the empty corridor while the top monitor offers an unexpected, real-time view of the rear side of the body of the spectator, recorded by the video camera above the entrance. Upon approaching the "show-boxes," the visitor diminishes on the top screen, receding from him/herself, almost disappearing in the space in the monitor. Oddly, one watches oneself from the position of someone else, seeing oneself disappear. Kate Mondloch observes that the viewer's experience with Nauman's corridor works is less about built architecture than about an architecture of media screen spectatorship – a mutually informing and psychically charged phenomenal connection between the viewing body and the display screen (2010, 30–31). Mondloch wonders whether the bottom monitor's playback is even more disturbing because it distressingly fails to "see" the spectator at all: conditioned by network television to understand news coverage as "live," spectators assume that the feedback on both of the artwork's monitors displays real-time images of the corridor and should therefore confirm their presence within the space. This statement relates to Ursula Frohne's more general observation about the transformation of the Benthamian-Orwellian idea of a panoptic society from one in which the problem is the impossibility of hiding from the omnipresent eye of authority to one where the fear is that of being withdrawn completely from the gaze of the others – the compulsive anticipation of observation of those who voluntarily expose themselves to the gaze of the camera to uphold at least some kind of connection to the media (in Levin, Frohne, and Weibel 2002, 275).

An important difference between *Wipe Cycle* and *Live-Taped Video Corridor* with regard to the relationship space-video-viewer is that the

former work does not depend on the visitor's active participation. When visitors enter the exhibition room they immediately become part of the work, whereas Nauman's video work only comes into being when someone enters it. In the mid-1970s, Robert Stearns noted with regard to exhibiting closed-circuit video as art in The Kitchen Gallery that at that time such works were the most difficult to present to the public. Unlike broadcast television, which by omnipresent transmission waves enters private space, closed-circuit environments must be viewed by people willing to situate themselves in foreign, formalized environments (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 160). Today, more than three decades later, these feedback systems have grown familiar to visitors of video art exhibitions, but closed-circuit recording appears to be used less often by artists. David Joselit, writing in 2004, mourns the loss of the social interactivity of closed-circuit video art; present-day projections "tend to hug the architectural envelope rather than produce a second informational circuit within the container of the gallery" (154). *Tillie*, the case study I presented at the beginning of this chapter, could be seen as an example of mid-1990s closed-circuit video art that not only enclosed the physical place of the artwork but also a global space. The social interactivity even plays a more crucial and complicated role than in early closed-circuit works. The monitor in Hershman's installation might be called a "sculptural" object as in early video, but the doll as object is far more important in this work. In the next section I examine the insertion of objects in video installations, which allows us to approach more closely the spatial aspects addressed in *Tillie*.

Spatial Video Installations and the Relationship with the Space of the Visitor

By the end of the 1970s, many video artists aspired to free video from its historical containment in the TV set. In the next decade, the term "video installation" became an often applied term for more spatial experiments with video presentations, even if defined variously. Some authors, for example, use this term for "multi-channel" video artworks in general: these works consist of various video presentations on projection screens or monitors. If the use of multiple monitors was discussed in the previous section, while the next section will deal with multi-channel projections on screens, this section discusses video installations that can be defined as



Figure 2.5 Mike Kelley, *Switching Marys*, 2005, mixed media installation with video projection. © Mike Kelley Foundation for the Arts. All Rights Reserved/ VAGA, NY /Pictoright Amsterdam 2015.

a combination of video art and installation artworks that contain objects which are part of the space of the visitors and which surround them. Rather than one ideal place from which to survey the work, the viewer is activated to move through the artwork and to experience the work from various angles. Perception of these works is made even more complicated by the combination of the physical objects with virtual objects and people in an illusory space. Julie Reiss was one of the first to propose that the essence of installation art is spectator participation. It is important to realize that Reiss focuses on an installation art that consists of objects – not people, who tend to figure prominently in media such as painting, sculpture, and photography; the visitors who move along and in between the installation's objects seem to need to compensate for the lack of human presence. In the case studies below the visitors who enter the physical, static installation environments are actually met by virtual human beings in motion.[3]

The installation *Switching Marys* (2004–2005) by American artist Mike Kelley demonstrates clearly the impact of an installation in which image projections are combined with objects (Figure 2.5). Two oval half-transparent projection screens hang free in the exhibition space. Two still images of a woman dressed like "Mary" and standing on a pedestal are shown as constantly switching back and forth from one screen to the other. In the one image Mary is positioned outside in nature, standing on a tree-stump with her arms down; in the other one she poses inside, before

a curtain on a classical low column, and holding her hands up. Before the screens, in the space of the visitor, both pedestals are presented on top of each other, carrying a loudspeaker. Next to this constellation, Mary's blue cloak and her headdress are hanging on a wooden stepladder. On both sides of the ladder two attached beamers project the two poses of Mary onto the screens. On top of the ladder, another beamer projects a video in the opposite direction on a rectangular screen that hangs on the wall. This video, consisting of two episodes, starts with presenting the same Mary again, standing in a sort of garden on the tree-stump. A man places the stepladder, which the visitor will immediately recognize, before the woman. A boy steps on the ladder and places the headdress on the woman's head, in the presence of a group of people, which turns the event into a kind of initiation ritual. The second episode takes place inside. The boy walks through a dark building and is confronted with a woman in backlight, so he can only see her silhouette. When the light turns on, she proves to be a horrifying, awful-looking woman rather than the young beautiful Mary. The woman aggressively approaches the boy. In a kind of classical filmic pursuit through the stairwell and across the attic the boy screams that he is dying to awake from this horrifying dream. The two sides of life presented here, Eros and Thanatos, recur throughout Kelley's oeuvre.

Switching Marys consists of many dichotomies: two moving image projections facing each other, each composed of two alternating parts that either switch from one screen to another or replace each other in a continuous restart. One episode relates to nature and the world outside, the other episode takes place inside. All the objects in the installation have their virtual complement in the representations in the projected images. The objects become like theatrical props, and this stresses the staged nature of the video works; they also cause the viewer to become part of the scene and the virtual images.

The word "switching" in the title of Kelley's piece thus relates to many different complementary shifts in the work. Also, the visitor of *Switching Marys* is thrown, as it were, from the outside to the inside of the installation and projection, thus causing him/her to have to switch from looking from the outside at the installation to perceiving it from different angles on the inside.

With regard to the interrelationships between objects and video projection that allow visitors to wander around, the video installation artworks of Tony Oursler immediately come to mind. Oursler, a friend of Kelley, is well known for the array of projection surfaces he created for his videos.

In the 1990s, he used newly available data projectors to project obsessively talking heads onto puppet-like props, making the animated figures eerily appear to chant and rant. In effect, Oursler's flickering sculptures took the small puppet-show dramas of his earlier videotapes into the gallery, where viewers could walk among the figures and encounter them in three-dimensional space and nearly lifelike scale (Kotz 2005, 101). Chris Meigh-Andrews notes that Oursler pursues a strategy to engage the viewer in a more active relationship with his work, endeavoring to create a "situation rather than an image" (2006, 258–259). Especially his talking dummies would express his interest in the connection between the power of technology and human desire. In 2012 Oursler created a series of micro installations that he described as embodying "poetically-layered thought patterns" (quoted in Gielen 2013, 38). These works – roughly the size of a cranium (the portion of the skull enclosing the brain) and presented at head height – consist of assemblages of miniature objects on which a composition of tens of layers is projected through a single projection beam (38). Whereas Oursler's earlier works showed talking faces, here one sees complex networks of images in the "brain" while hearing struggling existential thoughts that seem to circulate there. The creation of these complex micro video installations became possible only after the invention of the mini-beamer.

In his works Oursler simultaneously combines a micro scale and a large scale, as well as new technologies and age-old ones. In 2013 he presented the installation *Phantasmagoria* in Hornu, Belgium, which with a length of forty meters is a kind of ghost train of frightening objects and projections, based on the Belgian scientist Etienne-Gaspard Robertson's notes about a phantasmagoria he presented in Paris in the late 1700s. The historical overview of image projection written by film scholar Tom Gunning in 2009 also starts with Robertson's optical experiments. As Gunning explains, they differed from traditional magic lantern shows primarily in that Robertson concealed the apparatus from the audience's view, resulting in images that seemed to suddenly loom out of the darkness (in Douglas and Eamon 2009, 24–28).

The discussion of Kelley's and Oursler's installations might suggest that combining objects and image projection only started in the 1980s, but American artist Robert Whitman presented his series *Cinema Pieces*, which consisted of objects animated by film projections, already in the years 1964–1965. His *Shower* (1964), for instance, was composed of a functioning shower stall in which he projected a woman showering (Iles 2001, 86–87). And for *Window* (1964) a real window was put into the

wall of the exhibition space. Behind it a rear-screen projection presented a forest through which a woman for a short instant passes and disrobes. Art historian Andrew V. Uroskie concludes in "Windows in the White Cube" that in this work the projected image not only shifted away from the cinema screen into the medium of sculpture, but the tactile, material space of the sculptural installation also became imbricated with the dematerialized dreamspace of the cinematic (in Trodd 2011, 151).

Uroskie's conclusion leads us back to the above-mentioned modalities of experience of installation art formulated by Claire Bishop in 2005, and the works discussed in this section. Kelley's and Oursler's accessible installations go further than a materialized dreamspace to be looked at; they have become what Bishop calls a Dream Scene. This type of installation art is characterized by psychological absorption and by physical immersion; the presence of real objects even places the viewer in the position of protagonist. Because these kinds of installations, which often present uneasy spaces, frequently seek to trigger fantasies, individual memories, or cultural associations in the viewer's mind, the symbolically charged "dream scene" would provide the richest and most poignant model of comparison for our experience (Bishop 2005, 47). Quite similarly, Rosenthal defines his pole of Enchantments for installation art as that the viewer is standing in a filled-space installation before a dream-like or nightmare-like world, but this viewer would be more often contemplating than participating (2003, 41). Applied to installations that include video, Bishop's and Rosenthal's characterizations make one realize that although the objects create a "real" world rather than an illusionist video space only, these video installations also present themselves as "dream worlds" constructed in the museum.

Although Hershman's *Tillie* similarly consists of objects and projections, the work does not fill the exhibition space; the visitor, who cannot wander in-between the objects, is neither psychologically absorbed nor physically immersed, but only indirectly "present" in the virtual space and in the mirror. As a result Hershman's work from 1995 cannot be called a Dream Scene. In 2005 Liz Kotz voiced critical concerns about recent developments in exhibitions of video installations geared to presenting increasingly spectacular works. She accused gallery-based video art to be all too eager to please, even to the extent of total submission to the dictates of spectacle culture. She refers to artists like Matthew Barney, who became well known for his spectacular kitschy installations in which objects and projections are combined. These works would use features characteristic of early video work by artists such as Acconci and

Nauman, such as duration, in a "cleaned up, prettified" fashion, just to be "entertaining" (Kotz 2005, 109).

Projections on Spatial Positioned Screens, the Space of Sound, and Interaction with the Visitor

The term "video installation" is most often used to refer to multi-channel video presentations projected on multiple screens. The simultaneously presented video images force the spectator to choose when to switch from one screen to another, to contemplate the relationship between various projections, and where to position him/herself in the space of the installation. Installation artworks that consist of objects stimulate visitors to walk along the objects and focus on the relationships between them. This differs from installations consisting of moving images, that we are used to sitting in front of to look at, particularly in the case of media such as cinema and television. With respect to two video projections opposite to each other, film scholar Duncan White has well formulated the dilemma involved: "as if they are to be watched simultaneously." In this respect, "seeing" even becomes a secondary aspect of the work's reception process once the spectator has resigned him/herself to the difficulty, if not impossibility, of watching the two screens at once (in Rees et al. 2011, 231). Rob Perrée describes the difference between viewing a one-channel video work and a multi-screen video installation as a shift from a time-experience to a space-experience: "looking at a video installation is more

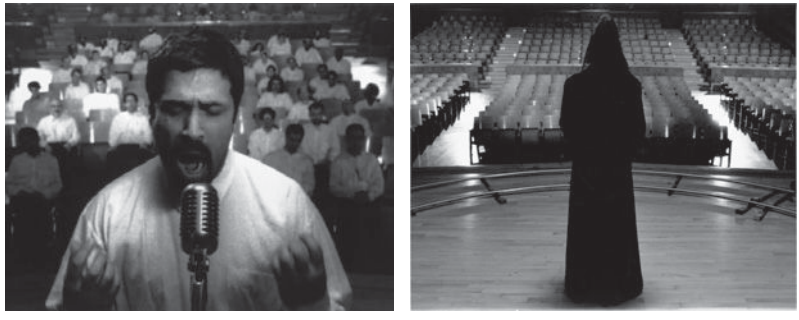


Figure 2.6 Shirin Neshat, *Turbulent*, 1998. Production Still. Two-channel video installation, black-and-white, sound, 10 minutes. © Shirin Neshat, courtesy Gladstone Gallery, New York and Brussels.

like looking at a room of paintings than watching a single video tape" (1988, 17).

The importance of space in video installations has been touched on in particular by art historian Margaret Morse, in her article with the meaningful title "Video Installation Art: The Body, the Image, and the Space-in-Between" (1989). Liz Kotz also addressed this aspect in detail in her "Video Projection: The Space Between Screens" (2005). Kate Mondloch, in *Screens: Viewing Media Installation Art* (2010), has elaborated the arguments of Morse and Kotz. Their views, as well as those of Mondloch herself, will be at the heart of this section. In addition, I discuss the debate on the concept of "expanded cinema": "expanded" increasingly appears to refer to expansion in space, although some authors use the term for expansion into real time or in consciousness, as well as for mixed-media experiments in cinema.

Margaret Morse opens her essay by discussing characteristics of installation art in general before she elaborates on multi-channel video presentations (1990 [1989], 154–156). As she notes, "installation" refers to the artist setting up several objects in a space that is usually of a temporary nature. The latter characteristic results in the documentation of installations by diagramming, photographing, videotaping, or describing them in language. Its crucial element, however, is ultimately missing from the documentation: "the space-in-between," or the actual construction of a passage for bodies in space and time. Equally important is that the visitor enters the artwork in the middle, which is unlike the set-up found in other media such as theater where there is a barrier (referred to as "the fourth wall") between stage and public. In shifting to video installations, Morse discerns two types that can be differentiated by focus on tense: presence versus past. Although this division is quite similar to the structure described in Chapter 1, in which time concepts in video art were divided in "immediacy" and "memory of the past," Morse highlights the consequences for how visitors deal with space in a video installation. In video installations in which closed-circuits are used, a "live" camera relays the image and sound of visitors in charged positions in the installation space to one or more monitors. Shifting back and forth between two and three dimensions, a closed-circuit installation explores the fit between images and the built environment. Morse connects this fit with the process of mediating identity and power. Conversely, the recorded video art installation can be compared to the spectator wandering about on a stage, in a bodily experience of conceptual propositions and an imaginary world of memory and anticipation (159).

The categorization suggested by Morse for video installations is not always productive. The viewer's experience of being present in the scene presented on the screens appears to be evoked quite often in video installations in combination with the experience of wandering about on a stage in a world of memory. A most relevant example is Iranian/American artist Shirin Neshat's black-and-white video installation *Turbulent* (1998) (Figure 2.6). In 1998 Neshat began positioning two large projection screens opposite each other. *Turbulent* shows the two opposite positions of a male and a female singer in a theater, with regard to her home country Iran after the 1979 Islamic Revolution. While the veiled female singer waits silently, her back to the camera, the man (filmmaker Shoja Azari) sings an old Persian song based on a Sufi poem (the voice is Shahram Nazer's, a Kurdish Iranian folksinger). He performs before a male audience, but they look at his back side, and he only turns to them when they applaud him. From the perspective of the audience in the theater, his position is extremely unusual, but, surprisingly, the viewer of the video hardly notices this absurdity: the experience the viewers have in fact – quite egocentrically – is that they are the audience of this singer. After finishing his song, the woman (Iranian singer/musician Sussan Deyhim) starts singing a raw, emotional song, which swells to a complex avant-garde sound collage (Noack 2000, 33), consisting of sounds and screaming, contrary to the man who has "the power of the words" but who now does not seem to address us anymore (Frohne 1999, 33). The woman has turned her back to us, facing the empty seats of the theater: in Iran women are not allowed to perform in public, which Neshat makes us aware of. Next, the camera starts to circle around the woman, emphasizing her isolated position, but also showing her face.

While standing in-between the opposite screens, one has to turn one's head time and again to check whether the image has changed on the other screen and to see how the two singers react to each other. Moreover, one continually moves back and forth, searching in vain for the best viewing position. The visitor also realizes that the "real-time" experience is stronger in perceiving the man than the woman, which fits in with the public life and interaction of men versus the private life of women in the Islamic world. Neshat remarked about the active position of the spectator of *Turbulent*:

> Unlike a cinematic picture, where you are sitting in your chair and are passive, here you become part of the piece. It's a very emotionally and psychologically demanding situation in which you have to keep debating

> whether you should be looking on this side or that side. ... You have to make a decision which side you are going to watch, which means you have to decide which part you are going to sacrifice. (quoted in Connolly 2009, 97)

Particularly the strong expression of the voice of the woman and the unfamiliar sounds (contrary to the man's traditional song) fix the viewer's attention. Neshat thus seems to call attention to the potential power of these women.

Evidently, sound plays an important role in this installation, even more than in the case of this chapter's above-discussed works that included sound. Particularly in the first decades of video art, most artists were trained in the visual arts and they suddenly had to deal creatively in video art with sound, a discipline unfamiliar to them. As a result, sound was not a priority for video artists, except for an artist such as Paik with a background in music. Whether video artists were artistically familiar with sound recordings or not, challenges in relating image and sound cropped up earlier in artists' films of the mid-twentieth century. Rob Perrée has articulated some of these challenges, suggesting that image and sound (although both time-based media) function as each other's opposites because in the reproduced image the third dimension is lost, implying that the image can be no more than a representation, whereas the sound, given its acoustic character, can be a faithful rendering of reality (1988, 45–46). Perrée also wonders whether our perception of image and sound is equivalent. In his view, repetition is an important characteristic of musical sound, whereas images aim in particular toward progression. Moreover, the tangibility of sound seems greater than that of the image. At the same time, sound always seems submissive to the image, whereas the content of images may be boosted or highlighted when combined with sound.

With regard to *Turbulent* it is safe to conclude that sound is at least as important as the images; in fact the images and the sounds are interwoven and interdependent. In Chapter 4, I will address some of the issues mentioned by Perrée in more detail when discussing Gary Hill's works in which images and sound are not synchronous and as a result are more competitive. For the present chapter's focus on space, it is relevant to note that the sound of the two songs fills the exhibition room (and sometimes even the adjacent spaces); it is directed outward, in other words, whereas the images on the two opposite flat screens close off the outside space and face inward. This observation underscores Perrée's

proposition that sound enhances a more spatial dimension. For a more in-depth reflection on the combination of sound and moving images we have to turn to publications such as critic and composer Michel Chion's *Film, a Sound Art* (2009 [2003]). Chion deals with film sound, but some of his arguments are also applicable to video art. His reflection on the spatiality of sound is particularly interesting in relation to spatial video installations such as Neshat's *Turbulent*.

The difference between a visual shot and what might be considered its audio equivalent is, according to Chion, that the former is a container of time and space with definite spatial and temporal borders, whereas with sound it is just the opposite (2009 [2003], 226). Sound has no actual frame. Independent of the image, sound is like a formless audio layer. This absence of a frame for sounds inevitably creates a dissymmetry between what we see and what we hear, although that does not mean that there is any hierarchy here (227). Regarding the position of sounds, Chion observes that the loudspeaker that emits them is not the place of their existence or of their operation. The loudspeaker is merely the thing that sends sounds into the theater where they bounce around, before they finally enter the viewer's ears: and it is only here that the sounds truly take place (247–248). This relates to the spatial differences between looking and listening. While the verb "to see" applies to everything inscribed physiologically within the field of vision, "to look" pertains to the active observation of an object or detail within this field. If, along similar lines, to hear is used to name all that enters via the ears and registers automatically on consciousness, to listen involves the act of paying full attention to a part of what one hears. Thus we can say that for humans, the field of hearing around listening is far bigger than that of seeing around looking (286). As a result of the limited angle of view, we see the direction in which people are looking, and we have to decide where to look, as in the case of Neshat's *Turbulent*. When it comes to hearing, we have no idea in which direction someone is listening, a phenomenon called "the invisibility of hearing and its effects" by Chion (291), but neither does one have to choose a perspective in the installation, because the sound of Neshat's singers is everywhere in the room.

When image and sound come together in lip synch, it is hard to imagine that sound is not coming from the singers' mouth, but from loudspeakers. Thus, when there is simultaneity between sounds and images, they blend with each other, and it becomes difficult to perceive them separately. Chion calls this "synchresis." Separating the experience would even be impossible, according to Chion, because synchresis is

a universal, psycho-physiological phenomenon that operates as spontaneously as any reflex, resulting from our nervous system and not from any cultural conditioning (214). Film makes abundant use of this effect, especially in post-synchronization and the production of sound effects. Synchresis makes us believe, for instance, that sounds that hardly resemble footsteps *are* those footsteps when synchronized with a shot of a person walking. It also enables the dubbing in of voices that are not those of the actors seen on screen (as in the case of Neshat's male singer). Synchresis is also what allows filmmakers to play with effects of contradiction and displacement (the mismatch of a voice and a body, one sound heard in place of another) (215). An interesting example in video art is American artist Bill Viola's *The Crossing* (1996). On one side of the projection screen one sees a man under an increasing deluge of water and on the other side one sees the same man in the middle of a fire beginning to blaze. It is fascinating that for the viewer the swelling up sound in the room is certainly the sound of water when looking at the one side and that of fire while looking at the other.

In the case of Neshat's *Turbulent* one should wonder, however, whether it is not just the overwhelming sound, but also the monumentality of the wall-size screens that contributes to the impact of the work. Liz Kotz notes that by the mid-1990s video turned up as increasingly monumental installations (2005, 101). In museums, installational projects claimed space on the main floor, while the conventional tapes remained marginalized in physically segregated "screenings." Kate Mondloch emphasizes that the screens themselves have "the curious status of functioning simultaneously as immaterial thresholds onto another space and time, and as solid, material entities" (2010, 4). To a certain extent this is applicable to Neshat's *Turbulent* because the two screens evoke the illusion that one looks onto two theater stages, but the screens also seem to function as two opposite walls. Mondloch explains the indifference toward projection screens as material entities by museum visitors by observing that the screen's objecthood is typically overlooked in daily life; the conventional propensity is to look "through" media screens, not at them. Although she considers the screen to be an ambivalent object, "its physical form shapes both its immediate space and its relationship to viewing subjects" (4).

Mondloch selected Peter Campus's work *Interface* (1972) for an in-depth case study about the viewer-screen relationship, but for this section it seems more interesting to discuss Campus's work *Shadow Projection* (1974). A semi-transparent screen is positioned in the center

of the exhibition room. Opposite the screen, a video camera and light beam are installed at a distance. The visitor who enters the space in-between is lighted and recorded. The light makes for a good recording, but also lights the screen and projects the shadow of the visitor onto the screen. Simultaneously, a video projector, positioned at the other side of the screen at a distance, projects the recording of the visitor on his/her shadow. Campus's installation confronts the viewer with a self-image that defies or challenges normal expectations. The artist used simple arrangements of the "live" video image and projection technology, sometimes in conjunction with mirrors, inverted cameras, or distorted projections, to create and explore complex coexistent physical and virtual spaces manifested via video technology.

The position of Campus's singular screen in the open space of a room turns the work into what Mondloch calls a "screen-reliant installation." As Mondloch claims, the screen shifts from being the apex of the viewer's "cone" of vision (centering the viewer as in perspectival painting) to being a conceptual and literal point of emphasis that the viewer moves around (something closer to minimalist sculpture[4]) (2010, 64). Although the visitor to Neshat's installation does not walk around the screens, Mondloch's description of the changed position of the viewer is applicable here, as well as her characterization of the screen-reliant installations as "the interpenetration between the space 'on' the screen, the space between the viewer and the screen, and the space of the screen object itself" (78).

As this section's last installation I would like to discuss *Le Détroit* (2000) by Stan Douglas, a Canadian of African descent, a work that relates to Neshat's and Campus's installations in various striking ways. Whereas Campus's 1974 work presented a color video, and Neshat presented videos in 1998 that were originally shot on 16mm black-and-white film, in 2000 Douglas returned to both the obsolete 16mm black-and-white film and film projectors, a medium that some artists in the 1990s started to prefer as a more material alternative to the immaterial digital video. *Le Détroit* consists of two films that are projected on each side of a semi-transparent screen in-between the two projectors. Both six-minute film loops are the same, but one is a negative version of the other. The title of the film is the former French name of the city Detroit. One sees a young black woman (turned into white in the negative) by night stepping out of a car and entering a deserted house where objects are left by the former inhabitants. Associations are evoked with the history of Detroit, the exodus of the white population, racial discrimination and riots, and the city's ultimate economic collapse. If Neshat, through the use of

opposite screens, underscored the different positions between men and women in Iranian culture, Douglas stressed the contrary positions of black and white people through opposite projections.[5] When the visitor enters one of the projection beams, one of the films is partly blocked, but, surprisingly, the image does not disappear but becomes even clearer because the image beamed from the opposite projector shines through the screen. As a result, the spectator becomes part of the story, which calls forth Campus's *Shadow Projection*. The spectator may even begin to feel a bond with the protagonist upon realizing, as observed by Dora Imhof, that one makes quite the same enveloping movements around the screen as the woman in the deserted house (in Frohne and Haberer 2012, 755).

Not only Douglas's presentation of film projectors in the exhibition space, but also the analyses of video installations by Mondloch, Kotz, and Morse provide some similarities with descriptions of what is called "expanded cinema." The anthology *Expanded Cinema* demonstrates clearly how wide the definition of "expanded cinema" can be (Rees et al. 2011). After its coining by filmmaker Stan Vanderbeek in 1965 (see the last section), the term was redefined in most subsequent publications. Regarding the theme of this chapter, filmmaker Birgit Hein's view is particularly interesting. She argues that expanded cinema extends film into the art scene: expanded cinema never really functions in a movie theater because you need more space, more than one flat screen, and often the audience must be able to move in the space (in Rees et al. 2011, 185). This perspective particularly meets the definition of video installations consisting of multiple projection screens.

If the concept of expanded cinema has its roots in the mid-1960s, the use of multi-screens can be traced further back in time. Although many publications on video art discuss the multi-screen presentation in video art in opposition to the singular screen in cinema, one should not forget the early experiments with film screens. A famous early example is Abel Gance's polyvision system for his 1927 movie *Napoleon*, a three-screen film presentation. Another interesting and more high-tech example is *Glimpses of the USA*, a film produced by Charles and Ray Eames for the American exhibition on science, technology, and culture in Moscow in 1959. On seven big screens in a dome, designed by R. Buckminster Fuller, 2200 images were presented of a typical workday in the US in nine minutes and a typical weekend day in three minutes (Beatriz Colomina in Douglas and Eamon 2009, 47).

How do the case studies discussed in this section fit into Bishop's and Rosenthal's classifications? Bishop's Heightened Perception is related to installations that are incomplete without our direct participation, as is the case in *Shadow Projection*. She defines this experience on the basis of Maurice Merleau-Ponty's work on the phenomenology of perception as formulated in 1962. In his view, perception is not simply a matter of vision but involves the whole body, which gives rise to the notion of embodied perception. Merleau-Ponty's claim that we do not see space according to its exterior envelope but that we live it from the inside and are immersed in it is applied by Bishop to installation art (2005, 48–50). In the book's final conclusion Bishop contemplates the paradoxical observation that installation art offers both an experience of centering and decentering: it insists on our centered presence (we have to step into the work) in order then to be caught in an experience of decentering (130). In other words, installation art involves us in a setting that reflects a world without a center or organizing principle; the viewing subject experiences this fragmentation firsthand (130). Furthermore, installation art aims to problematize the subject as decentered but also produces it (133). This is applicable in particular to multi-screen video installations as demonstrated in the analysis of Neshat's *Turbulent*.

Rosenthal's category of Impersonations deals with filled-space installations in which an artist presents either an impersonation of a life situation or one that subtly elaborates upon that condition. That a viewer may not even recognize the presence of a work of art may be applicable to Campus's screen that waits for visitors to see themselves projected. Rosenthal admits that these installations may have a dreamy aspect to the extent that they are removed from the real world (2003, 47), which is applicable to the theater scene brought into the museum by Neshat.

Rosenthal's observation that the artist wants dreams to be rooted in a sense of the everyday also fits Hershman's *Tillie* project. Likewise, being incomplete without the visitor's direct participation and making the viewing subject feel fragmented, as Bishop stresses, is certainly applicable to aspects of *Tillie* as well.

Immaterial Projections Interfering in Darkened Sites and Immersing the Viewer

When video art left the TV box and became a projected medium, the new way of presenting required darkness. As a result, video art shifted from the



Figure 2.7 Krzysztof Wodiczko, *Guests*, 2009. Five synchronized video projectors with sound system, Polish Pavilion, 53rd Venice Biennale, Venice, Italy. Curated by Bożena Czubak. © Krzysztof Wodiczko, courtesy Galerie Lelong, New York.

modernist "white cube" gallery into the "black box" gallery in the 1980s. Visitors had to grope their way into the exhibition rooms. Any sense of the given space was lost. This did not result, however, in the space being dissolved completely: the light of the projectors and the indirect light of the projections generated a space created by the video work itself. For instance, the walls of the dark corridor in Gary Hill's *Tall Ships* (1992) seem to withdraw when the projected people walk away, square to the space of the corridor.

Particularly Liz Kotz's article "Video Projection" offers valuable insights into the essence of projecting the video's light beam in the dark. Kotz contemplates on the origins of the term "projection" as derived from the Latin *projectionem*, meaning a throwing forward, extension, projection, and indicating displacement, dislocation, and transfer (2005, 102). At its core, projection is a form of geometry modeled on properties of light rays.

What are the consequences for our perception when a video installation is presented as an immaterial projection that interferes in a darkened site? We will explore the answers to this question by considering a representative case study, involving an intervention in the Polish pavilion at the Venice Biennale in 2009. The Polish/American artist Krzysztof

Wodiczko turned the pavilion from a building without any window into one with large windows in its walls and roof by means of video projections (Figure 2.7). This work suggested at first sight only to have "opened" the building for light to enter. The projections presented large steamy windows that were wiped by window-cleaners. By removing the vapor the window-cleaners seemed to enter the space, but the returning vapor "threw" them out again. This resulted in a process of alternating between becoming present and becoming absent – making one think of the title of Warhol's above-discussed work, *Outer and Inner Space*. But the title of Wodiczko's work, *Guests*, appears to address, symbolically, the problematic "opening" of Poland for migrants to enter Polish space (Czubak 2009, 100).

Wodiczko actually created a kind of virtual world that could be entered by the visitor, who could also walk around in it yet without the helmet (or glasses) usually needed for a "virtual reality experience." The spatial illusion thus created reminds one of the deceptive perception of panoramic paintings. This observation in turn calls forth media historian Oliver Grau's intriguing study *Virtual Art: From Illusion to Immersion*. Grau positions the illusionism of new virtual art in the art history of illusion and immersion, and he analyzes the related metamorphosis of the concepts of art and the image (2003 [2001], 5). Arguing that the idea of putting an observer in a hermetically closed-off image space of illusion did not make its first appearance with the technical invention of computer-aided virtual realities, Grau does not so much discuss video installations but rather returns to the frescoes of Villa dei Misteri in Pompeii, and from there to painted illusionistic spaces from the Renaissance, ceiling panoramas in Baroque churches, 360-degree panoramic paintings that became popular in the course of the nineteenth century, and twentieth-century cinematic panoramas. Grau thus demonstrates how in each period extraordinary efforts were made to produce maximum illusion with the technical means at hand. Moreover, he claims that these images, rather than presenting sequences of events, depict a spatial and temporal unity (5, 27).

In the same vein, Wodiczko's *Guests* does not present a sequence of events, but a unity in space and time, similar to a real-life experience. Regarding the viewer's experience, Grau notes that in most cases a mentally absorbing immersion takes place, one that can be characterized by a diminishing critical distance to what is presented and an increasing emotional involvement in what is happening (13). This leads him to the conclusion that immersive art specifically works against distanced and critical

reflection (339). Is this supposition also applicable to the video installation *Guests*? This is certainly true, I believe, for the first overwhelming experience when entering the pavilion. After a while, however, particularly as a result of the minimal action of wiping windows that takes place (conversely to immersive stories in cinema), the viewer gets the opportunity to reflect on the video installation. Grau ends his book with a quite similar point, arguing that contemporary artists tend to "play with and work on the paradigm of illusion, of resemblance to life, and of presence in other places." Their quest is "to rediscover the criterion of self-reflection, the awareness of inner distance and perception" (347).

As argued by curator Bozena Czubak in the Venice Biennale guide, *Guests* intends to evoke reflections on public space that has become very much the product of situated participants who craft that space through their engagement with ideas at a particular time and place (2009, 100). In an interview in 2003, Wodiczko cited the work of Claude Lefort and his advocacy of public space as a site for contention and debate, but also Chantal Mouffe and Ernesto Laclau's notion of antagonism – which allows for conflict and confrontation in understanding the fundamental construction of democracy – as ideas fundamental to his work (in Phillips 2003, 34).

The association with public space, instead of with individual movie watching, is also stimulated by the fact that the large projections reach the floor. In this respect, it was argued by Chrissie Iles at the 2003 round table on the projected image in contemporary art organized by Malcolm Turvey and George Baker that when a projected image reaches the floor, associations with cinema are negated and visitors are inclined to walk along as they do through a gallery. Iles contrasts this way of displaying with installing a film or video projector in a room, which rather seems to generate an experience more akin to a home movie experience (in Turvey et al. 2003, 80).

Video projection becomes even more related to public space when it is not presented in an exhibition room, but outdoors such as on facades of buildings. In this way, projections do not only transform the inner space of a building; they can alter its facade as well. In the past decade we have seen many (commercial) monumental projections on buildings during festivals and other events. Adaimy Studios (led by Lebanese Emile Adaimy), for instance, creates spectacular moving metamorphoses of facades of buildings such as their 3D animation projection *KOHAR* (2011) on the circular opera building in Yerevan, the capital of Armenia. In fact, monumental projections on facades by night do not differ

dramatically from monumental projections in "black cubes," aside from an even larger size and their "site-specificity" in the common definition of a work created for a particular site.

In *Pixels and Places: Video Art in Public Space* (2010), art historian Catrien Schreuder examines video projections in public space not only from the perspective of art history, but also from those of architecture history and urban design. Schreuder observes that practically every major city has had experience with showing video art in public spaces, either temporary interventions or as (semi-)permanent installations (2010, 5). The increasing popularity of outdoor video artworks mainly resulted from recent technological developments of beamers that can produce greater luminous intensity and increasingly brighter images that make projection from great distances possible as well as projecting in daylight. Moreover, LED-screens were invented for outdoor image projections (20). Schreuder's primary concern is with the artistic possibilities offered by public space (meaning, urban outdoor space) for video art and, vice versa, what video art has to offer public space. She distinguishes three different types in her conclusion: the museum type in which public space is seen as a new platform for autonomous art; a type that has roots in different forms of street art; and one characterized by collaboration between artists, architects, and urban designers (148). Her observation that video art is the medium par excellence for emphasizing the heterogeneity and variability of public space applies to all these categories (132). Adaimy Studios' *KOHAR* could be called a fourth category, being commissioned by the owners of the building and created as site-specific project, or a combination of Schreuder's first and third type.

Returning once more to Bishop's and Rosenthal's categories, one may conclude that the experience of Mimetic Engulfment seems to be applicable to the video works discussed in this section as well as the poles of Interventions and Rapprochements (both related to site-specific installations). According to Bishop, Mimetic Engulfment is evoked by dark installations that suggest visitors' dissolution; the possibility of locating oneself in relation to the space is diminished, because this space is obscured, confused, or in some way intangible (2005, 82). Rosenthal's pole of Interventions is defined as the aim of artists who interfere with and investigate the physical, functional, intellectual, cultural, or institutional character of a specific site (2003, 61). In some cases this can be combined with Rapprochements as other side of the coin of site-specific installations, which means that the space itself is emphasized (77).

Wodiczko's *Guests* demonstrates that his site-specific video projection both interferes with the pavilion and emphasizes its space as a result of the immaterial projections on the ceiling and walls and the reflections on the floor.

For more in-depth insights into the site-specificity and interventions regarding *Guests* and as a stepping stone to concepts of space in video art in the next section, art historian Miwon Kwon's essay "One Place After Another: Notes on Site Specificity" (1997) offers several worthwhile thoughts. Kwon deals with site-specific art that not only (or not anymore) relates to the physical characteristics of a site but also to its ideological aspects (2005 [1997], 34–35). She mentions, for instance, that the modern gallery/museum space with its stark white walls and artificial lighting (no windows) was perceived not solely in terms of basic dimensions but also as an institutional disguise. Kwon brings up as an example the removal of portions of a wall to reveal the base reality behind the "neutral" white cube, which is also what Wodiczko optically did to the Polish pavilion. But next to the social/institutional paradigm of site-specificity, Kwon also addresses the discursive paradigm of site-specificity, observing a shift from site-specific art to site-oriented practices. *Guests* is a multi-channel site-specific video work, but as life-size and real-to-life work it evokes the illusion of a social performance, becoming a kind of site-oriented practice. Kwon, however, mainly focuses on the presence of the artist, which becomes an absolute prerequisite for the execution/presentation of the site-oriented projects. It is now the performative aspect of an artist's characteristic mode of operation (even when collaborative) that is repeated and circulated as a new art commodity, with the artist functioning as the primary vehicle for its verification, repetition, and circulation. Generally speaking, the artist used to be a maker of aesthetic objects; now he or she is a facilitator, educator, or coordinator (or even bureaucrat). What this means with regard to video art will be discussed on the basis of the key work of the next section.

Interacting in the Merged Physical and Digital Space

Lynn Hershman applied a Web camera, computers, and internet for *Tillie* and related works in the mid-1990s. Lebanese artist Rabih Mroué's 2012 project *The Pixelated Revolution* reflects on the use of new media like these,



Figure 2.8 Rabih Mroué, *The Pixelated Revolution*, 2012. Photograph: Ernesto Donegana. © Rabih Mroué, courtesy of the artist.

but particularly focuses on the current use of cell phones for recording events in war situations (Figure 2.8). *The Pixelated Revolution* consists of a lecture performance in which the artist presents video footage downloaded from the internet, and a multimedia installation combined with the recording of the lecture. The project addresses the place of cell-phone cameras in between murderers and victims: the filmmakers do not move away from the snipers – who must have felt invisible, although they were not – which led to the recording of their own death. His lecture starts with the sentence: "Syrians are filming their own death." That the resulting videos circulated on the internet, however, made Mroué wonder if that meant that the victims were shot but not killed.

Mroué tries to find out why the filmmakers felt safe behind their cell phones and did not move away from the rifle of the sniper directed at them. He searches for explanations in how we tend to react to recorded moving images in feature films and video games. In general, his investigation ties in with a basic view of the pioneer in media studies, Marshall McLuhan (1964), who claimed that every new medium includes its predecessor. More specifically his research demonstrates a process that Jay David Bolter and Richard Grusin in *Remediation* (1999) have described as media influencing each other in how they mediate the "real" world, so

we experience the way of mediating by a new medium in comparison to other familiar media. Mroué provides the example of watching war films, which does not make one feel in danger oneself. In video games the spectator has even turned into the protagonist, who participates in a fight and can become the victim of his aggressor, but the player of the video game is never in peril of death.

Importantly, Mroué did not choose to present the selected footage from the internet, war films, and video games in the form of a documentary video accompanied by his statements as voice-over, but made the footage part of a lecture-performance, suggesting that a scholarly lecture would be taken more serious by the public than the documentary format, which is increasingly under discussion as unreliable. One might call this new genre in video art a "video performance," but the previous chapter demonstrated that this term is already used for various other forms of early video art. Miwon Kwon's observation of a shift from site-specific art toward site-oriented practices, whereby the artist becomes, for instance, an educator who mobilizes the site as a discursive narrative, becomes applicable here. The moving images projection is in fact used by Mroué as a classic educational tool to present his (artistic) research.

Mroué's project essentially starts from the fact that the use of cell phones as cameras caused a multiplication of the number of video recordings by amateurs. Ming-Yuen S. Ma and Erika Suderburg remind their readers in their introduction to the anthology *Resolutions 3* that the current Arab Spring uprisings have been fueled and multiplied by social networking, the impact of the audiovisual, and the cell phone/Web matrix's ability to portably and instantaneously broadcast the evolving revolution (2012, xi). They quote one of the Tunisian revolutionaries: "We could protest for two years here, but without videos no one would take any notice of us" and "The media blackout was broken because of a rock in one hand, a cell phone in the other" (xii). *Resolutions 3* includes a dialog between David Joselit and Faisal Devji, historian and author of *The Terrorist in Search of Humanity: Militant Islam and Global Politics* (2008), on locally produced jihadist videos intended for distribution via the global media network. They discuss the unlikely correlations between "terrorist" media strategies and video art practice, interrogating the production, circulation, and visibility of such media on a worldwide network through Devji's theory of the ethics of images. Devji argues that it is in their visualization that the local actions of jihad, disseminated worldwide through media, become influential events (in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 340).

Like Joselit and Ma and Suderburg, Mroué reflects on what Kenneth Rogers called "embedded video practice": video as part of the mobile, socially networked media. In his essay "New Media States: Web 2.0 and Embedded Video Practice," Rogers widely discussed the transition from an information-based internet to an interactive internet, called Web 2.0, in the years around 2000. The new tools and applications emphasize user-oriented and social networking services, rather than treat the Web as platform for content delivery. Users are allowed to upload and produce their own content and are able to interact with other users of the system. The new challenges resulted in the creation of blogs, wikis, social networking sites, online text, photo and video editing services, and so on. The power to influence network organization has moved into the hands of firms that organize and manage content rather than those who produce and distribute it (in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 41–42).

Regarding its effect on the public sphere, Rogers suggests that Web 2.0 is indicative of a powerfully progressive move toward a "networked information economy" that permits a greater potential for democratized social discourse in the public sphere. Video hosting sites emerge as an essential aspect of the Web 2.0 and function by organizing an open space that encourages users to produce and distribute their video content to a potentially mass audience, but, more likely, to a very narrow and culturally specific one. Web 2.0 made the distinction between sender and receiver fall away, creating an open-ended system where objects in circulation never reach an end destination (44). As Rogers concludes, the external form of social organization characteristic of Web 2.0 is less technologically bound and more of a bottom-up activation of social media by groups of people who are not exclusively online communities but for whom the online experience is simply another lateral extension of an already existing social network. In his view, a potential for social and political change is located in embedded video practice (45).

Mroué's *The Pixelated Revolution* is connected to the Web 2.0 as Hershman's *Tillie* depended in the 1990s on the internet in a stage of transition. Their relationship to the internet does not mean that these video works could not be related to ongoing debates on moving images from the mid-1960s on. Both video projects can be positioned as descendants of "expanded cinema," a term coined by American filmmaker and artist Stan Vanderbeek in 1965, the year that later would be called the year of birth of video art. Media scholar Mark Bartlett clarifies that Vanderbeek's concept of expanded cinema had a meaning radically different from the

many other traditions now known by that term. It was formed by his early encounters with Information and Computing Technologies (in Rees et al. 2011, 50). Vanderbeek combined very diverse media, such as film, video, computer animation and graphics, pre-software punch-card computer programming, and (multiple-screen) projection. Bartlett concludes that Vanderbeek's shift from film per se to centers of mass-media dissemination would have had two main aims: to achieve the greatest communication reach and exposure, while attempting to invent audio-visual technologies specifically for social ends, for intercommunication (60). The term "expanded cinema," however, only became well known after Gene Youngblood formulated its criteria in his seminal book *Expanded Cinema* (1970). Film scholar A.L. Rees concludes that the overall vision in Youngblood's work basically came down to melting down all art forms into multimedia and live-action events; exploring electronic technologies and the coming of cyberspace, as heralded by Marshall McLuhan; and breaking down the barrier between artist and audience through new kinds of participation (2011, 13).

Artworks that need the spectator to be realized are called "interactive artworks." Mroué's video lecture assumes an audience of course, but only in works such as Hershman's *Tillie* do visitors really participate. What are the consequences when the object of research is no longer an autonomous artwork but an interactive artwork? This question is the focus of Katja Kwastek's study *Aesthetics of Interaction in Digital Art* (2013). Starting from actions and processes in interactive art, she establishes that this kind of art calls into question fundamental aesthetic categories (2013, 43). If for her analysis of actions and processes she applies theories from game studies (among other theories), she observes that interactive art clearly differs from games in the fact that interactive art challenges expectations, or even provokes disruptions and irritation, and uses different forms of self-referentiality, often aiming at making spectators aware of their own rules and structures (134, 139, 162). Moreover, whereas AI (Artificial Intelligence) research investigates relationships with face-to-face communication, artists scrutinize in particular how mediated interaction deviates from face-to-face communication (121).

In her profound analysis of particular characteristics of processes in interactive artworks, Kwastek notes that most works are constructed in such a way that the options for action can be deduced from the work itself. The spectator's action would mainly depend on experiences with similar works, resulting expectations, and willingness to take action. It is

interesting that Kwastek also pays attention to the fact that many visitors appear to limit their activity to observing others interacting with a project, thereby taking a distanced position to the work. According to her, sensual or cognitive comprehension can still take place in these situations, as a form of "vicarious interaction" (95).[6] It should be added here that even reading detailed descriptions of interactive artworks enables imagination of interaction, although this indirect experience can never be a substitute for the real experience of (vicarious) interaction.

As amply shown in the previous sections, interactive digital video installations are also tributary to many spatial experiments in video art from 1965 on. On the one hand, one could conclude that after the use of closed-circuit systems, the digitization led to a further dematerialization of interactive artworks. On the other, one can observe a renewed interest in physical presence. For instance, Hershman positioned a real doll at the center of her interactive project, suggesting the "re-animation" of the doll – a lifeless representation of a human being – by means of an internet community. And Mroué chose to be physically present to reflect on how "screen reality" and the "real world" are confused by the cell phone users in Syria. His lecture was recorded and the images he selected from the internet were inserted into this one-channel video, which was presented during the *Documenta* exhibition in 2012. The presentation of flipbooks and projections and sounds of shooting games in the adjacent room creating the atmosphere of a video game hall added a physical element to the exhibition form of the project. Interestingly, Mary Ann Doane, who in "The Location of the Image" describes the history of technologies for representation of movement as a transition from optical toy to cinema, from touch to sight, and from materiality to abstraction, starts her overview with flipbooks (in Douglas and Eamon 2009, 152–153). Yet, the above-discussed interest of artists in the physicality of projection screens basically demonstrates a search for video art's "re-materialization." This may also explain the fascination for nineteenth-century machinery among artists and scholars, as well as the new field of so-called "media archaeology." As new media theorist Jussi Parikka argues in *What is Media Archaeology?*, media archaeology has been keen to focus on the nineteenth century as the foundation stone of modernity in terms of science, technology, and the birth of media capitalism (2012, 2, 138). Parikka observes that a lot of media-archaeological work is executed in artistic ways. As an example of old media technology resurrected in the contemporary context, he mentions Lynn Hershman's *Conceiving Ada* (1997), which relates digital culture to the past heroine

of pre-computers and software Lady Ada Lovelace (1815–1852). Parikka defines media-archaeological art as artworks that learn from past media cultures in order to understand present mediated, globalized network culture (136, 138). Similarly, Mroué refers in his lecture to nineteenth-century theories on the workings of the eye and the history of lens-based media.

Another historical perspective to the renewed interest in materiality in digital image production is provided by Bolter and Grusin through the traditional metaphor of the window for a painting, introduced by Alberti in fifteenth-century Italy. They discuss two ways in which the distance between the viewer and the world outside the window has now been reduced: the viewer can pass through the window, which happens when wearing a Virtual Reality helmet and gloves; or the world can come up to the window or even through the window and surround the viewer. Computer graphics tend to press themselves against the window (Bolter and Grusin 2000 [1999], 235). The dramatic fate of the cell phone filmmakers, as described by Mroué, can also be related to the window metaphor. The victims looked at their cell phone screens as if looking through a window, similar to watching film or television, or associated the frontal confrontation unconsciously with computer games, experiencing the sniper as pressing against the window. What in fact literally happened was that the bullet passed through their real window, turning the mediated reality into fatal reality. For decades we were warned not to confuse media with reality, but now, when used to being aware of media as mediation, Mroué warns us to keep alert for the real world "in" it.

Kate Mondloch, who in *Screens* draws attention to media screens that have pervaded contemporary life, aims to bridge the use of traditional and ultramodern screens. But toward the end of her chapter on computer screens, Mondloch comes to the conclusion that the appropriate allegory for the digital media screen is not the virtual window of the painting but an automatic sliding glass door (2010, 88, 89). In much the same way as the regulation automatic glass doors at an airport or supermarket, any activity can inadvertently open or close the screen's connectivity, and there exists a certain ambiguity as to which side of the door/screen has instigated the action. The digital sliding door, however, cannot create direct body-to-body contact. Hersman's *Tillie* demonstrates clearly what Mondloch means with the curious condition that external viewers (at home behind their computer screen) may never really know if an environment represented on their screen is an actual remote locale or not, even when it is (92).

Even more complex layers are added to Tillie when we realize that she is part of *The Dollie Clones*, two telerobotic humanoids called Tillie and CybeRoberta. When they are exhibited together, each is programmed to pirate the other's information, blurring their individual identities. A few months after the first cloned sheep named Dolly was announced to the public, Hershman had created the two telerobotic dolls. When pirating each other's identity, the dolls make the viewer aware of issues of identity theft and the hidden dangers inherent in surveillance technologies (Tromble 2005, 89). Hershman shares this interest with many other contemporary artists, as demonstrated in *CTRL [Space]: Rhetorics of Surveillance from Bentham to Big Brother* (Levin, Frohne, and Weibel 2002).

Abigail Solomon-Godeau notes that if the power of the look – the power to look – is conventionally attributed to men, who also have wielded the means of visual representation, the female dolls Tillie and CybeRoberta seem to be in charge of looking now, but the cameras in their eyes are controlled from external places by unknown powers (in Tromble 2005, 128). Solomon-Godeau's focus on the power to look in relation to social hierarchies leads us to Claire Bishop's fourth modality of experiencing installation art, which is Activated Spectatorship. In 2005 Bishop observed that recent writings by critics and artists about installation art suggested that the viewer's active presence within the work is more political and ethical in implication than when viewing more traditional types of art. The term "political" here particularly means, according to Bishop, to generate communication between visitors who are present in the space (2005, 102). This type of work conceives of its viewing subject as part of a collective or community. This characterization is applicable to Hershman's and Mroué's works: the former work connects visitors in the internet community to visitors of the gallery, and the latter artist, through his presence as lecturer, becomes part of the present community, but also makes his public aware that they are part of the same internet community in which the victims participate(d).

In relationship to new media, Activated Spectatorship has become a discussion on the perception of new electronic media as disembodied, or on the possibility of a new embodiment: how the body is modified through interactions facilitated by digital technology (Hansen 2006 [2004], xv–xx). Particularly video works that are part of so-called "digital performances" could be called embodied events. For instance, British artist Susan Collins's *In Conversation* (1997) consisted of a projected mouth on the pavement that talked to people passing by. These speech acts were initiated by online participants through typed messages

(reacting on recordings by the surveillance camera), to which the street participants could react directly (Wesdorp 2011). The new trend of "augmented reality (AR) art" shares some characteristics with digital performances, but it is specific to this art – as art historian Christine Ross explains – that in its augmented reality, projections of virtual spaces are combined with experiences of the real world, creating a real-virtual continuum. She adds that in most AR artworks projection is used for the sake of connectivity: the interactivity between users and between users and machines, which would imply the formation of communities. One of her examples is French artist Mathieu Briand, who devised for some of his installations head-mounted display devices to be worn by users who can then click on a button to swap instantaneously their views of the environment with other participants, seeing as it were through the eyes of the other. The visitor thus sees his or her environment through the visor, as well as private views of the other helmeted visitors circulating elsewhere in the same space at the same time (in Trodd 2011, 184–205).

Briand's AR artworks are based on twenty-first-century high tech, but do not differ dramatically from Hershman's *Tillie* of the mid-1990s. The media art spectatorship defined by Oliver Grau as being in various places simultaneously is applicable to both works: telepresence and teleaction enable the user to be present at the same time in the spatio-temporal location determined by the user's body, through teleperception in the simulated, virtual image space, and by means of teleaction in the place where, for example, a robot is situated that is directed by one's own movements (2003 [2001], 285). According to Grau, what he calls "Telepresence art" has more to do with telecommunication than with immersive environments such as virtual reality (271).

This chapter has revealed close interactions between various forms of video installation and different types of installation art that are related by Bishop and Rosenthal to diverse experiences of spectators. However, video installations proved to be even more complex than installation art consisting of objects. My argument was designed to underline that video installations relate to the physical space of the spectator in one way or another – through TV sets, additional objects, spatial screens, cameras, architecture as support, or physical presence of the artist – while at the same time present virtual spaces through immaterial images and sound that add an additional and other experiences of space, a combination that appears to play a constructive role in the production of meanings. My discussion of Lynn Hershman's *Tillie*, which as a case study recurred

throughout the chapter, demonstrated that in the enormous variety of video works addressed some characteristics in spatial concepts seemed more related to each other than initially expected. As became clear, most spatial characteristics contribute to the viewer's heightened awareness of strategies of visual mediation in both art and daily life.

Notes

1 Catherine Elwes quoted the artist Steve Hawley in Rees et al. 2011, 202.
2 See my book *Zen in the Fifties* (1996) for more on the interest of artists in Zen in the 1950s.
3 Human presence can also be inserted in installation art by photography. See my essay "The Concept of Place in Photography in Multimedia Artworks" (in Westgeest 2009, 97–130).
4 Some authors consider Minimal Art of the late 1960s to be the origin of those video installations that consist of rectangular screens that the spectator has to move around and through to make sense of the work. The components of the Minimal Art works, however, do not draw attention to themselves, as each video screen does.
5 Birgit Hopfener, in her essay on Chinese video installations "Responsive Wirklichkeitsverhältnisse: Chinesische Bewegtbild-Installationen im transkulturellen Kontext" (in Frohne and Haberer 2012, 197–217), proposes to investigate non-Western installation art in a transcultural context as "Third Space," a term used by post-colonial theorist Homi Bhabha in *Location of Culture* (1994) to indicate spaces of transformation, reflection, and intervention. Her conclusions with regard to Chinese video art will be addressed in Chapter 3.
6 Golan Levin used this concept in an interview with Kwastek. The concept was borrowed from educational science and denotes a cognitive comprehension of others' interactions.

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3

Moving Images Mediating as Contemplative Images: *Video's Challenge of Photography, Drawing, and Painting*

Video is only recognizable when the presented image is changing. If it does not, while being projected on some surface or presented on a monitor, it might as well be a photograph (a slide or digital photograph) or a digitally produced "painting." Many contemporary video works in fact seem to address the boundaries between video and photography or painting. The digitization of video in the early 1990s increased the range of options in manipulation, and made video look more like the constructed image in painting. But also today's photography and video – both lens-based media, reproduction technologies, and digital media – have much in common in how they represent their subject.

This chapter is devoted to a comparative approach of the relationship between video on the one hand and the interrelated static visual media of photography, drawing, and painting on the other. The main question focuses on how modes of representation in several selected video works relate and react to such modes in photography, painting, and drawing: how do views on representation implied in these various still media provide insights into video art?

The first section of this chapter deals with representational issues in video works that look like photographs. Although video and photography are lens-based media expected to record the referent in front of the camera, we have reason to doubt whether the images we perceive are just a visual trace of what was in front of the lens, or if the images were manipulated in one way or another or even "created." This section investigates

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how analysis of photography-like video works combined with comparative study of ways of representation in moving images and photography enhances our understanding of these works.

The last section of this chapter dwells on comparisons between video and painting. Some multi-channel videos clearly echo the tradition of triptych paintings. The influence of painting on video is even more evident in videos that directly refer to famous paintings or in "abstract" videos that consist of light and color compositions. In particular the recent tendency to present video on flat LCD screens on white cube exhibition walls seems to underline video's connection to "photorealistic" paintings more than before. This section thus provides insights into the various ways in which the selected video works relate to representational aspects in painting.

A section on comparative research of video's links to drawing serves to bridge the sections that focus on video's ties to photography and painting. A major interconnection of video, photography, and drawing pertains to their immediacy, while they also share a past as black-and-white medium. Yet, on the other hand, the creative processes in drawing and painting rather suggest a correspondence with manipulated video. Although in this section I will not discuss theories of animation film as such, some of my case studies draw on the combined traditions of drawing, animation, and video games. My concern with the issue of representation in this section will mainly center on particular views on the medium of drawing and their contribution to our understanding of video works that relate to drawing in one way or another.

The three media I use in this chapter as basis for comparison with video have in common that their final product is a static object. The videos commonly associated with these media are therefore the ones characterized by extreme slowness. On account of this feature, according to writer and artist David Campany, such video works evoke the traditional sense of "presence" typical of art's materially fixed media, such as painting, sculpture, and photography, all of which give priority to depiction rather than to re-creation of movement (2008, 39).

In the previous chapter I compared the perception and presentation of video art with those of television and spatial arts. With regard to the focus of this chapter, philosopher Boris Groys's reflection on museum visits is most relevant. As Groys has suggested, spectators in a traditional museum setting have complete control over the duration of their contemplation: they can interrupt contemplation at any time to come back

to it later; after all, in the period of their absence, the motionless image remains identical to itself (in Frieling and Herzogenrath 2006, 50). In life, we tend to be accidental witnesses of events, whose duration we cannot control in most instances. This is why our perception of art, according to Groys, starts from our wish to hold onto the moment, to let it linger for a time, preferably for a sustained period if not forever. This situation has changed drastically in museum settings with the introduction of moving images, for they dictate the time needed to view them. The visitor no longer knows what to do: should one stop and watch them closely until the end or watch for a while then continue moving through, hoping that over time they will change little if at all (51)? Most of the video works discussed in this chapter seem to resolve this dilemma: they hardly change over time.

Another characteristic of the objectness of drawings and paintings pertains to the artistic freedom when it comes to decisions about their size and proportions. In this respect, the TV set, on which early videos were presented, and the film screen started from a fixed ratio. Varieties in sizes were limited. Photo cameras (both analog and digital) also produce standard sizes and ratios of images, but these can be changed in the process of printing. The size and ratio of drawings and paintings have always been flexible. Yet after the completion of these artifacts the situation is reversed: drawings and paintings (and some photographs) have a fixed size, whereas with video it is no longer uncommon to see the same work presented in another exhibition in another size. A related issue is the verticality or horizontality of pictures. As the histories of painting, drawing, and photography reveal, there has been a preference for the vertical format of, for instance, portraits, still lifes of flowers, and buildings, while horizontal formats have been common for landscapes, group portraits, and events. Only recently, however, has it become possible to produce video art in vertical format.

The fact that all video works discussed in this chapter "include" another artistic medium makes one wonder whether terms such as "intermedia," "mixed media," or "multimedia" are at all appropriate to cover these various works. The first term was coined by the artist Dick Higgins in 1966, who argued that "much of the best work being produced today seems to fall between media" (1984, 18). He mentions, for instance, Allan Kaprow's happenings, but he does not clearly delineate intermedia as a concept. Yvonne Spielmann defines this notion more specifically in her essay "Intermedia in Electronic Images" as a category of media arts

in which elements of differing media images are combined and transformed to cause a shift in the notion of the whole image (2001, 55). She starts from the topical debates of intermedia in which this phenomenon is described as crossing boundaries between various traditional media; Spielmann extends this field to include how analog and digital media result in new forms of media art. She defines the difference between intermedia, mixed media, and multimedia by suggesting that intermedia deals with the interrelationship between or among distinct media that merge with each other, whereas the term multimedia should be applied in the case of the synchronous occurrence of different art forms within an integral medium (such as theater) that at the same time remain distinct from each other (56, 57). The notion of mixed media is useful, in her view, for works that incorporate elements of one medium in another (e.g. the use of photography in film), but without the occurrence of any (formal) transformation in either one. In the category of intermedia the different media elements also remain recognizable, while, according to Spielmann, the processes of transformation as result of the collision are reflected in the images (56). At the end of this chapter I will evaluate whether the term intermedia, as defined by Spielmann, is applicable to my case studies. For now, I would like to mention that Spielmann, in her recent essay "The Visual Flow: Fixity and Transformation in Photo- and Videographic Imagery," discusses transformation and processuality both as characteristics of video and intermedia (2013, 108). She demonstrates that video experiments since the 1970s have transgressed and expanded the characteristics of a single medium, claiming that video did in fact pioneer intermedia.

Although this book does not address the historiography of video art, the theory of the medium is related to its history, not least in the perception of the beholder who associates, consciously or unconsciously, an artwork with a familiar category of images. In the first chapter video art was discussed as a revolutionary phenomenon in the history of television and other electronic media. Video performances, however, tend to be considered part of the development in art history toward conceptualization and ephemeral works, whereas video installations are more commonly associated with spatial arts. Regarding the focus of this chapter, it is interesting that Martha Rosler has associated video art with avant-garde art movements such as Dada and Surrealism, as well as the nineteenth-century growth of the mass press and technologies of reproduction such as photography (in Hall and Fifer 1990 [1985], 34). Regarding the latter she notes that by the turn of the twentieth century photography was

well established as a rational and representational form, not only of private life and public spectacles, but as implicated in official and unofficial technologies of social control. In other words, photography and video – which has taken over many of these roles – are not just related as lens-based media; they are also used in similar ways (37).

The subsequent sections of this chapter develop the argument of how views on representation associated with photography, drawing, and painting can be linked to video artworks. In general terms, the visual communication scholar Keith Kenney, in "Representation Theory," has defined "representation" as how signs mediate (stand for or take the place of) something from the real world in the mind of a person (2005, 99). Kenney discusses four types of theories of how images represent: causal relation theories, resemblance theories, convention theories, and mental construction theories. The video works selected for this chapter not only represent their subject but also "represent" another medium, two processes which could be related to some of these types of theories, but which will not be done explicitly in this chapter, however. In *Representation* cultural theorist Stuart Hall also starts with a definition of representation as "stand in place of and for," but he discerns three different approaches: the reflective, intentional, and constructionist approach to representation (2013 [1997], 1). The first one deals with representing what already exists; the second focuses on the intention of the producer of the representation; and the third addresses constructions of meanings in language/images, which is a focus in particular in semiotics and discourse analysis. The authors in *Representation* mainly deal with the latter perspective, with discourse analysis concerned with the effects and consequences of representation. In the first two case studies presented below I will touch upon this to relate the contents with the medium, but for my analyses of how the video works selected here represent another medium next to their subject I will draw interchangeably (albeit implicitly rather than explicitly) on Hall's three approaches.

Kudzanai Chiurai's *Iyeza* (2012) Juxtaposed to Thierry Kuntzel's *Été – double vue* (1988)

In 2012 at *Documenta 13* in Kassel, Zimbabwean-born multimedia artist Kudzanai Chiurai, who lives in Johannesburg, presented his large moving



Figure 3.1 Kudzanai Chiurai, *Iyeza*, 2012. One-channel digital video, color, sound, 11 minutes. © Kudzanai Chiurai, courtesy of the artist.



Figure 3.2 Thierry Kuntzel, *Été – double vue*, 1988. One screen of the two-channel video installation, color, no sound, two 7 minutes loops. All rights reserved.

picture *Iyeza* (2012) (Figure 3.1). The work was shown on a wall opposite one that presented a large *tableau*-like photograph with the same title, actually a still image taken from the moving image.[1] As a result of the technical improvements of beamers, a dark room is no longer needed for the projection of images, making it possible to exhibit large-size videos in the same room as photographs and paintings. Both versions of *Iyeza* show a scene of people grouped around a table. The video images hardly change: the video was shot with a high speed HD (high definition) camera in only eight seconds and extended to eleven minutes. The opposite presentation of the video and photograph emphasizes the photo-like qualities of the video, but also demonstrates that development of movements over some seconds in slow motion is experienced differently from a frozen moment.

Both images evoke associations with *The Last Supper* (ca. 1495–1498) by Leonardo da Vinci. It is not only the compositional likeness with this famous picture that relates *Iyeza* to the medium of painting, however. The decorated flat background and the ordering of the people behind and before the table on a shallow stage makes the photograph in particular look like a *tableau vivant*, a composition of people on a theater stage often depicting a famous painting.

Chiurai used the theme of the Last Supper as allegory to depict the establishment of a new nation-state ("Iyeza" means "coming" in Zulu), juxtaposing the past and the present of a continent in the grip of violent civil wars.[2] Some actors are involved in an argument, as in Leonardo's painting, but others engage in more violent acts. On the left side, someone is actually shot to death in an elongated split second. In the foreground, a medicine man and his burning candle capture the attention of two superstitious women. The slowly "moving painting" is accompanied by a song – presented through headphones – based on a composition of the South-African singer Thandiswa, after which the work is also named.

By relating the conflicts in Africa to the "superiority" of European art history, *Iyeza* draws the attention of the Western spectators to Europe's historical involvement in Africa, including Christianization as a powerful instrument. As sociologist Myriam-Odile Blin has argued in her essay "African Video Art. War, Dreams, and Freedom," in Europe and the US video has often functioned as an experimental art form concerned with exploration of the medium itself, while in African video art the political context strongly influenced the contents of video works. Artists are facing situations where violence, lack of freedom, and poverty are so intensely present that it seems impossible not to engage them (in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 326). One may also argue that violence and primitive behavior (superstition) are part of stereotyping African black people in the West (Hall 2013 [1997], Chapter 4), and that Chiurai draws attention to that through artificial, extremely slow movements.

Although French artist Thierry Kuntzel's two-channel installation *Été – double vue* [Summer – Double View] (1988) relates to both painting and photography as well, while also addressing representations of black males through video, the intermedial relationships lie in different aspects. A striking characteristic of this installation is the contrast between the two moving images facing each other in a darkened room. Regarding the scale of the screens, Kuntzel wrote in his notes: "1 the smallest possible

HD video screen; 2 the largest possible 16 or 35 mm movie screen" (in Duguet 2006, 584). The seven-minute loop presents a slowly moving "close-up tracking shot" of a nude black male on the large screen and a static "long shot view" of the room in which this male figure reclines on a divan on the small screen (Figure 3.2). The image of the room is dominated by three grand arches in the room's far wall. This archway frames a landscape. A woman approaches the room from a distance, sits in the doorway, and finally departs across the foreground of the image.

The title of the installation refers to a painting by the seventeenth-century French artist Nicholas Poussin. A photographic reproduction of this painting in a book is visible on the nude male's lap, which is covered with a red cloth that looks like a cloth in the painting. The reclining figure calls forth Titian's famous painting *Venus of Urbino* (1538) and Édouard Manet's equally famous *Olympia* (1864), which was inspired by Titian's painting and in which he changed the woman in the background into a black woman in a period in which the laws on slavery were under discussion in France. In his notes on *Été*, Kuntzel mentions some more painters as source of inspiration. He relates the reading model and miniature format to Balthus, and the couch, fabric, and dressing gown to Henri Matisse (in Duguet 2006, 584–585).

As noticed by film scholar Maureen Turim, the figures in *Été* act less as actors than as models, with obvious reference to the history of art, but also to photography. The work of Ansel Adams, Paul Strand, and Robert Mapplethorpe figures intertextually, while the male model in *Été*, Ken Moody, even figured as one of Mapplethorpe's most oft-photographed subjects (in Renov and Suderburg 1996, 36).

Poussin's painting *Été* depicts the biblical story of Boaz's encounter with Ruth in the foreground of a wheat field landscape. How is it possible to relate Kuntzel's work to the contents of Poussin's painting? New media scholar Timothy Murray, in *Like a Film: Ideological Fantasy on Screen, Camera, and Canvas*, interpreted Kuntzel's video installation by considering Poussin's *Été* as its source (1993, 11–12). Murray notes a connection in Boaz's initial gesture of generosity by declaring his fields something of a "sex-free zone" where Ruth can be safe from the threat of molestation by his men and those of his neighbor. This observation corresponds to the relationship between the male and female figure in Kuntzel's *Été*, which is called "ambiguous" by Turim. The woman moves to the foreground, where she looks at the man, who is preoccupied and oblivious to her presence, as if the two occupy different spaces. The models are mute in their interaction, "as figures in painting must be" (in Renov and

Suderburg 1996, 38). Turim also draws attention to the set of two images that can be seen as forming a highly displaced shot versus a reverse shot (in French *champs-contre-champs*). There is no cutting in of the scene that would give us a close-up of the gaze of the woman. Instead, the close-up of the man's skin provides a reverse shot not from her point of view, but from that of the spectators on the scene (39).

As with Chiurai's *Iyeza*, it is possible to relate Kuntzel's *Été* to the representational practice of stereotyping black males, in this case the black nude as erotic and aesthetic object (Hall 2013 [1997], Chapter 4). Whereas in traditional painting the white female model played that role (for instance in paintings of Titian and Manet), in various more recent ad campaigns and Mapplethorpe's photographs the black nude male has adopted it. Stuart Hall discusses strategies to intervene in the field of representation, to contest "negative" images through trans-coding, such as presenting positive images and contesting representation from within (2013 [1997], 260–264). His comment on the latter approach seems applicable to Kuntzel's *Été*: "Since black people have so often been fixed, stereotypically, by the racialized gaze, it may have been tempting to refuse the complex emotions associated with 'looking'." But he adds that "this strategy makes elaborate play with 'looking,' hoping by its very attention, to 'make it strange,' that is to de-familiarize it, and so make explicit what is often hidden, its erotic dimensions" (264). By using the slowly moving close-up tracking shot of the time-based medium of video, the video installation's opposite screens, the detailed way of recording of lens-based media, and the endless invitation to continue looking through presentation as loops, Kuntzel trans-codes the "erotic" gaze at nudes and sexuality as contents in painting and photography.

The deliberate confrontation of the static visual arts with a time-based medium, which is a crucial issue in both *Iyeza* and *Été*, hardly involves a new phenomenon. Already in the first half of the twentieth century producers of art documentaries struggled with cinematic visualizations of artworks. Art historian Steven Jacobs describes art documentaries in *Framing Pictures: Film and the Visual Arts* as investigations of the boundaries of film that zoom in on movement versus stasis, narrative versus iconic images, and cinematic space versus pictorial surface (2011, x). Quite similar complexities are observed by Jacobs in the use of *tableau-vivant*-like compositions in films and in the production of publicity film stills. *Iyeza* and *Été* and the other key works discussed in this chapter strikingly differ from art documentaries, and vary from recorded

tableau-vivants and film stills, but Jacobs's observations are certainly relevant for this chapter's recurring theme, the tension between movement and stasis.

Video Art and Photography

Video, photography, and film are all lens-based media. As a result, they share several main characteristics: the mechanical apparatus of the camera records the light reflections in front of it that transcend the lens, to be fixed on the tape/film/chip in the body of the camera. Discussions about

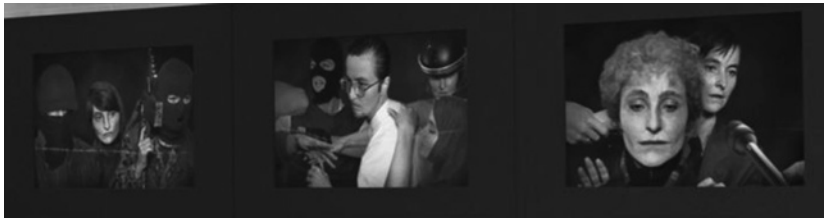


Figure 3.3 Ute Friederike Jürss, *You Never Know the Whole Story*, 2000. Three-channel digital video, black-and-white, no sound, 10 minutes. © Ute Friederike Jürss c/o Pictoright Amsterdam 2014, courtesy of the artist.



Figure 3.4 Gillian Wearing, *Sixty Minute Silence* (video still), 1996. Color video for projection with sound, 60 minutes. © Gillian Wearing, courtesy Maureen Paley, London.

photographic aspects in cinema mainly concentrate on freeze frames,[3] film stills, film frames, and the crucial role of photographs as object in some feature films. Raymond Bellour's "The Pensive Spectator" (1984) is a seminal text regarding this issue. In this essay Bellour analyzes the effects of still images in film on its perception (2007 [1984], 120–123). A spectator will experience the still, be it in the form of a freeze frame or a filmed photograph, as a pause in the flow. At these moments, according to Bellour, the spectator begins to find time to add to the image. The spectator starts to reflect differently on cinema. Yet the film does not permit the spectator to add to the image, because it does not afford him or her enough time to do so. Thus the still images in film create, in the words of Bellour, a pensive spectator. This observation should be understood as an elaboration of literary theorist Roland Barthes's contemplation on "the still" in cinema in "The Third Meaning" (1977). Barthes even claimed that, paradoxically, the filmic cannot be grasped in the film "in movement," but only in the still (1977, 65). Different from Bellour, Barthes discusses *photogrammes* (film frames), which are the singular images on the film strip projected at a speed of twenty-four per second onto the film screen, a context that sets them apart from the simple straight photograph.

In the cases discussed by Bellour and Barthes, the relationship between photography and cinema only shows up in a still fragment of a film. Commonly, video art that relates to photography or comes across as a photograph at first sight does not restrict this relationship to fragments. But since there is hardly any literature about video art that relates to photography, my argument in this section, aside from drawing on visual research by video artists and essays about their work, mainly relies on theories of photography and comparative approaches of photography and film.[4]

An insightful example of photography-like video art is German artist Ute Friederike Jürss's three-channel video installation *You Never Know the Whole Story* (2000), in which digital compositing is used to produce moving images that look like a series of blown-up black-and-white newspaper photographs (Figure 3.3). The artist selected images from the *New York Times*, but the three large screens do not present human figures who are frozen by a photo camera: the figures appear to stand still for about ten minutes (and apparently endlessly as a result of the looping), "representing" the news snapshots. The only sense of time passing that can be

experienced is through the slight wavering and trembling of the figures, and the occasional blink of an eye.

What do these images actually represent? The three "news photographs" (both the original ones and the video copies) present people in diverse extreme situations, but the images do not inform us about what exactly is happening and where. Who are those people? And who are the victims and who the perpetrators? The title of the installation, as claimed by Ursula Frohne, addresses our limited view of current events, which invariably remains fragmentary in spite of the ubiquity and speed of the media, and never quite succeeds in bridging the gap between the visible and invisible (Frohne 2000, 14). It is only clear that one is looking at videos of human beings who do their utmost to "live the situation." In fact, we are only looking at the artist herself experiencing the situations on her own. Frohne explains that Jürss, when seeing the news photos, wondered why these photographs in particular interested her so much (16). This question calls forth Roland Barthes's contemplations on press photos, which he added as captions to the reproductions of those images in his *Camera Lucida* (1981 [1980]). Jürss reacted in a more complicated way. She transposed the scenes in the photographs step by step into the medium of video. With the aid of a make-up artist, she transformed herself into each of the figures, thereby literally "entering" the image. After having been filmed in the still positions, the press images were reconstructed as videos with the aid of special effects software used in technologically advanced Hollywood productions (Frohne 2000, 18). Jürss seems to demonstrate that even putting yourself literally in someone's position cannot bring you closer to the drama that takes place in a press photo. Frohne conveys that Jürss illuminates the structural and ideological aspects of the media in terms of their ambivalent relationship to reality, and that the artist addresses the impact of a visual rhetoric with which we are permanently confronted, consciously or not (16). Film scholar Mary Ann Doane agrees with that conclusion, calling the verisimilitude the piece strives for and critically interrogates a form of "media realism," which is meant to refer to our trust in newspaper photography (in Green and Lowry 2006, 33–34). Media theorist Thomas Y. Levin's analysis of the work leads to a similar outcome, but he particularly stresses that the insistence in the three projections that one never knows the whole story perhaps indicates that there never was a whole about which a story or "the" story could have been told. If previously the rhetoric of photo-chemical indexicality helped maintain the fiction of the possibility of both a story and that

whole, now it requires "a trio of quivering heterochronic projections to tell the 'you never know the whole' story" (in Leighton 2008, 474).

Through the medium of video, then, Jürss critically comments in particular on representation in news photos. In *The Spoken Image: Photography and Language* (1999), literary scholar Clive Scott has profoundly analyzed news photography. Scott states that we can only think of war crimes if we can think of bereaved individuals, trials, and war criminals in docks (1999, 103). So the news photo is a powerful weapon in that process of "personalization," which is an important factor in the assessment of news values. Moreover, news comes to us as interpretation, and often as an interpretation of an interpretation, when the already implicitly interpreted is overlaid by an explicit interpretation, the editorial voice of the caption. Scott conveys that the caption transforms a "real" event into a newspaper event, and calls it the voice of news-digestion (106). In his view, news photos do not tend to be significant as such; rather, they are emblematic, or representative: they have the task of establishing a news item – authenticating it instead of depicting it. We can read the sequence of photographs in a newspaper as a shorthand or *aide-mémoire* for the current state of the news, which we have probably seen more fully reported in pictures on TV. The news photographs demonstrate that one is always too late to participate, prevent, or to indulge one's voyeuristic urges in the actual (114, 115). The characteristics of news photos listed by Scott are foregrounded in Jürss's video work through the demonstration that these news photos deprived from their captions evoke many questions, and that even Jürss's "strenuous embodiments" did not bring her closer to the people in the photograph and what happened to them. Her translation in video could only animate the frozen figures. Jürss's silent video series confirms Roy Armes's observation that just as news photos need captions and silent cinema needed intertitles, so too the images of a video tape need sound to remove their basic ambiguity (1988, 172–173).

In some ways Jürss's silent video work is reminiscent of a *tableau vivant*. Commonly, this age-old tradition involves an imitation of a famous artwork – most often a painting – by costumed individuals who do not move throughout the duration of the display. They freeze the action of a selected painting (and hence in the *tableau vivant*) at a moment of heightened meaning, a point at which the gestures express the full significance and all the implications of the story (Jacobs 2012 [2011], 88). But for her work, Jürss rather chose infamous news photos with ambiguous meanings. Another characteristic of a *tableau vivant* is that it translates the

painting's flatness, its two-dimensionality, into a three-dimensional setting. Jürss, however, posed for each depicted figure herself, while her compilation again involved a two-dimensional projection.

What does the literature about moving images in relationship to photography offer us regarding these kinds of hybrid moving-still images? In the introduction to their anthology *Still Moving: Between Cinema and Photography*, film scholars Karen Beckman and Jean Ma state that their volume in general argues for the impossibility of watching movement without simultaneously watching stasis and the media that produce these effects (2008, 5). Particularly the hesitation between stasis and motion would produce an interval in which rigorous thinking can emerge (10). Their case studies, however, do not seem useful in relation to the video works in this section. More relevant is art historian Joanna Lowry's essay "Portraits, Still Video Portraits and the Account of the Soul" in *Stillness and Time: Photography and the Moving Image* (2006), which focuses on the relationship between time, technology, and the self. This focus is central to recent practices in photographic and time-based arts, particularly in the phenomenon of the "still" video portrait, whereby the subject poses as if for a studio photograph and is filmed for any length of time, from a few seconds to an hour or more (2006, 69). Recent examples of the genre include work by Gillian Wearing, Sam Taylor-Wood, Rineke Dijkstra, Thomas Struth, and Fiona Tan. This type of work takes on all the conventions of the still photograph as its framing discourse, but extends it in time, refusing the resolution of the still image and preserving the temporality of the pose (69). Lowry claims that while having historical precedents in experimental film work of the 1960s and in the work of that era's performance artists concerned with ideas of real time, duration, and endurance, there is a strong case for situating this more recent set of experiments within discussions about photography. The adoption of a fixed camera position, the conventions of the head and shoulder portrait or group portrait, and the carefully composed presentation of the subject to the camera all indicate an attempt to delineate a space that is recognizably "photographic." This is a practice that seeks to use the available technology to stretch or extend the photograph to its limit, through a testing of the idea of the pose as a kind of performance (72). Lowry concludes that video portraits offer us a new enchantment with the provisionality and fragility of the pose, and with the alternation between absorption and performance that is central to our understanding of the self (78).

Another possible conclusion is that photographs give us the illusion that time can be halted, whereas video portraits annul that illusion and

demonstrate that we can only control the time of recording by the camera and the duration of posing. Gillian Wearing developed the performance of posing to an extreme in her video portrait *Sixty Minute Silence* (1996) (Figure 3.4). For this work, she brought together police officers (actually actors) that seem to be posing for a group portrait, but she asked them to hold still for an hour in front of her video camera. Consequently, a split-second shot is replaced by sixty minutes of stiff posing, or, in fact, of acting as if posing for a photo camera. The only signs of movement are the officers' inevitable sniffing, trembling, and yelps of relief when the hour is up. *Silver Lining* (2011) by Swiss artist Bettina Disler is somewhat related to these "video portraits," but at the same time her video is quite different. Six people – three women and three men – are arranged around a table, all of them facing the viewer. During the full eleven minutes all models, except for one, are frozen as in a photograph, yet they take turns in unfreezing and expressing thoughts about their expectations of a future partner. The transition from still to moving image seems to represent the stereotype of the "frozen" single, who "unfreezes" merely by the thought of some ideal love partner ("the silver lining") (Langenbach 2013, 67).

The various "video portraits" discussed are to some extent related to what visual theorist Johanna Drucker calls "temporal photography" in her similarly entitled 2010 essay. Being a video, the temporal portrait photograph adds not only contexts to the frozen moment of the still photo portrait but also provides insights into the process of posing, which turns the temporal photograph into an epistemological event (2010, 24). Her most relevant example is a series of video portraits made in 2007 by the American artist Scott Kildall. In two-minute sections these video portraits present the facial gestures of people getting ready to have their picture taken, demonstrating that they have internalized the idea of "the photograph" as a final event, and this elucidates the radical incompleteness of the photographic image (22, 23). In fact, these video portraits reflect on the act of "posing," defined by Drucker as self-constructed projection of self into image (23). A video about posing for a photograph reveals different issues, however, when the subject is translated into an Islamic cultural context. This becomes clear in Syrian artist Samir Barkawi's video *Poster* (2004). This video of less than one minute presents three girls taking pictures of each other. Their heavy veiling prevents us from recognizing who is who. Art historian Charlotte Bank interprets the work as dealing with the conflict between contemporary individualism and traditional notions of female modesty (2008, 18).

In a way, the subtle and complex difference between "video portraits" and "photo portraits" is related to our set of expectations in relation to posing in photography and acting in cinema. David Campany starts his discussion on the photographic aspects of film stills in "Posing, Acting, Photography" by discussing the binary of acting versus posing (2006, 98). He observes that acting is usually associated with something unfolding in time like cinema or theater, while posing rather suggests the stillness of photography and painting. Although it is possible to think of examples that complicate this opposition, as in scenes of arrest such as the *tableau vivant* in theater or cinema's close-up of a face in pensive contemplation, acting does tend to be linked to movement and posing to stillness. In this respect, Campany discusses Cindy Sherman's photo series *Untitled Film Stills* (1977–1980), wondering whether in these self-portraits Sherman poses or acts, or acts as if posing or poses as if acting. For an answer he refers initially to art critic Craig Owens who pointed out the similarity between posing and the nature of photography: "I freeze as if anticipating the still I am about to become" (quoted in Campany 2006, 107). An important reason why Sherman's self-portraits seem to look more like acting than posing, however, appears to relate to the absence of a sense of frontality in these photographs. This ignoring of the presence of the camera is reminiscent of classical narrative cinema (107–108).

Campany has further nuanced the discussion of the differences between film and photography in his 2008 textbook *Photography and Cinema*. Among other things he discusses Andy Warhol's *Screen Tests* (1964–1966), single-take short films of friends and celebrities who remained before his 16mm movie camera for about four minutes. Unsure as to quite what the *Screen Tests* were, Warhol toyed with calling them Living Portrait Boxes, Film Portraits or even "Stillies" (Campany 2008, 17). Warhol's *Screen Tests* shift back and forth between posing and acting. Conversely, the video portraits by Wearing, Disler, and Kildall are clearly about posing. Even Jürss's video work in which she as a model ignores the presence of the camera uses posing as a strategy to interrogate the ambiguity of straight news photos.

In the previous two chapters I discussed the closed-circuit video system, first in its ability to give immediate feedback and next in its relationship with the space of the viewer. Regarding the focus of this section, the static image produced by some closed-circuit video works is worth addressing in more detail. An intriguing example is Nam June Paik's *TV Buddha* (1974). A meditative Buddha sculpture is facing his own image

on a TV screen that is recorded by the video camera above the monitor. Wulf Herzogenrath observes that precisely because Paik uses a time-based medium, the meditation looks even more static. As viewers, we may even wonder whether we perceive a moving or static image projection. Only when we pass behind the sculpture is movement added to the screen. In this way it is the spectator who turns the static image into a moving image (in Herzogenrath and Decker 1989, 48).

We should not forget, of course, that the history of cinema has its own tradition of various uses of the "long take" – for instance in Yasujiro Ozu's films – which appear to resolve the difference between film and a photograph of a static object, but in these films the contrasting moving images before and after the still image are essential for the function of the long take. In "Possessive, Pensive and Possessed," Victor Burgin uses the example of the long take to nuance the logic of assigning the still image to photography theory and the moving image to film theory (2006, 171). A film may depict an immobile object even while the film strip itself is moving at twenty-four frames per second; a photograph may depict a moving object even though the photograph does not move. Subsequently he claims that it is not movement as such that fascinates most people, but purposive movement, movement with causes and consequences. In fact, what audiences find most interesting about characters on the screen are not their movements but their acts. Burgin's observation may explain the tension in Jürss's video work: we miss purposive movement rather than movement per se.

Steven Jacobs (2012 [2011], 116) deals from another perspective with the tension between still and moving. He describes the problematic confrontation when a painting is set into motion by means of cinematic devices in art documentaries, because the illusion of movement the painter skillfully created is thus lost. Likewise, a *tableau vivant* in film does not so much animate the painting, but petrifies or mortifies it. Translated to Jürss's work, this means that her videos mortify the suggested movement in the photographs: when we look at a photograph we assume that the people we see in fact continued to move and were halted only by the recording of the camera, but the videos present the people clearly as petrified.

One of the most oft-mentioned examples with regard to the tension between film's and photography's representation of movement appears to be Canadian artist Michael Snow's forty-five-minute analog film *Wavelength* (1966–1967), created in the same period that Warhol

produced his short films. Gene Youngblood already discussed this work in detail in his groundbreaking 1970 text *Expanded Cinema*. *Wavelength* presents for the whole length of the film a photograph of foaming sea waves hanging on a white wall. What changes is the optical distance from the wall; the camera slowly zooms in and out, and only toward the end of the film can spectators clearly discern the sea waves. Looking all the time at the centrally positioned photograph in *Wavelength*, the spectator starts to wonder what is different from looking straight at a photograph of a seascape.

If *Wavelength* adds movement to a photograph by zooming in and out, and Jürss's *You Never Know the Whole Story* achieves this through reenactments of the frozen moments in news photos, Thierry Kuntzel's *Peau* [Skin] (2007) creates "moving photographs" through the "scanning" of still images by a film projector. *Peau* consists of a large projection screen and an unusual film projector called a "projecteur PhotoMobile" designed by Gérard Harlay in 2000. A 70mm film moves extremely slowly (about 0.2 cm per second) from right to left through this projector. The film that has a length of five meters comprises forty-five macro photographs of skin that scroll slowly across the projection screen. In fact, in *Peau* the spectator sees something similar to that in Kuntzel's *Été* (one of the opening case studies of this chapter), but on the large screen in *Été* the camera scrolled across the model's skin, whereas in *Peau* the still photos slide through the projector. Bellour, who devotes his essay "Le point de l'art" (2007) to a profound analysis of *Peau*, explains that Kuntzel was inspired by the Japanese makimono scroll paintings (2012, 490–495). Moreover, the filmic scanning of photographs calls forth Chris Marker's famous film *La Jetée*, even if in this case a film camera moved across photographs. *Peau* actually presents the basic principle of film: still images are led through the projector, yet vertically and at a speed of twenty-four images a second, too fast to perceive them as still images. The extreme slowness and absence of narrative in this work as well as in the other works discussed in this section invites us to take a closer look at the concept of boredom.

Theory of boredom

The notion of "boredom," it seems, has been applied more to video art, both early works and recent ones, than to any other medium. Yet, according to Nam June Paik, boredom is all but a negative quality; being a Korean-born artist trained in Japan he stresses that boredom is even

a sign of aristocracy in Asia (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 98). The Irish/Canadian artist Les Levine blamed viewers of video art in 1974 for apparently missing the dynamics of television in video art: the work is "boring if you demand that it be something else. If you demand that it be itself then it is not boring" (quoted by Antin in Schneider and Korot 1976, 178). This suggests that videotapes are not judged to be boring in comparison with paintings or sculpture; they are merely unexciting in comparison with television, which has set the standard of video time and which relies on distinct shots of rarely more than twenty seconds (180).

In terms of this chapter's theme, one may wonder what boredom regarding video art amounts to. How, in other words, does boredom in video influence the mediation of something from the real world in the mind of a person? Quite a few theorists in the field of philosophy and sociology have reflected on boredom in contemporary society, seeking to define boredom as attitude. Film theorist Patrice Petro, in "After Shock / Between Boredom and History," locates film and photography between boredom and history (1995, 265). As Petro's interdisciplinary research establishes, boredom is typically thought to represent a subjective experience of a time without event, when nothing happens, a seemingly endless flux without beginning or end. History, by contrast, is commonly understood to document that which happened: a series of events, or, at least, moments thought to be eventful, which suggest that something occurred (rather than nothing at all). Petro stresses that it is important to overcome the idea of boredom as merely subjective, and for inspiration she refers to extensive literature on boredom as a peculiarly modern experience (268), while mainly basing her own view on that of Fredric Jameson as formulated in *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (1991).

According to Petro, boredom is about too much and too little, about sensory overload and sensory deprivation, anxieties of excess as well as anxieties of loss. In twentieth-century psychoanalytical and clinical practice, boredom became linked to depression, anger, grief, or loss as the source of a depression; but, finally, in contemporary postmodern theories, boredom became associated with both frustration and relief. Boredom thus becomes, as in Jameson's text, both a symptom and a cure (270). In particular the relationship between boredom and waiting gained more importance, for it is in waiting without aim that the possibility of change may present itself. Petro concludes that the anticipation that something (different) might occur is hidden in the negativity of boredom and waiting (275).

The theories of boredom increasingly locate the indeterminate within the realm of the everyday – that site of change and stasis, identity and nonbeing, happenings and nonevents (276). Examples given by Petro from the field of the arts include Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot*, Warhol's early films, and Chantal Akerman's *Jeanne Dielman, 23 Quai du Commerce – 1080 Bruxelles* (which explores the intolerably routinized, repetitious, and almost painful experience of time in a day in the life of a middle-class housewife). As these examples suggest, an aesthetic of boredom retains the modernist impulse of provocation and calculated assault: how long must one watch and wait until something actually happens? How much tedium can one possibly stand? This conceptualization nevertheless abandons the modernist fiction of the self-contained aesthetic object, precisely by exploring the temporal and psychic structures of perception itself. The tedium and irritation of perceptual boredom, in other words, enable an awareness of looking as a temporal process – bound not to a particular object but to ways of seeing (276).

Petro's argument points at crucial aspects of the photograph-like video works discussed in this section. Video works that rely on "unfreezing" or "animating" photographs are likely to be called "boring" when video is perceived in its relationship to television and film. These "slow" video works, however, make us aware of perception itself – in particular of looking as a temporal process. They turn us into "pensive spectators" of processes of visual representation. The barely moving videos which position themselves in-between photography and moving images appear to be successful in critically reflecting on the problematic issues of representation in news and portrait photographs, respectively their ambiguous meaning without captions and the action (or even "acting") of posing. The photograph-like videos also reflect on themselves as "animated pictures": if photographs are usually identified as presenting people as "frozen," it is actually the "still videos" that present them as "petrified" rather than animated.

Video Art and Drawing

So far there have been few theoretical reflections on video art that discuss this medium in relation to the medium of drawing. At the same time, both media tend to be associated with becoming, rather than being, and the possibility of easy erasure and direct renewal. In particular South African artist William Kentridge's works have demonstrated that moving images



Figure 3.5 William Kentridge, Drawing for *Felix in Exile*, 1994. Charcoal on paper. © William Kentridge, courtesy of the artist.

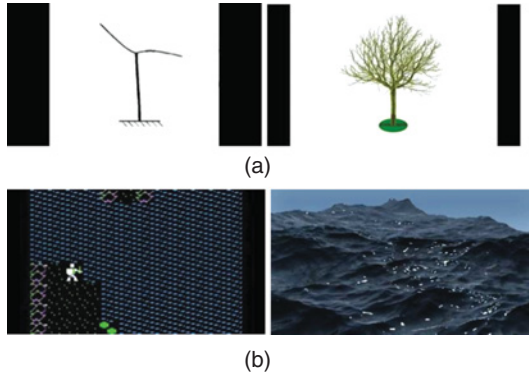


Figure 3.6 Harun Farocki, *Parallele I* (*Parallel I*), 2012. Two-channel digital video, color, sound, 17:10 minutes. © Harun Farocki 2012, courtesy of the studio.

and drawings can mutually reinforce each other in interesting new ways, even if he uses a film camera instead of a video camera. In the years 1989–2003, Kentridge produced a series of nine short films called *Drawings for Projection*. In this series his drawings become a "time-based art" as a result of the recording of the process of continuously revising a drawing (Figure 3.5). Using 16mm or 35mm film, he slowed down the process

by transferring the film's final form onto video at half or a quarter of the normal speed.

The issue of representation in this section mainly concerns the question of what insights views on the medium of drawing can provide into how videos that relate to drawing represent their subject. Particularly interesting in this context is art historian Norman Bryson's essay "A Walk for a Walk's Sake" (2003). Aiming to answer the question of what drawing is, Bryson observes that the drawn line presents "becoming," and this is unlike painting, which rather presents "being" (2003, 150). Line gives you the image together with the whole history of its becoming-image. If there is a last line to a drawing, the time of finally ending the image never fully arrives. Bryson refers to the drawn line as "a radically open zone that always operates in real time," and he emphasizes that it always exists in the present tense, in the time of its own unfolding, the ongoing time of a present that constantly presses forward. This is why it is quite possible that the drawn line is far closer to the immediacy of the artist's thought and perception than the line made on canvas (149–151).

Interestingly, Kentridge also relates drawing to thinking, calling his medium "a testing of ideas," "a slow-motion version of thought," and a form of "thinking aloud" (in an interview with Carolyn Christov-Bakargiev, in Cameron, Coetzee, and Christov-Bakargiev 1999, 35). In his view, the immediacy and suppleness of the charcoal mark serve as a most direct way to address issues of both art and politics (quoted in McCrickard 2012, 7). His "drawings in motion" and "erasures" reflect on socio-political situations in his homeland of South Africa. Dramatic and violent scenes are often executed in a calm way, which may seem contradictory but which could be explained as representing these paradoxes in daily life. Kentridge commented on this as follows: "what is the atmosphere in which we live that enables the shocks and clashes of daily life to leave us so calm?" (quoted in Christov-Bakargiev 1998, 56)

Kentridge fell into filming his drawings quite accidentally. Mainly worried about losing his drawings through overworking, he borrowed a 16mm Bolex movie camera and created a static studio set-up. His goal was to see a drawing come into being. After he started drawing, he would interrupt this action by walking to the camera, shooting one or two frames, walking back to the paper, and continuing to change the drawing (McCrickard 2012, 17, 25). The alteration of the same drawing, rather than using a different drawing for each frame, would generate work that in his view differed from the classic animation technique. As

such, his technique is both an appropriation and an adaptation of the stop-motion method developed by Albert E. Smith and J. Stuart Blackton at the turn of the nineteenth century for the production of animation films (26).

Kentridge's studio practice, then, was more about making a drawing than making a film. According to writer and artist Kate McCrickard, his film project was inspired by Bruce Nauman's *Mapping the Studio* videos and Hans Namuth's studio footage of Jackson Pollock's drip paintings (2012, 17). Particularly the first source of inspiration invites reflection on Kentridge's works in terms of the relationship between video art and studio practice: performance artists applied video in their studio (see Chapter 1) in a different way to sculptors like Nauman (see Chapter 2) or to Kentridge in his practice of drawing. Rosalind Krauss describes the latter practice in her essay "'The Rock': William Kentridge's Drawings for Projection" (2000, 10). She argues that in Kentridge's practice filmic animation is a support for "a type of drawing that is extremely reflexive about its own condition, that savors the graininess of the clouds of charcoal or pastel as they are blown onto paper ... " (10).

In an interview with Margaret Koerner (2012), Kentridge explained that through his working process he characterizes drawings as having a sense of time spent on them through being erased, redrawn, erased, and redrawn again. He described the problem of erasure he struggled with as: "As you erase an arm and redraw it in a slightly different position, you're left with the ghost image of where the arm had been." He tried every possible way to get rid of these ghost images. It took him more than a year to understand that the erasures were part of the films and, more than that, of their meanings and their interest (McCrickard 2012, 26). With regard to the aspect of erasure media scholar Michael Newman underscores that Kentridge uses animation for playing on the relation between the trace and its erasure. As a result of this process, the film becomes the memory of drawing (in Comer 2009, 99).

The role of trace and erasure in drawing is compared by Sean Cubitt in "Precepts for Digital Artwork" to the working process in digital media (in Marchessault and Lord 2007, 310). If drawing is a practice in which artists subordinate themselves to the activity of the line as to a machine designed to generate a non-volitional autonomy from selfhood, subordination to the technologies of computer memory offers a further tool: the double negation of the erasure that the computer enables becomes a

resource for the construction of the erased erasure of the past. The proof is that it is virtually impossible to erase a file accidentally. Traces remain from which skilled operators can retrieve even the most shredded data. As an example of dealing with this issue in art, Cubitt mentions Colombian artist Sawad Brooks's Net artwork *Lapses and Erasures* (1998). Brooks intends to make drawing interfaces to draw upon the erasure of erasure in the realm of the digital.

Video's characteristic of being erasable and re-usable is applied by sociologist Zygmunt Bauman in an intriguing way as a metaphor for the postmodern "problem of identity." Whereas the modern "problem of identity" was how to construct an identity and keep it solid and stable, the postmodern one is primarily how to avoid fixation and keep the options open (1996, 18). If his catchword for modernity is creation, for postmodernity it is recycling. This leads him to identify photographic paper as the medium of issues of modern identity, and the videotape as that of postmodern identity: being erasable and re-usable, so not holding anything forever (18).

Making (and erasing) chalk drawings as part of moving images, as Kentridge does, in fact goes back to the early years of video art. Joan Jonas inserted the act of making drawings into her performances and sometimes presented the final drawings as part of the video installations. Curator Ralf Christofori, in his essay "Information Passes Through: Drawing in the Work of Joan Jonas," focuses on the question of the form of representation Jonas works with in her drawings. He describes how in *Vertical Honey's Visual Telepathy* (1972) she did not look directly at the paper while drawing, but at a monitor that simultaneously transmitted the progressions of the drawings as they occurred. In this way the act of representation was itself mediated. As Christofori notes, the recurring motif of appearing and disappearing in Jonas's work (as discussed in Chapter 1), particularly the transforming and disappearing of archetypal images, finds its equivalent in drawing and its erasure (in Schmidt 2000, 222–224).

Combining performance, video, and drawing is not a surprising mixture when one realizes that theories on the specificity of drawing stress its provisional nature and the existence of a physical action. Art critic Brian Dillon, for instance, calls drawing a ghostly medium because it always maintains some relation with the provisional and unfinished, bearing the physical traces of its passage into being, which seems to us always incomplete (2009, 8). Referring to John Berger's essay

"Life-Drawing" (1960), Dillon adds that drawing records the unfolding of an event, not the fixed reality of an object (9). In *Drawing Acts*, a study of the phenomenology of drawing, art historian David Rosand observes that drawing, on a fundamental level, involves us, as viewers, in the kinesthetics of the act of drawing: "its qualities of direction, velocity, weight, its rhythm, pace, and inflection stand as permanent trace of the movement of the artist's hand ... " (2002, 16).

The relationship between drawing as ghostly medium and performance, and the unfolding of events in video is literally at the center of Australian artist Bridget Walker's video *Le Spectre Silencieux du Mouvement* [The Silent Specter of Motion] (2012). In this video, the artist plays a game of deception using various media, such as drawing, animation, games, and documentary film. Drawings are unrolled and become animated, producing a large number of weapon-like objects as if they are part of a violent video game. Rather than representing reality, an animated drawing of the specter becomes reality when the artist starts to dress up as a specter in daily life, walking the streets and doing her shopping. The animation even turns into a kind of documentary when in an "interview" friends of hers explain that the project ended up with this strange behavior (Langenbach 2013, 126).

Whereas Walker's 2012 video makes the spectator aware of the interrelationship of drawing, animation, computer games, and documentary, including their distinctive ways of representing, Czech-German artist Harun Farocki combines these media in his 2012 video *Parallel* to reflect on the history of reality-effects in computer-based animation (Figure 3.6a and Figure 3.6b). Focusing on drawings of trees, water, and clouds that represent natural environments of computer games, Farocki presents a revolutionary development that occurred within just three decades. Furthermore, he relates this process to the age-old developments in art history from ancient times (the representation of the human body in Egyptian painting and Pliny's story of the Greek painter Zeuxis whose painted grapes deceived birds) up to the invention of film. In this way, *Parallel* can be said to explore different modes of representation. In the earliest computer animation images, a tree was represented as a static line drawing and water as lines and dots (Figure 3.6a and Figure 3.6b). In the next stage colored squares were used as two-dimensional building blocks to create moving images. Subsequently, a photo-realism was developed on the basis of photographic images. Recently, scientific models of, for example, waves are used as sources: changing perspectives are based on mathematics and software is used for three-dimensional

designs. Toward the end of the video Farocki juxtaposes sea waves created through computer models – which is called "new constructivism" by the voice-over – and sea waves recorded by film. The flickering of the film images reveals the mediation by the film camera. The voice-over states that computer animation images will surpass film images in reality-effects.

In an analysis of *Parallel*, curator Anselm Franke concludes that this video questions the notion of "progress" that underlies histories of art and representation based on a linear, evolutionary progression from imperfect representation (mimesis) to more accurate, complex, and perfect forms:

> In the new mimetic paradigm of digital 'realism,' reality is no longer the measure of the always imperfect image; instead, the virtual image increasingly becomes the measure of an always-imperfect actuality. With the 'ideal-typical' image, representation seeks to overcome lived reality by constructing, monitoring, and governing it. (2012, 50)

This section addressed both "analog drawing" and "digital drawing." Critics and video artists who reflected on either form in some way seem to agree on the characteristic of drawing-erasing-redrawing as a process of becoming rather than being. Kentridge even uses this process as a metaphor for creative thinking, life, and politics, which he elucidates through recording his drawings' stages of development. Video recording can also be characterized, unlike film recording, as erasable and re-recordable, but it is virtually impossible to represent this characteristic in a video work. This makes me wonder whether one can consider the presentation of the drawing-erasing-redrawing process in a video as a metaphor of this ability of video. That video is related to becoming rather than being is made clear in particular in the common use of loops that suggest an ongoing, never-ending "becoming." Bryson's observation that the drawn line always exists in the time of its own unfolding, the ongoing time of a present that constantly presses forward, and that drawing is an immediate art, can be translated to the video artworks discussed in this chapter, but also to video in more general terms. Likewise, Dillon's characterization of drawing as provisional and seemingly always incomplete fits many video works. Farocki's *Parallel*, however, demonstrates that representation in "digital drawing" might surpass imperfect reality with "ideal-typical" images.

Another relevant distinction is that *Parallel* contemplates the representation of trees, water, and clouds in computer images/drawings through the same digital medium, which is different from Kentridge's work, in which the way of representing through film and video is combined with that in drawing through recording drawings. The next section discusses video artworks that do not reflect on representation in painting by presenting paintings, but by seeming to be paintings, as in the case of the photographs by Jürss. What are the implications for the spectator of these different forms of representation?

As a stepping stone to my discussion of this issue in the next section, I briefly consider philosopher Richard Wollheim's view on representational seeing in his "Seeing-as, Seeing-in, and Pictorial Representation" (1980). Wollheim relates seeing-as to straightforward perception, a capacity of humans and animals to perceive things present to the senses (1980, 217). Seeing-in derives from a special perceptual capacity, which presupposes, but is something over and above, straightforward perception, and allows us to have perceptual experiences of things that are not present to the senses: both of things that are absent and of things that are non-existent (217). Moreover, seeing-in permits simultaneous attention to what is represented and to the representation, thus to the object and the medium. In fact, it is not just permitted but even required to attend simultaneously to these two. Wollheim labels this requirement "the twofold thesis" (213). A next development would occur when an artist modifies or adjusts an external object in a specific way, which he calls pictorial representation (218–219). Wollheim concludes that the artist exploits twofold-ness to build up analogies and correspondences between the medium and the object of representation, while showing that seeing-in rests upon seeing-as: "seeing the representation as a representation" (226). At this point we turn to video works that represent paintings in various ways.

Video Art and Painting

An important and quite new painterly aspect of video is the flat screen, which made it possible for video art to be exhibited as "framed panels" hung on white walls, as in classical white cube modernist painting exhibitions. Because these screens allow more light in the exhibition rooms (than in the era of projection beamers), videos on flat screens can be exhibited next to paintings on the same wall. Chris Meigh-Andrews mentions interesting early examples of small video portraits in vertical



Figure 3.7 Bill Viola, *Catherine's Room*, 2001. Color video polyptych on five LCD flat panels mounted on wall. 15 × 97 × $2\frac{1}{4}$ in (38.1 x 246.4 × 5.7 cm). 18:00 minutes. Performer: Weba Garretson. Photo credit: Kira Perov. © Bill Viola, courtesy of the artist.

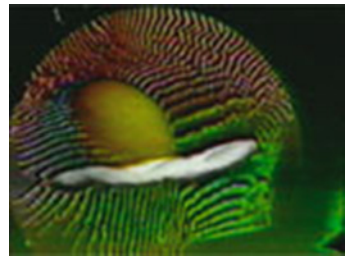


Figure 3.8 Woody and Steina Vasulka, *Golden Voyage*, 1973. One-channel analog video, color, sound, 14:20 minutes. © Woody and Steina Vasulka, courtesy of the artists.



Figure 3.9 Yang Fudong, *No Snow on the Broken Bridge*, 2006. Eight-channel installation, 35mm black-and-white film, music by Jin Wang, 11 minutes. Exhibition view in Hangzhou, China 2013. Photograph: Fay Yeong. © Yang Fudong, courtesy of the artist, ShanghART gallery and Marian Goodman Gallery.

and square formats, framed analogous to traditional paintings, by the British artists Marty St James and Anne Wilson (2006, 247). In the early 1990s they exhibited these video portraits, such as *Smoking man – Giuliano Pirani* (1991), alongside more traditional portraits in formal gallery settings such as the National Portrait Gallery in London.

Various flat screens combined can even evoke associations with small triptychs or predellas from the late Middle Ages, such as in *Catherine's Room* (2001), which is part of a recent development in Bill Viola's video works (Figure 3.7). His earliest video works from the 1970s were clearly influenced by performance art. Quite soon, however, his interest in existential issues brought him to studies of both philosophical views of life and spiritual views from Christian ascetics and Buddhism. Subjects related to spirituality are most often visualized through the medium of painting (or sculpture). We have become familiar with religious painting in a huge variety of styles, but representations of, for instance, Christ or Buddha as photograph or video in churches or temples are still exceptional, probably because lens-based media (still) seem to be too much connected to the visible, externally present world.

In the mid-1990s Viola found a way to create lens-based video works that are inspired by traditional religious paintings, and which also relate to existential questions in the present. His large video projection *The Greeting* (1995), inspired by Jacopo da Pontormo's *Visitation* (1528–1529), presents in the foreground a meeting between two women, as in the painting. The forty-five-second recording of the staged meeting that he shot at three hundred frames per second (using a high-speed 35mm film camera) was extended to a ten-minute video. The slowly changing expressions in the faces and body language hold the attention of the spectators, who may not invest that much time into studying the details of Pontormo's painting. In *Visitation* Pontormo depicted the meeting between Mary and her niece Elizabeth as described in the Bible (Luke I: 36/39–56). Mary came to tell her niece that she was pregnant, so this meeting announced the imminent birth of Jesus. In an interview in 1997 Viola explained that his interest in this painting was triggered by its social aspect, as opposed to the obvious religious aspect.[5] The painting made him reflect on greeting moments, the moments in which people come together. Those "magic moments" happen continually, especially at airports. Viola positioned his meeting in a neutral urban exterior setting and a timeless context: the colorful cloths are not related to a particular period or culture, and when the figures greet each other we cannot hear which language they speak as a result of the noise of the wind that drowns out their voices.

Marc Mayer added a quite unusual interpretation of this video to his observation that the extreme slow motion, which serves to emphasize its solemnity, also draws us into contemplation about media (1996, 67). He suggests that if we remember that both Elizabeth and Mary are paradoxical mothers, one well past her prime and the other a virgin, we might

be reminded that a similar description applies to painting and video, one too exhausted and the other too immaculate to produce art in our time. Video, as the ultimate manifestation of mechanical reproduction, "greets" ancient, "authentic" painting, to which it communicates its aesthetic anxiety in a work where the sacred meets the profane (73).

The Greeting needs to be projected in a dark room, but in the mid-1990s Viola also started to experiment with LCD flat panels that he presented on white exhibition walls. Whereas his beamer projections were impressive as a result of their monumentality or almost mysterious appearance in the dark, the small flat screens particularly draw attention through their intimacy. His fascination for the relationship between spiritual themes and existential questions continued, as did his use of extreme slow motion. The polyptych *Catherine's Room* (2001), consisting of five small LCD flat panels (Figure 3.7), was inspired by a predella (the base of an altarpiece containing decorated panels) painted by Andrea di Bartolo in 1393–1394. The five scenes in the predella present episodes from the life of St Catherina from Siena. Viola saw the predella in The Getty Museum and noted: "Solitary suffering and the pain of the wound [of Catherine's stigmata] – 'where light enters'." Regarding his own polyptych he said: "The key to this piece is the balance between a direct presentation of traditional (Western) spirituality and a view of a contemporary person in a contemporary setting" (in Walsh 2003, 46). This statement is quite similar to his comment on *The Greeting*. *Catherine's Room* provides a view into the room of a solitary woman who executes daily rituals from morning until night. Each panel represents a different time of the day.

The theme of this chapter, "moving images mediating as contemplative images," is certainly at the center of Viola's videos and notes. In several texts he relates video to Western as well as Asian traditional music and religious visual culture, to human senses and memory in general, and even to cosmic structures. One of his examples is the Indian Tantric doctrine of the three traditional expressions of the deity: the anthropomorphic image, the yantra or geometric "energy" diagram, and the mantra or sonic representation through chanting and music. These are all considered to be equivalent outward expressions of the same underlying thing. Viola observes that in terms of form this is quite similar to the nature of electronic systems: the same electronic signal could be an image if fed into a video monitor, an energy diagram if fed into an oscilloscope, and a sequence of sounds if imported into an audio system (1998 [1995], 107).

In his essay "Video Black – The Mortality of the Image" (1990), Viola introduces a history of visual arts consisting of four stages: the era of the Eternal Image, the Temporal Image, the Temporary Image, and the Last Image (1998 [1995], 197–209). The first encompasses the sacred arts; the second started with Brunelleschi's discovery of the vanishing point and linear perspective, which implied the creation of point of view and its identification with a place in real space, turning the viewer into an embodiment of the painter. The invention of photography heralded the third era, that of the temporary image, continued by the introduction of film and video as media of duration, which is also characteristic of thought. Because the viewer only sees the decay trace of a single moving point of light in video, the whole does not exist, and therefore can only reside in the mind of the person who has seen it, to be revived periodically through his or her memory. One senses a strange familiarity with human life: an image is born, flashes before our eyes, and dies in blackness. This observation, according to Viola, leads to the era of the last image, because the means of the artistic creation of images are now the laws of optics and the properties of light, putting the focus on the human eye. This statement calls forth the reference by Oliver Grau to laser scanners that can now beam virtual images directly onto the retina. Grau wonders whether the term "image" is still an appropriate characterization here, now the retina suffices as a medium, dealing with the most private of all images imaginable so far, one that may be interpreted as a neural category (2003 [2001] 251).

In another piece, "Between How and Why" (1993), Viola claims that machines, technologies, infrastructures, and the like focus on "how" and are therefore irrelevant to the development of our inner lives. Art, however, is traditionally the articulation and expression of the "why" side of life, and therefore now so important and vital, even though it remains confused and inconsistent in its response to new demands. The new technologies of image-making are bringing us back, according to Viola, to fundamental questions. Spending time with a video camera would prompt some of the primary questions, such as what the fleeting image called "life" is, why we are here sharing the living moment, and why the essential elements of life are change, movement, and transformation, rather than stability, immobility, and constancy (1998 [1995], 256–257).

In his painting-like videos, Viola stays much closer to painting than do the films inspired by paintings discussed by film scholar David Morrison

in his essay "Framing Loneliness in Painting and Film" (in Allen and Hubner 2012, 203–219). Morrison discusses how strategies such as track-in shots and music are applied by filmmakers who were influenced by Edward Hopper's painting (e.g. Billy Wilder's *The Apartment*, 1960). In most of his videos, Viola kept the silence, did not change the framed location, and only allowed a minimum of changes. Especially the light in Catherine's room is changing, which reminds the spectator that video is one of the lens-based media, one that registers on the basis of the presence of light.

The unchanging static framing of the location calls forth one of the distinctions that the film critic André Bazin made between film and painting in his seminal publication *What is Cinema?* (2005 [1967], 166). According to Bazin, the outer edges of the screen are not the "frame" of the film image. They are merely the edges of a piece of masking that shows a portion of reality. Conversely, the picture frame polarizes space inward. This is why the frame should be called centripetal, the screen centrifugal. Bill Viola's screens – like the screen of Chiurai and Kuntzel's small screen – could be called centripetal, because the framed images do not seem to be cut out of a larger visual reality.

As discussed in the second section, extreme slowness is a quite recent trend in video art. This observation raises the question of how early video art sought to relate to painting. On the one hand, we can find statements from the 1970s that compare these two media and mainly stress the immediateness they have in common. On the other, there were video performances (see Chapter 1) in which artists inserted paintings, such as German artist Ulrike Rosenbach's *Glauben Sie nicht dass ich eine Amazone bin* [Do Not Believe I Am an Amazone], performed in 1975. During her performance Rosenbach shot arrows at a reproduction of the famous medieval painting *Maria im Rosenhagen* [Madonna of the Rose Bower] by Stefan Lochner. Two cameras recorded the performance: one directed to Rosenbach, one to the reproduction of the painting perforated by arrows. On a monitor the two recordings were shown in superposition, resulting in a fusion of Rosenbach and the Madonna, and turning the performance into a martyrdom or "self-destruction."

Statements from the 1970s that drew a comparison between video and painting mainly stressed that the video artist, like the painter who sees the result of his brushstroke on the canvas right away, was able to see immediately the result of the recording, which was unlike the recording process in analog photography and film. In the early 1970s, German

filmmaker and gallerist Gerry Schum, for instance, referred to the similar instantaneity in creating an electronic image and a painted picture as residing in the fact that one had the opportunity to take control of the medium in the same way as one did, for instance, with the canvas or paint medium where there was a learning process (in Blase 1977, 39). Schum and others mainly hinted at "being in control" of the process, because in the 1970s most video artists could hardly edit the video camera's real-time recordings. Deliberate distortions were the main form of creative editing. Art critic Richard Kostelanetz also related this form of editing to painting, claiming that video offers an arsenal of techniques for producing instant distortion – a surrealism that, because of the screen's size, is more painterly (if not literary) than filmic (in Battcock 1978, 41).

Only toward the 1980s did a variety of creative editing procedures become more easily available to most artists. One of the early exceptions was Paik's video-synthesizer (see Chapter 1), a tool that as early as 1974 caused Paik to imagine shaping video "as precisely as Leonardo, as freely as Picasso, as colorfully as Renoir, as profoundly as Mondrian, as violently as Pollock, and as lyrically as Jasper Johns" (in Rosebush 1974). In particular the image-processing systems developed by Woody and Steina Vasulka can be considered as early experimental tools for creating videos equivalent to creating formalist paintings through manipulating colors and forms. As of 1969, Steina, trained in the field of music, and Woody, an engineer, filmmaker and film editor, began to devote themselves to video art. Two years later they were co-founders of "The Kitchen," a collaborative of artists and activists working with video, sound, and performance. Chris Meigh-Andrews explains that the Vasulkas searched to provide the foundation for a new electronic language and to explore and define the frontiers of digital and televisual space. Rather than being specifically interested in making "abstract" video, they sought to develop a vocabulary of electronic images through a systematic deconstruction process (2006, 123–125). Michael Rush underscores that the Vasulkas had a passion for understanding the inner workings of video as "electrical energy organized as voltages and frequencies in a temporal event. Like painters involved with the contents of their palette . . . " (1999, 90).

In their video *Golden Voyage* (1973), the Vasulkas invented new means of electronic manipulation that altered viewers' perceptions, much like Pointillism and Impressionism had done in painting a century before, according to Rush (1999, 91) (Figure 3.8). Maureen Turim describes *Golden Voyage* in "The Image of Art in Video" as an invitation to look at this work as meta-discourse on painting and video (in Renov and

Suderburg 1996, 30). She stresses its re-imaging of past aesthetics in its reference to René Magritte's painting *La légende dorée* [The Golden Legend] (1958), which was the source of inspiration for the Vasulkas. Turim calls Magritte's paintings prevideographic – in the same way certain devices and images have been called precinematic – seeing in his paintings the type of collage, juxtaposition, and image manipulation that current video techniques afford (29).

Whereas videos by the Vasulkas and Viola are mainly related to the European history of painting, many video artists with a different cultural background search for inspiration in their own cultural history. Chinese artist Yang Fudong, for instance, became famous for his multi-channel black-and-white video or film installations that look like Chinese black-and-white scroll ink paintings (Figure 3.9). Art historian and sinologist Birgit Hopfener notes in an essay on Chinese video art that China does not have a rich film history to offer to video artists, which makes Chinese painting a more important source of inspiration (in Frohne and Haberer 2012, 197–217).[6] According to rules of aesthetics, formulated some fifteen centuries ago, presenting life as continuous transformation related to *qi* (energy of life) should be the most important aim in Chinese art (212). Traditionally, perception in China is not focused on looking but on bodily experience, and observing paintings included unrolling the scroll paintings. In these paintings space was represented as poly-perspective rather than in central perspective as in Western painting (213). Hopfener concludes that most Chinese video works contain – consciously or unconsciously – traditional Chinese aesthetics. This would be particularly clear in their liveliness and de-framing, and in images that intend to activate the beholders. Moreover, the *qi* that is present in brushstrokes in Chinese paintings has been translated in video in repetition and moving images (217).

Hopfener does not discuss the video works of Yang Fudong, but his multi-screen film and video projections, such as *No Snow on the Broken Bridge* (2006), certainly fit her observations (Figure 3.9). On eight juxtaposed screens one sees eight young men and women take a meandering walk along Hangzhou's famous West Lake, admiring the surrounding scenery. The video lasts eleven minutes and no definitive action takes place (Kent 2011). The young people represent the artist's generation, which hovers between past and present in a rapidly modernizing China. In an interview with art historian Claire Roberts (2011), the artist expressed his admiration for the modern brush-and-ink painter

Fu Baoshi, who painted his figures in an antique mode which "moved things forward a lot." Roberts concludes that *No Snow* connects with the visual and aesthetic cultures of China's past and yet remains very much of the present.

Color in video art and the relationship between painting and avant-garde films

With regard to the comparison of video and Western painting it is important to realize that the resemblance with paintings dramatically increased after the introduction of the color video recording. Photography, film, television, and video all started out as media of black-and-white images. It took many decades to invent color photography, but the development of color in film and television followed within a few decades of their introduction. Color video artworks were produced by some artists such as Paik and the Vasulkas in the early 1970s already (so within a decade of the introduction of the Portapak video camera), mainly with the help of television studio equipment. American video artist Jud Yalkut, in his textual contribution to *Video Art: An Anthology* (1976), mentions that the guest-artists-in-residencies program at the WNET Television Laboratory in New York permitted him to realize ideas with a fully interfaced color-capable system. For his video work *The Astrolabe of God* (1972) he utilized two color studio cameras, the technology for preparing an electronically colorized feedback tape to serve as sync source and visual input during production, as well as chroma-key capability. In 1965 he had met Nam June Paik, marking the beginning of their ongoing collaboration, which included projects in television laboratories (in Schneider and Korot 1976, 146–147).

Since literature on video art does not pay much attention to the aspect of color in video, Malcolm Le Grice's essay "Colour Abstraction – Painting – Film – Video – Digital Media" (1995), in which he compares the aspect of color in four media, is particularly interesting to consult (2001, 259–272). Le Grice, a British pioneer of "structural film" in the 1970s who exhibited his first video and computer works already in the late 1960s, published numerous notes, especially on film. He observes that by the time light hits the retina and is electrochemically transmitted to the visual cortex it makes no great physical difference whether that light has come reflected from the pigment of a painting or has been emitted from the video screen. Inextricably bound to its medium, however,

color is significantly affected by the historical context of that medium, its place in society and culture, and the kinds of meanings resulting from this context. Moreover, from the point of view of the artist, the physical properties of the medium or its technologies are fundamental to the kind of images or experiences that can be produced (261). Le Grice defines four distinct systems for color which, in general, correspond to the media of painting, film, video, and digital art. First, in pigment systems light falls on a surface, whereby some wavelengths are absorbed and others are reflected back to the eye. Second, in photochemical systems colored light is recorded through layered filter emulsions. Third, in electro-analog systems color is recorded on magnetic tape as a continuously changing signal, coding luminance and chrominance for later presentation via a cathode ray tube, which separates the signal into three component red-, green-, and blue-filtered intensities. Fourth, in electro-digital systems recorded images are analyzed into discrete pixels given intensity values for the component colors red, green, and blue, after which they are re-synthesized from the digital information for presentation in a variety of output technologies (262).

Le Grice subsequently asserts that it is no longer easy to separate analog video from digital media, because almost all video effects generators are incorporating a digital frame store as a final stage, and much of the manipulation of images takes place at a digital rather than analog level. As an exceptional example of color abstraction that derived from the characteristics of analog video and the cathode ray tube he mentions Nam June Paik's early cooperation with video engineer Shuya Abe and the Uchida Radio Research Institute in Tokyo in 1963–1964 (266). Finally Le Grice mentions as "media-specific" opportunities for video to work directly with image scan reversals, distortions, and color selective superimposures through "keying" (267). But particularly digital methods of manipulating images offer much greater and more precise control of the transformation of color. This is based on a fundamental technological property of digital systems that all the information, whether visual, auditory, or textual, is analyzed into digital code. In the visual field, this means that each component of the image, normally assumed to be a "pixel" or single point of the image, is stored as numeral data giving a precise value to its intensity (luminance) and color (chrominance). As a consequence, by rewriting these values through a computer program, their properties and locations may be manipulated as desired within the limits of the program to select and restructure the data (268).

In the 1980s the quality of the electronic images improved significantly, although artists continued to struggle with details and colors, relying on an additive color process, contrary to the full color spectrum of motion picture film which uses a subtractive color process (Butler 2007 [2002], 172). The technical developments made many video artists shift from black-and-white to color video productions by the 1980s, turning color into an increasingly important feature in video art. One of the contemporary video artists deserving particular attention for the way she deals with color is Swiss artist Pipilotti Rist. Rist uses spectacular color distortions, adjusting the images during recording and in post-production in order to deliberately exaggerate color intensity and contrasts. Rist has characterized video as "moving paintings behind glass." She manipulated colors in order to represent internal states of mind:

> I am interested in the pictures that result when the RGB signal is out of synch – e.g. if the three colour tubes are shifted, or the different signal values are over-modulated ... I'm interested in feedback and generation losses, like colour noise and bleeds. In my experiments with video it becomes clear to me how very much these supposedly faulty, chance images are like pictures in my own subconscious. (quoted in Phelan, Obrist, and Bronfen 2001, 108)

The formal experiments with moving images by Rist and the Vasulkas call forth associations with structural films of avant-garde filmmakers in the 1920s. Regarding the theme of this section, it is important to realize that these films were partly inspired by modernist paintings. This phenomenon is addressed by film theorist Peter Wollen in his seminal essay "The Two Avant-Gardes," first published in 1975 and revised in 1982. Wollen characterizes the close relationship between avant-garde film and art as both a strength and a weakness (in Leighton 2008, 173). He calls for the need of historical study when it comes to understanding the split in avant-garde filmmaking in the late 1960s and 1970s. A similar split can be found in Europe in the 1920s, when artists with a background in painting, such as Fernand Léger, also made films, thereby attempting to extend the scope of painting by introducing the dimension of time. Although Wollen also identifies a group of avant-garde filmmakers with a background in theater (Eisenstein) or futurist sound-poetry (Vertov), he emphasizes the leading role of painting in the development of modernism in the other arts during the 1920s (174).

Painting stimulated, according to Wollen, the tendency toward abstraction, which led to the use in film of pure light or color, non-figurative design or deformation, fragmentation, extreme close-ups, etcetera (175). Artists translated the tendency in painting to concentrate on its own sphere of materials and signification into specifically cinematic terms and concerns (176).

Whereas modernist painting influenced avant-garde film, film curator Stuart Comer, editor of the anthology *Film and Video Art* (2009), discusses avant-garde film (and even pre-cinema experiments) not only as predecessor of painting-like video art, but also of video art in general. To underscore that view his anthology starts with two chapters by A.L. Rees devoted to movements in film in the periods 1912–1940 and 1941–1979. Rees, like Wollen, discusses artistic aspects of analog avant-garde film. In contrast, media theorist Lev Manovich, in "What is Digital Cinema?," highlights the relation of digital cinema to painting, in addition to comparing analog avant-garde film and early hand-painted films to painting. He concludes that as a result of the manual construction of images, digital cinema is no longer an indexical media technology, but rather a sub-genre of painting and painting in time (2000 [1999], 175, 192).

In concluding this section on video works and painting, I return to Wollheim's observation that the painter exploits twofold-ness to build up analogies and correspondences between the medium and the object of representation, while showing that seeing-in rests upon seeing-as: seeing the representation as a representation. The video works covered in this section might be said to deal with a threefold-ness of the medium of video, the medium of painting, and the object of representation. Likewise, the video works in the previous sections dealt with a threefold-ness, combining video and photography or drawing.

The video works that relate to painting in various ways open up an array of interpretive challenges. Adapted characteristics from paintings – such as framing, the centripetal effect, manipulations of color and form, or references to specific paintings – encourage us to look at these video works as if they were paintings, even when some movement is added to the video. Bill Viola even considers video as a next stage of painting, being more immaterial as consisting of light and energy, and more related to duration of thought and transformation of life.

The two opening case studies of this chapter, as well as the "photograph-like videos" and "drawing-related videos" discussed in the previous sections, also mainly focus on a fixed frame, a flat image, visual

experience (rather than sound), and a strong reduction of movement to facilitate contemplation. An interesting byproduct of most of these videos is that through the application of slight changes or minor movements – which "reanimate" the seemingly static pictures (although they in fact "petrify" them) – this kind of video work appears to hold the attention of the beholder (somewhat) longer than classical pictures.

My argument in this chapter has demonstrated that each medium has its own conventions of representation, but that video, as a highly adaptable medium, appears to be capable in particular of appropriating specific representational conventions of photography, drawing, and painting. The term intermedia, defined as different media elements remaining recognizable while processes of transformation are reflected in the images, seems to be well applicable to the video works discussed.

Highlighting the medium's multifaceted and chameleonic nature, some videos even look more like a photograph, drawing, or painting, enriched with a temporal dimension. In all cases, however, this minimal temporal dimension proved to be crucial in the construction of meanings: creating a pensive spectator on posing and decontextualization in photography, on paintings as mental constructions in which twofold-ness is exploited, and on drawing as ongoing process. Moreover, in various video works the representation of another medium stimulates the spectator to reflect on issues of representation in the mass media with which we all have to deal in everyday life. This applies in particular to the video works by Jürss, Chiurai, and Farocki.

Notes

1 For a discussion of the concept of "tableau" in theories of photography, see Van Gelder and Westgeest 2011, Chapter 1.

2 This interpretation of the work is based on the announcement of the presentation of the work at Sundance Institute in 2013. See http://filmguide.sundance.org/film/13211/iyeza (accessed January 16, 2014); and on information in the exhibition *Kudzanai Chiurai: Conflict Resolution*, Kunsthal, Rotterdam, 2014.

3 The freeze frame is a multiplication of a single photogram of the film strip that results in a photograph-like frozen image at a spectacular moment that the film director wants to "hold."

4 For an introductory overview of comparative views on photography and film, see Van Gelder and Westgeest 2011, Chapter 2.

5 www.sfmoma.org/explore/multimedia/videos/13 (accessed February 26, 2013).
6 For a historical brief of the introduction of the medium of video art in China, see Li 2009.

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4

Repetition and Fragmentation in Narrative:
Video's Appropriation and Subversion of Classical Cinema

Video and cinema have become more interwoven only in recent years. In the early decades after its emergence, video largely figured as part of the modern art world, whereas cinema was part of the commercial world of movie production and theaters. At universities, professional film production was also studied in terms of its own history and research concerns. While the scholarly discipline of film studies used to take narrative cinema as its point of reference, the discipline of art history mainly focused on visual analysis, theorizing artists' concepts, and artistic contexts of pictures. Because video art was rooted in the late modernist visual arts that largely lack a concern for narrative, many theories from film studies were hardly applicable to video art. Today, however, film theorists have begun to pay attention to video art while art historians have developed a wider interest in (expanded) cinema.

The concern of video artists for cinema mainly started as a fascination for experimental films that bridged the gap between video artworks and classic cinema. In the 1950s and 1960s, experimental filmmakers such as Jean-Luc Godard, Stan Brakhage, and Jonas Mekas sought to hook up with the tradition of modern art by creating films that could be qualified as "avant-garde film," "expanded cinema," or "post-cinema." Many of these films gave up on narrative continuity. Michael Newman emphasizes that the basic distrust of narrative continuity in avant-garde cinema emerged as a response to ways in which

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mainstream cinema constructed an ideological subject, locked into the film (in Comer 2009, 104). Despite the rapprochement between video artists and experimental cinema, art film houses and art galleries still represented two separate worlds, also because their audiences did not necessarily overlap.

It was experimental film's critical reflection on mainstream cinema in particular that served to inspire several video artists from the early 1990s on. The video artists who are at the center of this chapter's argument mainly chose to isolate, caricaturize, or invert some of Hollywood's conventions. As Michael Rush has argued, this development in video art resulted in new viewing experiences that could be called cinematic (in Ma and Suderburg 2012, 112–113). Rush coined the notion of *new cinematics* for the new tendency in video art of referring to the creative process – often indistinguishable from editing procedures of movies – and the heightened viewing experience of larger-than-life images (114). In emphasizing the recent developments in film and video one should not forget, however, that the presence of film in the art gallery space as such is hardly a new phenomenon. As early as the late 1960s and 1970s, artists such as Andy Warhol and Dan Graham and filmmakers such as Michael Snow presented their films in art galleries. At the same time, their works tried to avoid a cinematic experience, which is at odds with several contemporary video works that deliberately evoke canonical images from film history.

Moreover, in the early twenty-first century, as part of an exhibition, several video artists began to urge the public to enter at the beginning of the presentation of their work and leave at the end, even though in many cases it is unclear whether a video work really needs to be seen according to such cinematic logic. And both the tendency to transform an exhibition room into a cinema theater with classical chairs in rows (e.g. *Documenta XI*, 2002) and the digitization of both film and video make it sometimes hard to discern whether we are looking at cinema or video art. Some video artists play along with this confusion. For instance, Janet Cardiff's *The Muriel Lake Incident* (1999) consists of a miniature movie theater the viewer can look into, while headphones provide the experience of sitting in it; a surround-sound system mimics whispers and other kinds of sounds typically produced by spectators sitting close to you in a conventional movie theater.

This chapter mainly raises the issue of how specific insights about narrative theory from film studies can enhance our understanding of

the video artworks discussed. Particularly the role of temporal aspects, the perceptual activity of the spectator in creating a narrative, and discussion on Hollywood conventions appear to be interesting for closer examination of strategies such as repetition in these video works. When discussing videos that react to Hollywood films, one cannot ignore the fact that quite a few video works are based on Hitchcock films, an issue covered at the end of the second section. Next, the last section is devoted to views on the use of verbal language – particularly the voice-over – in cinema and video art, notably its relationship with images.

Aside from literature dealing with the selected video works and video art in general, this chapter's main sources come from the discipline of film studies. In this chapter, however, I do not particularly develop a comparison of the selected video artworks with the genre of art films, in which sometimes quite similar strategies are used, and therefore I largely ignore the possible innovative nature of these videos. As in the other chapters, my interdisciplinary approach to videos interrogating traditional cinema is grounded in an art historical perspective, which includes, for instance, attention to artists' statements.

Candice Breitz's *Mother + Father* (2005) Juxtaposed to Rodney Graham's *Vexation Island* (1997) and Keren Cytter's *Corrections* (2013)

In an arched semi-circle of six plasma screens, six Hollywood actresses passionately perform the rites of motherhood, presented as close-ups of neurotic mothers. In a second parallel installation in an adjacent room, six equally recognizable actors present themselves as clichéd angry and defensive fathers. This video installation, entitled *Mother + Father*, was produced in 2005 by the Berlin-based South African artist Candice Breitz (Figure 4.1). The artist lifted the actors out of their movies (dating from the 1980s and 1990s) and isolated them from their previous contexts by blackening out backgrounds and other characters. The short sequences are shown in a loop, but sometimes Breitz also made the actors repeat a sentence over and over again, or replicated facial expressions staccato-like as micro-loops, which almost turns them into mechanical objects. Because every reference to the stories of the Hollywood feature films is eliminated, *Mother + Father* does not look like

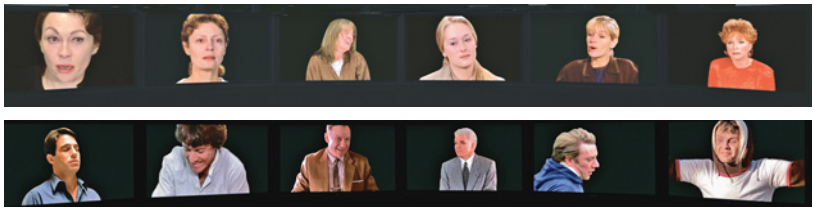


Figure 4.1 Candice Breitz, *Mother*, 2005. Six-channel installation, color, sound, 13:15 minutes. *Father*, 2005. Six-channel installation, color, sound, 11 minutes. Installation View: Italian Pavilion, 51st Venice Biennale, 2005. Photograph: Alexander Fahl. Ed. 3 + A.P. © Candice Breitz, courtesy of the artist.



Figure 4.2 Rodney Graham, *Vexation Island*, 1997. 35mm film transferred to DVD, color, sound, 9 minutes projected on continuous loop. © Rodney Graham, courtesy Lisson Gallery, London.



Figure 4.3 Keren Cytter, *Corrections*, 2013. One-channel digital video, color, sound, 8 minutes. © Keren Cytter, courtesy of the artist and Pilar Corrias, London.

traditional Hollywood film stories at first sight. A more in-depth analysis and consultation of film theory, however, will provide more layered insights.

Rather than eliminating most of the main characteristics of feature films, as Breitz did in *Mother + Father*, Canadian artist Rodney Graham caricatured some of those aspects in *Vexation Island* (1997) (Figure 4.2). Graham shot the nine-minute loop as 35mm film in widescreen format, edited it on video, and presented it on laser disc. The loop shows a sleeping (or unconscious) shipwrecked man dressed in eighteenth-century costume and with a wound on his head. He is lying under a palm tree on a small deserted island with only a parrot as his partner. The man gets up, notices a coconut in the top of the tree, and shakes it to get it down. The coconut duly drops and hits him right on the head where the wound is, which the viewer has already seen clearly in close-ups of the face. The man is knocked unconscious and falls down in slow motion in the same place where he woke up. Subsequently, the film seamlessly starts all over again.

Israeli (and peripatetic) artist Keren Cytter's eight-minute video *Corrections* (2013) is related to the two other video works in drawing attention to clichés used in classical Hollywood films, but the applied strategies are different (Figure 4.3). Cytter uses conventions of cinema in a deliberately erroneous way. Actors perform in an overly artificial manner, and recite their texts without affect, while their statements are too cryptic and fragmented to be understood immediately. Moreover, the camerawork is illogical: too much directed to the ground, close-ups at unusual moments, too much use of blurredness with unclear function, and with voices sometimes out of synch with the images of the speakers. Particularly striking is the too frequent and too obvious occurrence of repetition of sentences and short fragments. Contrary to *Vexation Island* where hardly anything happens, *Corrections* is overloaded with visual impressions, fragmented incoherent sentences, and visual effects, as if the viewer is scrolling through a feature film. The protagonist is a man who struggles with a trauma, but it remains unclear what exactly the relationship is with the killing of a young couple and a cockroach, which are the main events in Cytter's video.

Breitz, Graham, and Cytter reflect on clichés in Hollywood film in different ways, but in each of the works repetitions play a crucial role, as in many other video works discussed in the previous chapters. In the next section the strategy of repetition will be related to some aspects of narrative in film theories and particular psychoanalytic views.

Aspects of Narrative in Video Art Reacting to Hollywood Films, and Views on Compulsive Repetition

Theories on narrative applied to the three key works

Film scholars have used the concept of narrative in different ways. The range of types of narrative theory vary from theories that concentrate on the developmental logic of series of events (the plot) or on style, which is concerned with how devices and techniques operate to convert a plot into a story, to approaches that have shifted attention from authors and narrators toward how sense is made by spectators (Branigan 1992, 118–124). Related to this diversity, the notion of narrative has been given different meanings. Tom Gunning, in "Narrative Discourse and the Narrator System," discusses narrative as means of expression, or what he calls "narrative discourse" (2004 [1991], 470). To gain more insight into the temporal aspects of narrative in the key works discussed here, the function of "tense" within narrative discourse is particularly useful (472). Within "tense," Gunning designates three principal manipulations of story events: order as succession of events in a narrative; duration dealing with the compression or extension of events within a narrative; and frequency describing the possibility of multiple retellings of a single event.

The three key works employ loops and repetition in obvious and even extreme ways, which renders frequency the most explicit form of manipulation. The compact combinations of fragments applied by Breitz and Cytter result in compressions of events and extensions caused by repetitions, but they do not contribute to the creation of a clear story. It is even problematic to speak of a succession of events in their videos: they only present fragments of events, which are hard to relate to each other in a successive way. Conversely, Graham only shows one straightforward event.

To raise our understanding of the manipulation of time in these video works and the consequences for our perception of them, it is interesting to consult the work of film theorists Edward Branigan and David Bordwell. Branigan, in *Narrative Comprehension and Film* (1992, 3), defines narrative mainly as the perceptual activity of the spectator. His emphasis on the role of the perceptual capacities and experience of the spectator does not mean that he turns his attention to the public: his publications focus on analyses of strategies in films that encourage the spectator to execute

story-constructing activities. This activity consists of a way of organizing spatial and temporal data into a cause-effect chain of events that embodies a judgment about the nature of the events, as well as demonstrating how it is possible to know and hence to narrate the events. Branigan argues that not every construction should be called a narrative:

> in a narrative, some person, object, or situation undergoes a particular type of change and this change is measured by a sequence of attributions which apply to the thing at different times. Narrative is a way of experiencing a group of sentences or pictures which together attribute a beginning, middle and end to something. (4)

Being presented as a loop, Graham's *Vexation Island* has neither a beginning nor an end. Still, causality and transformation – features much emphasized by Branigan – play a crucial role, but in a cyclic rather than linear order. In this video, time seems to proceed, yet the spectator merely shares in an event in which a character makes the same mistake over and over again. After the mistake is made, it is almost as if forgotten and immediately repeated again.

David Bordwell, in *Narration in the Fiction Film*, underlines the importance of attention for the manipulation of time (1986 [1985], 32). A narrative film stimulates the viewer to construct stories, but may also contain cues and structures that encourage the spectator to make errors of comprehension. In such cases, the film deliberately aims to produce "misunderstanding" at some level (39). Breitz, Graham, and Cytter explicitly use "misunderstanding" as a strategy to activate the spectator. In conventional Hollywood films misunderstandings tend to be solved before the end of the movie, but these three video artists leave it up to the beholders to develop their own interpretation. In this respect, their works relate to art-cinema, which, as Bordwell explains, generally loosens up cause and effect (206).

The so-called flash-forward, which according to Bordwell is unthinkable in traditional narrative cinema (210), is applied by Graham to show the wounded head before one sees the coconut as cause of the injury. Cytter's video is so complex that one is constantly in doubt as to whether one is looking at an unfolding story, flashbacks, or flash-forwards. This complexity, however, does not mainly result in formal experiments, such as in early avant-garde films as Fernand Léger's *Ballet Méchanique* (1924): the repetitive "corrections" suggest almost desperate efforts to create a narrative. Although a clear understanding of the video seems impossible,

its complexity is intriguing; and thanks to the fact that *Corrections* can be downloaded from the internet and only lasts eight minutes, the spectator is stimulated to view the work several times to make more sense out of it.

Bordwell's chapter on classical Hollywood filmmaking (circa 1917–1960) contributes particularly well to our understanding of how Graham, Breitz, and Cytter deal with Hollywood conventions. Framing in classical Hollywood films is less likely to rely on extreme long shots or extreme close-ups, or on a high or a low angle (163). Graham and Cytter clearly violate this unwritten rule, while Breitz, through endless repetition of a short fragment, turns emotional statements into extreme long shots. Moreover, Bordwell describes canonic narration of Hollywood film as a form of presenting

> psychologically defined individuals who struggle to solve a clear-cut problem or to attain specific goals. In the course of this struggle, the characters enter into conflict with others or with external circumstances. The story ends with a decisive victory or defeat, a resolution of the problem, and a clear achievement or nonachievement of the goals. (157)

He adds that the most "specified" character is usually the protagonist, who becomes the principal causal agent, the target of narrational restrictions, and the main object of audience identification (157). Graham and Breitz have isolated the role of the struggling Hollywood protagonist. Breitz has eliminated all contextual information, and this makes it virtually impossible to identify with the protagonists. It is not much easier to identify with Graham's protagonist: during seven of the video's nine minutes he is asleep. Cytter's protagonist is also struggling, but the situations are too confusing for the viewer to become absorbed by them.

Another important strategy in Hollywood films to stimulate identification pertains to the "point of view" (or "POV"-shot), which refers to the angle or perspective from which the story is told (Branigan 1984). Perspective is either hardly identifiable, notably in Breitz's videos, or constantly and abruptly changing, in particular in Graham's and Cytter's works – at least more than would be allowed in conventional cinema because it undermines smooth perception by the viewers. Cytter, for instance, plays with points of view by placing the camera in the position of the person addressed by one of the protagonists, while it is not clear who that person is. Regarding the issue of address, however, the actors in my three key works do not speak to the viewer directly, as they

do in early television-like and performance-like video works (such as Vito Acconci's *Centers*); rather, they negate the spectator, much in the same way as in conventional cinema.

Bordwell adds that Hollywood narratives are highly redundant, an effect achieved principally by patterns attributable to the story world (1986 [1985], 161). It is possible to recognize the same traits and same functions in each character; or different characters presenting the same interpretive commentary on the same character or situation. Breitz's juxtaposition of the roles of six mothers and six fathers underscores this characteristic. All key works discussed make use of Hollywood conventions, and they do so chiefly by isolating (Breitz), caricaturizing (Graham), or inverting (Cytter) them. The works evoke memories of movies seen in the past, which fits in with Branigan's argument that a film spectator, through exposure to a small number of films, knows how to understand a potentially infinite number of new films. This means that Branigan considers meaning to be the end result of a series of judgments and inferences made by a reader about the underlying structure (1992, 17–18). Many spectators will associate Breitz's, Graham's, and Cytter's works with films they have seen or know about. According to Branigan, this sense-making by the spectator is not a completely subjective matter because cognition is "driven" by forces, a reference to the main drive theories from psychoanalysis. In the next subsection, I relate *Mother + Father*, *Vexation Island*, and *Corrections* in particular to psychoanalytical views on people's compulsion to repeat.

Compulsive repetition

As curator Loretta Yarlow has argued, Graham's *Vexation Island* presents a neurotic hero for whom repetition replaces remembrance of the past, in accordance with Sigmund Freud's concept of neurosis (in Graham 1997, 3–4). Similarly, curator Jack Liang relates the compulsion toward repetition in this video to Freud's theories on the subject. More specifically Liang refers to the Freudian idea of screen memories, which replace or veil real memories (1998, 3). This unconscious veiling of traumatic events can be read in the continuous confusion of the shipwrecked man, when waking up with a red-purple bruise on his forehead, seemingly unaware of what has happened and how he was hurt.

Freud mentioned the compulsion to repeat for the first time in an essay entitled "Erinnern, wiederholen und durcharbeiten" [Remembering, Repeating, and Working-through] (1991 [1914]), but he elaborated

the concept in "Jenseits des Lustprinzips" [Beyond the Pleasure Principle] (1998 [1920]). In Freud's view, the unconscious contains a supreme compulsion to repeat. His observation that the patient repeats traumatic events rather than remember them consciously is clearly applicable to the protagonist in *Vexation Island*. Compulsion toward repetition to cope with a trauma can also be identified as a guiding theme in Cytter's *Corrections*, as its title suggests. Several times, actions and sayings are repeated in an attempt to correct the past, albeit in vain. In fact, this struggle provides *Corrections* with its basic storyline.

In his 1920 essay Freud also relates compulsive repetition to repetitive behavior in daily life with respect to distressing experiences in the past. This means that he at first, in 1914, dealt with it as a clinical phenomenon, and in 1920 as a characteristic of an instinct. By exploiting video's various repetition techniques, Breitz magnified this behavior in the roles of mothers and fathers. As she remarked in an interview with Louise Neri, she started experimenting with moving images to explore her interest in the mechanical and repetitive potential of video, as tied to certain psychological impulses (Neri 2005, 5). The drama of life, according to Breitz, is also a drama of repetition: maintaining a notion of who we are needs a certain consistency, the continual repeating and confirming of certain beliefs, values, and behaviors. We learn who we are by observing others, thus through mimicry and repetition. She expects viewers of her video installation *Mother + Father* to wonder whether their feelings coincidentally correspond with these Hollywood feelings or whether Hollywood feelings are based on our feelings (6).

Victor Burgin, in his study *The Remembered Film* (2004), has coined "sequence-image" as a term for confrontations of experiences from daily life with fragments from films. Burgin argues that his concept differs from the notion of "image-sequence," which is only a linear arrangement of still images (2004, 19). He describes the sequence-image as that which starts with an experience in daily life and subsequently triggers a memory of a fragment from a movie, which in turn leads to another association, such as a short sequence from another film, an aspect from personal or collective memory, or particular details from one's image environment. The elements that constitute the sequence-image (particularly perceptions and recollections), then, emerge successively but not teleologically (21). In this way, Burgin also relates his notion of the sequence-image to seemingly arbitrary chains of associative links at work in the unconscious and in dreams. According to Alexander Streitberger, it is possible to characterize Burgin's video works of the late 1990s and after as visual

explorations of the sequence-image as a heterogeneous object where various kinds of images coexist in a non-teleological way, such as in *Listen to Britain* (2002) (2013, 72).

Film theorist Laura Mulvey focuses in *Death 24x a Second: Stillness and the Moving Image* (2006) on new ways of experiencing classical cinematic images after the arrival of new technologies. Mulvey's analysis, which initially does not seem relevant for the key works discussed here, offers quite a convincing account of how Cytter and Breitz deal with Hollywood films and the consequences for how spectators experience their work. Mulvey's main argument is that viewing digitized classical films on DVD at home provides easy access to repetition, slow motion, and freeze frame, and may well shift the spectator's pleasure to a fetishistic rather than a voyeuristic investment in the cinematic object.

Return and repetition necessarily include interrupting the flow of film, delaying its progress, and discerning cinema's complex relation to time (Mulvey 2007 [2006], 8). Delay shows details previously unnoticed that seem to have been waiting to be noticed. Mulvey observes here a loose equivalent with Freud's notion of deferred action (*Nachträglichkeit*), which includes the way the unconscious preserves a specific experience, while its traumatic effect might only be realized later by another, somehow interrelated event (8).

Digital spectatorship would also affect the internal pattern of narrative: sequences can be easily omitted or repeated, overturning hierarchies of privilege, and setting up unexpected relationships that displace the chain of meaning invested in cause and effect. When broken down in this way, a movie's apparently horizontal structure mutates (27–28). Breitz's conscious choice and compilation of film fragments also affected the narratives. Digital tools made it possible to blacken out the background and context to isolate the selected images even more. Mulvey's argument seems valid when she claims that the narrative drive weakens as a result of the spectator (in this case Breitz), who is able to control its flow, to repeat and return to certain sequences while omitting others. The process of identification, usually kept in place by the relation between plot and character, suspense and transcendence, loses its hold over the spectator (in this case the spectator of Breitz's video work). Mulvey even claims that with the weakening of narrative and its effects, the aesthetic of the film begins to become "feminized," because the male star is stripped of the power to organize relations between movement, action, and drive of the plot (165). The patriarchal dominance is also reduced by Breitz as a

result of de-contextualization and by presenting the two groups as equally present, albeit as clichéd characters.

Mulvey – who addresses the halted image rather than the isolated fragment – concludes that the viewer becomes more intrigued by image than the plot, returning compulsively to privileged moments, investing emotion, and "visual pleasure" in any slight gesture, a particular look or exchange taking place on the screen (166). This description of what Mulvey calls the "possessive spectator" is particularly applicable to Breitz's position, whereas the spectators of her work can only experience the consequences of her actions for the narrative drive.

Unlike Breitz and Mulvey's hypothetical spectator, Keren Cytter did not lift images from Hollywood films; rather, she treated her own Hollywood-inspired film material in the same way. As a result of making her videos available on the internet, the spectators are enabled to halt and repeat the images time and again to gain other and new insights. In an interview Cytter has stressed this advantage of the easy availability of her work on the internet (Gat 2011). In this way she puts her work at the service of creating a kind of spectatorship as, in the words of Mulvey, a possibility resulting from digitization – a possibility that in principle is created by anyone who uploads his or her videos on the internet.

Although continuous repetition is especially a characteristic of video loops in general, a loop is not always a meaningful aspect of a video work. In *Mother + Father* and *Vexation Island* looping certainly contributes to the meanings of the works because it turns the protagonists' actions into compulsive behavior. Although *Corrections* presents credit titles at a certain moment that could be called the end, the video starts with a cockroach falling onto the street after being thrown out of the window just before the credit titles. This relationship turns *Corrections* into a kind of loop as well, but because this video is quite overloaded and therefore cannot be remembered exactly, spectators are not sure whether they are looking at a loop, or even loops in a loop, or at successively presented, almost identical versions of the video – serving as "corrections" of the former ones.

The current interest in loops is discussed in historical perspective by Lev Manovich in "What is Digital Cinema?" (2000 [1999], 187). He notes that all nineteenth-century pro-cinematic devices, up to Edison's Kinetoscope, were based on short loops. Technical developments in film production progressively banished the loop to the low-art domains of the instructional film, the pornographic peep-show, and the animated

cartoon. Narrative cinema avoided repetitions, preferring a linear progression through unique events. Several revolutionary Soviet montage films experimented with loops, but they were an exception to the rule. Focusing on cinema rather than on modern art, Manovich does not mention the film loops created in the period 1964–1970 by Fluxus artists such as Nam June Paik and Yoko Ono, short (8mm and 16mm) films whose length ranges from about ten seconds to ten minutes. The interest of contemporary video artists in loops should partly be considered in that tradition, but an important difference is that the so-called "Fluxfilms" were low-quality, basic productions presented by means of a film loop projector, whereas Breitz, Graham, and Cytter produced digitally edited loops to be presented by a beamer or on the internet. In this respect, these works relate to the introduction of digital cinema, including the built-in QuickTime interface. QuickTime movies are supposed to be played forward, backward or looped. Manovich speculates whether the loop can be a new narrative form suitable for the computer age, because looping is one of the elementary control structures that alter the linear flow of data in programming (189). The important role of looping in the three key works of this section, particularly the variety of loops applied in *Mother + Father* and *Corrections*, can be seen in light of this development.

Classical narrative is marked by principles of causality, temporal progress, and psychological motivation. In the video works under discussion, these aspects are transformed through repetition. One may initially perceive the diverse forms of repetition enabled by present video techniques as formal characteristics of these works. However, in relation to repetition of a certain behavior or traumatic events by the actors, the struggle with compulsive repetition itself has become the displaced narrative.

Hitchcock and Freud's "uncanny" as source of inspiration

The exhibition *Notorious: Alfred Hitchcock and Contemporary Art*, presented in 1999 in the Museum of Modern Art in Oxford, clearly demonstrated how many artists have used Alfred Hitchcock's films as a source of inspiration. The curators Kerry Brougher, Michael Tarantino, and Astrid Brown aimed to show both the amplitude and multifariousness of the influences of this famous British filmmaker on contemporary artworks. They situate this interest in the fascination for cinema among artists that developed in the course of the 1980s. This reframing of film would have had the effect of negating the original power of cinema to suspend our

disbelief, creating in its place a meditation on the nature of cinema and the way film language operates. Rather than watching film we begin to watch ourselves watching, and Hitchcock's films appear to contain useful material for these artists (Brougher and Tarantino 1999, 4).

Important characteristics of Hitchcock's work mentioned by Kerry Brougher in the catalog are the ability to occupy a dreamspace between reality and fiction – dreamy virtual worlds which are at once real and unreal – and a self-reflexivity that turns the focus of his films back upon themselves (1999, 8–9). Moreover, his protagonists are often placed in unfamiliar territories and in imbalanced states; even within familiar terrain the main characters seem uncomfortable. This characterization is strikingly applicable to the protagonists of Cytter's *Corrections*: a man who struggles with a trauma and two quite hysterical and blasé women.

The meeting of the man and women in *Corrections* takes place in what looks like a park surrounded by gruesome buildings where the man shoots a couple; next, the scene continues indoors in what looks like a house where the cockroach is killed. Hitchcock's sets are described by Brougher as frequently having a degree of artificiality about them, evoking a strange space between reality and theatricality (11). The same could be said of Cytter's sets, partly as a result of the indefinable and blurred environments. With regard to the former subsection about relationships between these video works and some of Freud's psychoanalytic views, it is noteworthy that Brougher, like many other analysts of Hitchcock's films, mentions the filmmaker's interest in Freud's psychoanalysis, particularly in the concept of the *unheimliche* [uncanny], referring to turning the familiar (*heimlich*) into something uncomfortable, uncanny. *Corrections* is full of uncanny atmospheres.

The interest of filmmakers and video artists in Hitchcock's films is categorized by Steven Jacobs as three interrelated themes: the appropriation of the Hitchcock image as a tool to reflect on film history and memory; the Hitchcock image cherished as a fetish by what Laura Mulvey called a "possessive spectator"; and the Hitchcockian theme of the double (2012 [2011], 158). These various themes play a role in the following two examples, while the latter theme features in particular in Grimonprez's *Double Take*.

One of the most literal appropriations of a Hitchcock film is Scottish artist Douglas Gordon's *24-Hour Psycho* (1993), which expands Hitchcock's *Psycho* (1960) by slowing it down electronically from its original ninety minutes into twenty-four hours, which means running at two frames per



Figure 4.4 Johan Grimonprez, *Double Take*, 2009. One-channel digital film novel, black-and-white, sound, 80 minutes. © Johan Grimonprez, courtesy of the artist.

second. Consequently, the narrative becomes impossible to follow, but Michael Newman argues that the video demonstrates how much *Psycho* is part of the cultural memory of viewers, making the urge to watch the whole film unnecessary (in Comer, 2009, 105).

Laura Mulvey refers in her analysis of *Psycho* to Peter Wollen, who has typified this film in "Hybrid Plots in *Psycho*" (1980) as a different type of story that, following Freud, we can call a tale of the uncanny (2007 [2006], 96). Mulvey characterizes the iconic horror in *Psycho* as making use of the most identifiable of narrative figures and tropes: near-clichéd images (86). Gordon's *24-Hour Psycho* is defined by Mulvey as a dialog between the film and technology to determine something that is not there in the original as screened but that can still be revealed within it. She calls this video a celebration of the fundamental new possibilities offered by video viewing (101). While the flow of twenty-four frames a second tends to assert a "now-ness" to the picture, stillness allows access to the time of the film's registration, its "then-ness." In Mulvey's view, Gordon's detection of another dimension to the film image, as he slowed his machine to scrutinize a highly self-reflexive moment of voyeurism, can be seen as a symbol of this shift in spectatorship (102–103).

One of the most complicated reworkings of a Hitchcock film is Johan Grimonprez's *Double Take* (2009), which combines short fragments from Hitchcock's *The Birds* with fragments from television presentations by Hitchcock, television news shows and commercials, as well as moving images that refer to René Magritte's Surrealist paintings (Figure 4.4). In a dialog with Catherine Bernard in 2009, Grimonprez clarifies that the coffee ads in *Double Take* reveal the underlying ideology through their historical displacement, but are also woven into the fiction's plot: it is the commercial (the cup of coffee) that literally becomes the murder weapon. The commercials particularly stress that they are part of the arrival of television that killed cinema, but they also allude to how television's commercial breaks have changed the mode of telling narratives



Figure 4.4 continued

(Bernard and Grimonprez 2011 [2009], 119). This change in a dominant medium is also expressed in the presentation of Hitchcock himself in two functions, as filmmaker and television maker, a dual function that followed in part from the closure of many movie theaters as a result of the loss of audiences to television. If most video artists used Hitchcock as symbol of film history, Grimonprez presents him as a transitional figure who reflected in his films on his medium and who even more critically reflected on television in his television performances. The main critique concerns television's fragmented character, which is emphasized in *Double Take* through an editing pattern that evokes zapping rather than film montage (Jacobs, 2012 [2011], 175). These abrupt changes between fragments of news shows, commercials, and films are discussed in Chapter 1 in my comparison of video and television as media. Regarding the present chapter's central theme – the role of repetition and fragmentation in narrative – it is noteworthy that the zapping-based structure resulted in many repetitions of images that resembled each other and fragments that resembled each other.

Doubling, however, is most literally present in *Double Take* in the *doppelgänger*. The main protagonist is Ron Burrage, a "professional" Hitchcock double. We also see Hitchcock playing himself, for instance in staging a Hitchcock lookalike contest. The story that is woven through *Double Take* was written by Tom McCarthy and based on Jorge Luis Borges's short story "The Other," in which he recounts the incident of meeting a younger version of himself. In *Double Take* Hitchcock meets himself as twenty years older, and during the meeting he witnesses his own death caused by a poisoned cup of coffee. Grimonprez's work seems to confirm Freud's view that meeting one's double is an encounter with the uncanny, as expressed in his essay "Das Unheimliche" [The Uncanny].

This subsection has established that video art is an appropriate medium for evoking an uncanny feeling, as described by Freud and aroused by Hitchcock's films. Specific strategies include extreme delay, exaggerated artificiality, de-contextualizing familiar images (from Hollywood films), doubling, and repetition.

The Tension between Images and Verbal Language as Dialog, Voice-over, Voice-off, or Text

Among comparisons of video art with other media, verbal language (as text or speech) is rarely addressed. This renders Richard Kostelanetz's

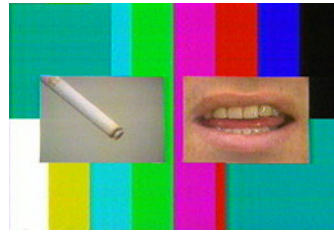


Figure 4.5 Gary Hill, *Primarily Speaking*, 1981–1983. One-channel analog video, color, sound, 18:40 minutes. © Gary Hill c/o Pictoright Amsterdam 2014, courtesy of the artist.



Figure 4.6 Omer Fast, *The Casting*, 2007. Video installation, four-channel video projection, color, 35mm film transferred to video/video/sound, projection with hard disc players, 14 minutes. Edition of 6 + 2 APs. © Omer Fast. Courtesy the artist, Zabludowicz Collection, and GB Agency, Paris. 4.6b: Photo Stephen White during *We Will Live We Will See* exhibition at the Zabludowicz Collection in 2011.

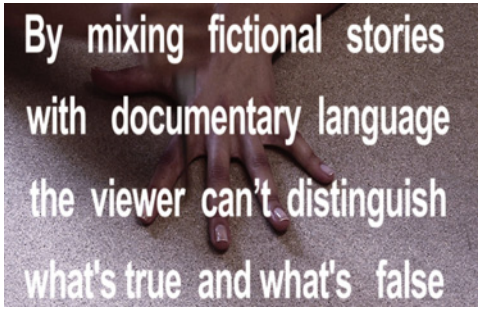


Figure 4.7 Keren Cytter, *Video Art Manual*, 2011. One-channel digital video, color, sound, 14 minutes. © Keren Cytter, courtesy of the artist and Pilar Corrias, London.

essay "Literary Video" (1978) all the more remarkable. Kostelanetz describes what he calls "literary video" as a category that differs from other video artworks in that it has a basis in a text that is conceived within the traditions of literature and espouses a contemporary sense of verbal possibilities. As a result, the author has become an artist, exploiting the intrinsic possibilities of the new medium: instant playback, overdubbing, image distortion in live time, etc. (in Battcock 1978, 40). Literary video thus integrates literary materials and video possibilities. Regarding video art in general, Kostelanetz observes that the medium video is closer to books than film, because the television screen is small and perceptually distant, like the printed page, rather than large and enveloping, like the movie screen. Although the size of the video projection screen has increased dramatically after the publication of this essay, Kostelanetz's argument that video is customarily "read" like a book, in small groups or alone, still seems appropriate. The same goes for his observation that most of us feel no qualms about interrupting someone watching television or reading a book, while at the movies viewers tend to be left undisturbed (41). Video presentations in exhibitions are still continually disturbed by visitors entering and leaving the room.

An exceptional video that consists only of text combined with music – though not mentioned by Kostelanetz, but included as illustration in Battcock's anthology (1978, 23) – is American artist Richard Serra's video *Television Delivers People* (1973). Serra presents texts that roll from the bottom to the top of the screen. While muzak – the kind of music one hears in shopping malls – is playing in the background, critical texts are shown about how television manipulates its public, for instance: "The

public is the product of the television, of commercial television, . . . he is the consumer who becomes consumed . . . Television delivers people." Serra developed the script by assembling excerpts from published papers given at an academic media symposium. The work was broadcast first as a station sign-off in Amarillo Texas, and subsequently on other broadcast television stations (Ravenal 2002, 95).

The most explicit comparison of video with writing can be found in Raymond Bellour's essay "Video Writing" (1990). Bellour considers the video "image" as written in varying degrees, for instance because the image is created with the aid of scanning machines; this is even more the case when the video image is deliberately conceived with the aid of a graphic palette or a computer (in Hall and Fifer 1990, 421). He discusses various ways of inscribing the metaphor of writing in video art on the basis of individual case studies, such as *Video Letter* (1982–1983) by Shito Terayama and Shuntaro Tanikawa. The "video letter" at the center of this video is called a new kind of correspondence made possible by video. For almost two years, the two Japanese poets Terayama and Tanikawa sent each other video letters, a popular format in Japan in the early 1980s resulting from the enormous growth of consumer video. The video letters consisted of images (personal photographs and recordings of their own environment) and speech. Fragments from sixteen letters were finally combined in one videotape, resulting in a compilation that often obscures who is speaking (337–340). Their debate is about the meaning and non-meaning of the words, about what would be beyond them, in the body as well as in the image, but also in the words themselves as body and image (440). Bellour's other case studies, if elaborated in less detail, pertain to videos by Thierry Kuntzel, Bill Viola, and Gary Hill. The work of the latter artist is relevant here in particular because his videos of the 1980s are most often discussed for their language/image interaction.

In Chapter 2 I addressed the spatial qualities of Hill's first video *Hole in the Wall* (1974) that resulted from his background as sculptor. An exemplary work of his shift to language in the 1980s is *Primarily Speaking* (1981–1983), first presented as single-channel videotape and later as eight-channel video installation. In both forms the work aims at presenting equivalents between speech and imagery. In the single videotape two images are shown next to each other at the center of the screen of a monitor against a television test card backdrop, which has come to symbolize the void on television, a color grid that appears on the screen when programs go off the air; the image stays that way until they come back on

(Figure 4.5). The videotape lasts about nineteen minutes, during which time the two image sources are having a sort of dialog. The tape begins with the words: "Well . . . you know what they say . . . we've all heard it before . . . " (Broeker 2001, 105–110). One sees a drop falling into a pool of water. In the pause that follows the word "well," concentric circles ebb from the spot where the drop landed. Willem van Weelden, in his essay "Primarily Spoken" (1993), has argued that if the spectator interprets the word "well" as a noun rather than an adverb, it acquires the meaning of "spring." This opening image could then be understood as a metaphor for the spring of speech and the dying of its echo (in Morgan 2000, 96). Sequences of image-samples accompany the text spoken by Hill like a synchronized simultaneous translation. The images suggest that they "look like what is being said" (98). The text increases the oscillatory effect by continually changing back and forth between an I, a You, and a We form. At times it seems as if the spectator is being directly addressed, provoked even; at times the "you" seems to refer to the other frame (100). The spectator is thus encouraged to actively compare the modulations of Hill's voice – which is virtually synthetic and as anonymous as possible – with the modulations and rhetorical repetition effects of the images: " . . . the speaking voice acting as a kind of motor generating images. This really puts one inside the time of speaking. Every syllable is tied to an image" (Hill quoted in Quasha, Stein, and Cooke 2009, 399).

Hill explained in an interview that his preoccupation with language began with very sculptural notions coming out of sound, the body, utterance, and speaking (in Morgan 2000, 292). This process would also clarify, according to Hill, that his work is not based on theories from linguistics or semiotics, although he has expressed an interest in the work of some authors from these fields:

> My ideas seem to shift, turn, invert, contradict, rather than develop, refine, and serialize. . . . Furthermore, this took place within the discourse of electronic media: when you work in real time the mediation of signs is very different than in a reading/writing context. . . . And yet, although my art is based on images, I am very much involved in the undermining of those images through language. (292)

As Jacinto Lageira concludes in "The Image of the World in the Body of the Text" (1992), it is at the very moment when dialog, reading, and writing tip over into entropy that Hill intervenes in order to try to stick

back together the scattered pieces (in Morgan 2000, 46). In particular through playing words and images off against each other, *Primarily Speaking* problematizes their meanings.

Because language in *Primarily Speaking* is only occasionally present as text (through words on the screen) and mainly in the form of a voice, it is interesting to bring in Mary Ann Doane's essay "The Voice in the Cinema" (1980) and Michel Chion's *Film, a Sound Art* (2003). One of the phenomena discussed by Chion is what he calls "synchresis," a term also discussed in Chapter 2. When sounds and images appear simultaneously, they blend with each other, making it almost impossible to perceive them separately (2009 [2003], 214). The spoken text and images in Hill's *Primarily Speaking* are presented in a complicated relationship, and this stimulates the viewer to experience their interaction from a more detached and critical perspective. The voice-image relationship has more in common with what Chion calls "counterpoint," as one of his five rhetorical figures of the "said/shown relationship": the situation that something is said while something else is shown, which is neither exactly the opposite nor in obvious contrast to what is heard. Chion stresses that especially in daily life we often encounter such situations (387).

For the crucial role of the voice-over in Hill's work it is insightful to consult Mary Ann Doane who describes the voice-over commentary in the documentary or during a flashback or interior monolog as a disembodied voice (2004 [1980], 379). The voice-over commentary is necessarily presented outside the diegetic space, thus not localizable by the spectator. It is its radical otherness with respect to the diegesis which endows this voice with a certain authority. As a form of direct address, it speaks without mediation to the audience, bypassing the "characters" and establishing a complicity between itself and the spectator; together they understand and thus place the image (379).

Doane refers to the argument of Pascal Bonitzer in his "Les silences de la voix" [The Silences of the Voice] (1975), where he discusses ideological implications of the voice-over in representing a specific power: that of disposing of the image and of what it reflects, from a space absolutely other with respect to that inscribed in the image-track and absolutely indeterminable. The voice-over in power can be found in particular, according to Doane, in the history of the documentary, where a male voice-over has been most common and where its power resides in the

possession of knowledge and in the privileged, unquestioned activity of interpretation. This function has been appropriated by television documentaries and television news programs, in which sound carries the burden of "information" while the impoverished image simply fills the screen (379). Relating Doane's arguments to *Primarily Speaking*, one can conclude that Hill's voice as voice-over interrogates the power of the voice-over over images: the title words "primarily speaking" seem to confirm the hierarchy of the voice-over over images, but the complex interaction between speech and images subverts the voice-over's power and implicit ideology.

An even more complicated relationship between voice-over and image than the one in *Primarily Speaking* can be found in Omer Fast's four-channel video installation *The Casting* (2007), presented as two projections next to each other on both sides of two screens (Figure 4.6). The work started from interviews held in 2006 by this Israeli artist in Texas with members of the US Army about their experiences in Iraq. Fast selected two stories by the same person from the recorded material and edited them into a multi-layered narrative. On the rear sides of the screens, Fast is presented as interviewer on one screen while the sergeant interviewed is visible on the other. Their exchange of words constitutes the sound of the installation. The front side images are more diverse: some look like film stills, others are quite similar to news photographs, and yet others are shots of a film studio. If the images all seem to be still images at first sight, they appear to be "posed video scenes," quite similar to the "video portraits" discussed in Chapter 3. The moving images show people posing as frozen in their gestures. The blinking of their eyes, their slowly waving clothes and hair, the subtle shaking of limbs – all indicate the recording of passing time.

The visitor hears about two traumatic incidents told by the sergeant. One occurred in his private life while stationed in Bavaria: a romantic affair that ended up in a nightmare, including a car crash. The other incident involves a shooting near Baghdad during his service in Iraq, where he accidently killed an innocent citizen in a car. Listening to these stories, the spectator shifts back and forth between what seem to be film stills from a soap story and a war movie (although the latter also look much like photographs from a news agency). The impression of a movie is enhanced by a third story interlaced with the two other ones. Some of the interviewer's questions and comments indicate a casting scenario, a selection procedure for a role in a film or television play, where, as art

historian Matthias Michalka put it, the best-told story or the ability to tell the most credible story will win (2007, 10). During these comments the images on the front side of the screen present shots of a casting session in a film studio. It is as if the sergeant's replies, then, become a text of a casting candidate on the set.

The alternating images that shift back and forth between glimpses of the Bavarian love story and of the Baghdad incident and film casting suggest zapping between television stations or surfing on the internet rather than film montage. This observation can be related to the fact that Fast, according to Michalka, used Google Images as basis for what could be called his *tableau vivants* (2007, 13). In Chapter 3 I discussed *tableau vivant* as a notion in the context of Jürss's videos that represents infamous news photos with ambiguous meanings rather than famous artworks with well-known meanings. Conversely, Fast's staged images in *The Casting* confront us with clichéd images, and make us realize that most images circulating on the internet, uploaded by amateurs as well as professionals, confirm clichés rather than subvert them. From that perspective the images can be called *tableau vivants* of clichéd images on the internet. With regard to the theme of death, which is pervasive in *The Casting*, it is interesting that Steven Jacobs relates the use of *tableau vivants* in films to their "melancholy and spectral character resulting in a curious deathliness"; their inherent oscillation between movement and stillness is often used as a metaphor for the tension between life and death (2012 [2011], 96).

Before the spectator discovers the interview on the back side of the screens, the voices seem to be voice-overs commenting on the images. While looking at the back sides, the spectator has the experience of watching an interview in a TV show; because of the seamless editing of the interviews, the flow of speech appears uninterrupted, even though the three stories never become one. With regard to the changing role of speech in *The Casting* it is interesting to return once more to Doane's arguments in "The Voice in the Cinema." Doane discusses a concept from film theory that concerns the voice of the character who is not visible within the frame and is referred to as the "voice-off" (2004 [1980], 376). By means of previous shots or other contextual determinants, the character's "presence" in the space of the scene is established. Doane describes the position of the invisible "voice-off" as just over there in a space which "exists," but which the camera does not choose to show. The voices in *The Casting* become, in a way, a "voice-off" when the spectator, rather than the camera as in Doane's description, moves to the images on

the front side of the screens, placing the speaking characters out of sight. In several front-side scenes, the character of the voice-off does indeed seem to be in the presented space, just outside the frame. In some other scenes the voice turns into a counterpoint of the image. But in most cases the voice suggests that the sergeant is looking together with the spectator at images from his memory, thus suggesting a voice-over flashback. The sergeant's voice could be that of the protagonist in these images, but that appears untrue when one sees the sergeant's face on the back side. Or is he also an actor?

The Casting finishes with Omer Fast as interviewer sighing:

> I'm definitely not so much, you know, looking for a political angle … Um … I'm more interested in terms of, you know, the way that experience is basically turned into memory and then the way that memories become stories, the way that memories become, you know, mediated; they get recorded and broadcast and things like this. (quoted in Michalka 2007, 18)

Michalka relates Fast's statement to Freud, who claimed that in the unconscious, truth and emotionally charged fiction cannot be distinguished from one another; "psychic reality" has laws of its own, and ultimately it makes no difference if the traumatic event really took place or not, as only the effect in the present is decisive for therapy (21).

One may conclude that *The Casting* makes its beholders increasingly doubt the truthfulness of everything they see and hear, including the reasons and consequences of these doubts. This experience is evoked by the shift from dialog to either voice-over or voice-off, as well as from synchresis of sound and moving images to the interchange between synchresis and counterpoint of sound in combination with the still-moving images.

Like Fast and Hill, Cytter plays with the role of the voice-over, at some moments in an even more confusing way. Particularly interesting in her *Corrections* are the fragments in which, simultaneously, the voice-over, the subtitles, and the image present another message. For instance, when the voice-over exclaims "Why is it morally wrong to kill your own parents?," the subtitle reads "He just said he hates us – his parents. The moment he got out of the womb we both started screaming," while we look at the cockroach, just before it is killed. As in Hill's video work, what is said by the voice-over most often does not fit with what we see, which Chion calls a "counterpoint" rhetorical figure.

Counterpoints can also be found in Fast's confrontation between fact and fiction. The title of Fast's work underscores the importance of the casting in this video installation. For Fast and several other video artists, casting appears to be an attractive practice because of its intermediate position between real life and the fictional life of cinema. In Grimonprez's *Double Take*, discussed in Chapter 1 and in the former section, various film fragments deal with a casting for the role of Hitchcock. In *Casting Jesus* (2011), a two-channel video by the German artist Christian Jankowski, a casting for the role of Jesus is performed during the full sixty minutes of the work. The staged casting shows that stereotypical poses in Christian paintings serve as models for the actors. Thus, whereas in the past the lens-based media (particularly photography and film) could be categorized in genres such as factual documentary/journalism and fiction/staged, more contemporary still and moving images are often hard to label. Many contemporary video artworks exploit not only their position in-between genres, but also their mixed roots in cinema and broadcast television. Frequently, casting sessions are presented to look like reality TV, TV shows, or eyewitness reports.

The blurring of differences between video, cinema, television, casting, and real life is even central to Keren Cytter's *Video Art Manual* (2011) (Figures 4.7 and 1.4). This one-channel, fourteen-minute video work suggests it is, as the title indicates, a manual for creating video art. This function is mainly highlighted in the contents of the subtitles, such as: "subtitles help to distract the viewer from bad acting and visual mistakes... if you offer any human being one second of boredom, he'll think about death." In some respects, *Video Art Manual* is related to Cytter's video *Corrections*. Both works provide an overload of information and consist of very short shots, which makes it almost impossible for the viewer to develop a sense of an unfolding plot. Because of the simultaneous combination of unrelated text, speech, and images, *Video Art Manual* is on a par with Hill's above-discussed *Primarily Speaking*, even if this video has a far less systematical structure. The recurring theme in *Video Art Manual* is the fear of loss of electricity as a result of solar activity, a conclusion of the "solar sun theory." Cytter demonstrates how television stimulates rather than reduces fear, which calls forth associations with the same warning in Grimonprez's *Double Take*.

Interestingly, *Video Art Manual*, as the final case study not only of this chapter but also of this volume, contains references to many of the issues discussed here, particularly in Chapter 1, such as to 1970s' video performances and videos relating to and reflecting on television. Moreover, the

obvious technical mistakes, such as a-synchronicity of speech and fast-forward effects resulting in too rapid speech and faltered movements, remind one of home videos by amateurs. In general, however, Cytter's work can best be characterized as video art from the generation that "zaps" in front of the TV set and "surfs" on the internet. Ironically, her "video art manual" does not only show people's fear of the loss of electricity, but also comprises dialogs on dealing with that loss, which implies reflection on art that does not depend on electricity.

Unlike most other works discussed in this volume, the video works examined in this chapter (except for *Vexation Island*) afford speech or dialog a significant role. These textual aspects, however, have such a fragmented structure that they do not allow viewers to develop a straightforward narrative. Particularly the intriguing relationship between voice-overs and images in the videos of Hill, Fast, and Cytter, as well as their complex use of both synchresis and counterpoint, position their works between appropriating narrative aspects of traditional cinema and subverting them.

The extreme manipulation of sequencing, of frequency, and of compression or extension of events in the video works by Breitz, Graham, and Cytter, makes it also virtually impossible for the spectator to construct a narrative line. My argument revealed in particular the important role of various forms of repetitions and loops in these works. The variety of repetitions and use of fragmentation encourage spectators to look for links with familiar Hollywood films, rather than to create a specific narrative. By applying Bordwell's discussion on Hollywood conventions to the key works, it was possible to conclude that Breitz, Graham, and Cytter zoom in on the conventional Hollywood protagonist who struggles to solve a problem, but that they do so in critical ways. By playing with unsolved misunderstandings, hardly identifiable or constantly shifting points of view, blocked identification, and processes of change without clear organization in beginning, middle and end, they subvert rather than appropriate Hollywood narratives. Breitz in particular isolates Hollywood conventions, whereas Graham caricaturizes them, and Cytter inverts them. Finally, it proved productive to relate the endless repetitions of struggles to compulsive repetitions as described by Freud as well as to Laura Mulvey's somewhat similar model of the "possessive spectator." Compulsive repetition, sometimes combined with uncanny atmospheres, appears to have become a kind of displaced narrative in the video works discussed.

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In Lieu of a Conclusion

Video art had a highly elusive character from the outset, but has also evolved strongly as an artform in the five decades of its existence. This transformation gave rise to exciting changes notably in its relationships with other media. These two concerns served as the starting point for my study. Departing from visual analysis of video artworks, statements by video artists, and scholarly work on video art, I have sought to demonstrate how video art "works" on the basis of a comparative media approach. Through a selection of case studies from different periods over the past fifty years, I investigated how technical developments and cultural contexts reshaped this medium and changed its ties to other media, without intending to write a strictly historical survey of these changes.

It was clear to me from the start that it is impossible to capture video art in a single, all-inclusive definition. In the four chapters I have therefore tried to establish that rather than searching for medium-specificity or a general theory, it is more useful to develop a theoretical framework for research into video art. As such this study is meant to underscore the usefulness and merits of the comparative media approach as a way to gain a better understanding of how video art "works." The method of research developed in this volume is grounded in a comparative focus on obvious features and characteristics of a (selection of) video work(s) – such as immediacy, immateriality, spatiality, slowness, repetition, fragmentation, or electronic nature – or the specific function or purpose

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pursued in these works, such as to serve as *aide-mémoire*, social document, mass media critique, or autonomous artwork. If these qualities are hardly medium-specific, they are interesting as focal points for comparison with how other media deal with these same features, characteristics, or functions. As my case studies revealed, this method of research can provide insights into the consequences or implications of a particular application of these characteristics and references to other media for the construction of meanings. The key works foregrounded in my case studies, which were selected on the basis of their self-reflexive qualities and their challenge to other visual media, proved useful not only as objects of research but also as catalysts for theoretical reflections on comparisons of media.

The case studies also confirmed that the expectations of spectators toward a medium, based on their former experiences with that same medium or other media, play an important role in the comparative media approach. Many video artworks challenge these conventions and make viewers aware of their preconceived notions and prejudices. Thus these artworks accomplish two things for us: they critically examine not only video's own mediation, but also the common language of television, photography, and cinema that we all deal with on a daily basis. Quite a few of the best video works precisely interrogate this common language in media or they are devoted to exploring particular media conventions or familiar stereotypes. In the first chapter I discussed video works that critically questioned clichés associated with television, in the third chapter I concentrated on clichés in news and portrait photographs, and the works discussed in the fourth chapter highlighted clichés in conventional cinema.

Because video is everywhere in our daily life (for instance in public space as advertisements or surveillance, and at home on television and the internet), while many works of video art tend to reflect upon these practices, I supplemented my comparative media approach with several interdisciplinary theoretical frameworks, including concepts and theories from media studies, cultural studies, psychology, and philosophy. Moreover, regarding video's function as an artistic medium, it proved productive to also borrow from particular art-historical perspectives, be it theories on installation art, performance art, painting, drawing, and photography, or specific exhibition practices.

The case studies in the four chapters of this study were primarily designed to demonstrate the kinds of insights that the perspective adopted provides into how video art "works." The first chapter zoomed in on immediacy

as an oft-mentioned characteristic of video and argues that video art cannot be studied apart from television as the origin and sparring partner of many early video artworks. Television studies and cultural studies proved to be useful not only for understanding how critical early video artworks such as those by Rosler and Jonas deal with gender issues or tensions between private and public, but also for gaining insights into more recent work by Wearing, which reflects on topical television issues such as "confessions." As a feature, video art shares immediacy with performance art as well, but in relationship to this artistic medium video appears to be in particular a tool for self-reflection (pertaining to either the artist, the audience, or the medium). All case studies, however, demonstrated that video's immediacy is linked up with directly addressing the spectator. By the same token, quite different insights were generated by a focus on video's nature of recording for memory, where we entered into relationships with the diary as a medium and photo and film documentaries. In this context, video, in particular as an easy tool for recording, with its ability to be erased, overwritten, and distorted, appeared to be meaningful in its similarity to how our memory operates.

The seemingly opposite characteristics of video regarding time – its immediacy and its role in our memory of the past – that were at the center of Chapter 1 were echoed in the two seemingly contradictory features of video regarding space in Chapter 2: immateriality and three-dimensionality. Art-historical theories on installation art turned out to be particularly useful for understanding how the different forms of spatiality of video installations, in combination with the use of sound, interact with the visitor and contribute to generating meanings. This led us to the conclusion, for instance, that video installations have a more complex character than installation art, in which physical environments are created to be entered by the visitor. The video installations discussed in this chapter relate to the physical space of the spectator in many different ways – through TV sets, additional objects, spatial screens, cameras, projectors, architecture as support, or physical presence of the artist – while at the same time they present virtual spaces through immaterial images and sound, which can be said to add a further and other experience of space. The method of research applied generated new insights, for instance, into how Neshat's installation produced meanings in relation to gender issues in private and public life in Iran, or into how Hershman's installation shows what it means that we are not just living in a physical place anymore, but constantly have to behave in a complex and often confusing network of physical and virtual places.

The main question in Chapter 3 focused on how modes of representation in the selected video works relate and react to such modes in photography, painting, and drawing: how do views on representation implied in these various media provide insights into video art? The case studies in this chapter – which could be categorized as painting-like video, photograph-like video, or drawing-related video (or a combination of them) – all appear to focus on a fixed frame, a flat image, a visual experience (rather than sound), and a strong reduction of movement to facilitate contemplation. Rather than moving images, the videos analyzed seem more like a photograph, a drawing, or a painting, to which a minimal temporal dimension was added. This nominal sense of duration, however, proved crucial in generating meanings: creating a pensive spectator on posing and decontextualization in photography, on paintings as mental constructions in which twofold-ness is exploited, and on drawing as ongoing process. Particularly in the works by Jürss, Chiurai, and Farocki the representation of another medium prompts the spectator to reflect on issues of representation in the mass media we have to deal with in everyday life.

If in the first chapter I addressed the temporal aspects of immediacy and remembrance, the fourth chapter deals with time through focusing on repetition. My case studies served to demonstrate how specific insights about narrative theory from film studies and Hollywood conventions can enhance our understanding of the video artworks discussed. The video works by Breitz, Graham, and Cytter rely on fragmentation and in particular repetition in various ways – such as duplication, recurrence, looping, and slight modification – as strategies to isolate, caricaturize, or invert characteristics of classical cinema.

Repetition proved to be not only an interesting formal aspect of video art, and even serves as the most frequently observed video art strategy in this textbook, but is also used as a metaphor for people's inclination to compulsive or almost ritual behavior in daily life. This observation can be extended to my experience with the comparative media approach in general. This method of research might be criticized for being too restricted to formal analysis. Yet while various kinds of disturbances, systems of mirroring, and immediate feedback (in closed circuits) etc. could be considered as only formal or technical characteristics, the case studies demonstrate that these also often appear to function as metaphors for how we deal with ourselves and the world around us, and how others deal with us.

Because of the chameleonic nature of video, it is probably the most suitable medium for comparative media research. The comparative approach allows us not only to increase our understanding of how video art "works," but also to gain fresh perspectives on the functioning of the other media explored or interrogated through video. Although this second aspect was initially beyond the scope of the research for this study, as a line of inquiry it certainly opens up possibilities for new and more sustained research projects. Moreover, while the study of video art in the context of the history of Western modern art cannot do full justice to non-Western video art, the comparative media approach – with its focus on aspects of time, space, representation, and narrative – may also break fresh ground when it comes to developing alternative ways of relating video works from different cultural contexts to each other, as well as to exploring different views on time, space, representation, and narrative within various cultures in their mutual interaction.

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